

Your Wealth, Your Legacy

# Decidedly Wealthy



5 Key Decisions to Transform  
Wealth to Significance

SANGER D. SMITH  
SHAWN D. SMITH

## Decidedly Wealthy

Copyright © 2025 Sanger Smith and Shawn Smith

ISBN: 978-1-955362-32-0

All rights reserved. No portion of this book may be reproduced in any form without permission from the publisher, except as permitted by U.S. copyright law. Although both the publisher and author have used reasonable care in preparing this book, the information it contains is distributed “as is” and without warranties of any kind. This book is not intended as legal, financial, or health advice, and not all of the recommendations will be suitable for your situation. Professional legal, financial, and health advisors should be consulted as needed. Neither the publisher nor the author shall be liable for any costs, expenses, or damages resulting from the use of or reliance on the information contained in this book.

Published by Story Chorus ([www.storychorus.com](http://www.storychorus.com))

**STORY  CHORUS**

# Dedication

*To those stepping on  
the unfamiliar trail to a transformational  
journey of their dreams.*



# Table of Contents

|                                                       |            |
|-------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| <i>Prelude</i>                                        | <i>vii</i> |
| <i>Introduction</i>                                   | <i>xi</i>  |
| <br>                                                  |            |
| <b>KEY DECISION 1</b>                                 |            |
| <b>Decide Who You Are</b>                             | <b>1</b>   |
| Chapter 1: What Is Important About Your Wealth?       | 3          |
| Chapter 2: What Do You Want Your Money to Do for You? | 19         |
| Chapter 3: What Is Your Relationship with Money?      | 35         |
| Chapter 4: What Matters to You?                       | 49         |
| Chapter 5: What Are Your Core Values?                 | 59         |
| <br>                                                  |            |
| <b>KEY DECISION 2</b>                                 |            |
| <b>Decide Where You Are</b>                           | <b>73</b>  |
| Chapter 6: Your Starting Point and Money Habits       | 75         |
| Chapter 7: What Is Your Cash Flow?                    | 89         |

**KEY DECISION 3**

**Decide Where You Are Going 99**

Chapter 8: What Is Your Primary Goal? 101

Chapter 9: Retiring *to* Something 111

Chapter 10: What Are Your Aspirational Goals? 119

Chapter 11: The Freedom to Pursue Significance 129

**KEY DECISION 4**

**Decide How You Are Going to Get There 145**

Chapter 12: How Heavy Is Your Pack? 147

Chapter 13: Who Is with You? 159

Chapter 14: Are You on Your Own Path? 171

**KEY DECISION 5**

**Decide Who Matters 187**

Chapter 15: Did You Leave a Trace? 189

Chapter 16: What Is Your Legacy? 201

Chapter 17: Passing Down More Than Wealth 209

*Conclusion 219*

*About the Authors 221*

# Prelude

## **Day 0. Morning.**

On March 21st, I crossed the hall into my dad's office. The room always carried a certain type of energy, but that morning it was charged with something different. His office was special, not for its financial influence, but for the impact it had on its clients. It was special because of what it represented.

My father always kept the space pristine. The office—large as a living room—had no trash can. Even garbage tucked away in a corner, he believed, would corrupt the professionalism of the environment. Every detail was a decision made with purpose.

His private bathroom? A decision to shave minutes off his day, minimizing disruption. The black granite table paired with his Montblanc pen? A decision to present authority, its weight commanding clients to sit straighter when they joined him. The leather sofa by the fireplace? A decision to foster long after-work conversations that shaped lives.

And the bookcase filled with family photos? Each picture was from a trip with only one of us kids or my mother. This was a decision to remind himself and others who mattered most.

But what made the room special was the large wooden box resting almost unnoticed on the glass coffee table. Hundreds of

clients, employees, and friends had been in that office. No one ever asked about it.

A few weeks earlier, my dad had shown me. Inside were decades of thank-you notes—letters from clients who wanted him to know the impact he'd made.

*When we first started working together, I was only 26.  
Now I'm 56 and retired while my friends are not. Thank you  
for your wisdom.*

—David

*As we move into uncharted waters with Cliff's Alzheimer's, we are  
thankful for the foundation you helped us build. If we hadn't  
traveled when you told us to, we may never have had the chance.*

—Beth

*I believe that because God led us to you several years ago,  
you were part of the healing of our little family.*

—Katherine

Each note echoed the same theme: gratitude for his guidance in life-shaping decisions. That struck me, because the day I stood in his office, my father himself was in the middle of one of the most significant decisions of his life.

He didn't look the part. Instead of khakis and a sport coat, he wore hiking boots, shorts, a t-shirt, and a ball cap. Beside him, a stuffed Osprey backpack sat ready. On the table lay folders of legal paperwork. He motioned me over.

"Sanger, come here. Let's go. We can't be here all day."

Sliding his Montblanc pen toward me, he asked—half joking, half not—“Are you sure you want to do this?”

We laughed, but my chest tightened. I picked up the heavy pen and looked down at the papers, I was the most *sure* and most *unsure* I’d ever been. On the paper, more zeroes than I could count stared back. I was about to acquire more debt than I’d ever imagined. For him, this was a lifetime of progress. For me, it was the beginning.

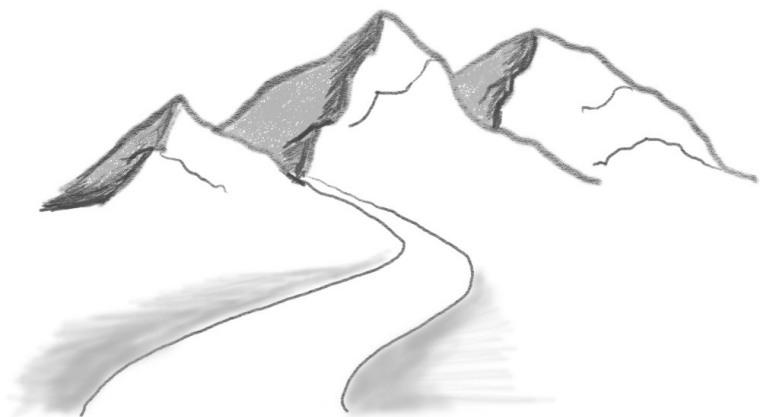
The day my father was selling his business. I was buying my first. Later he told me about his experience: “Although I’d already decided, there was still a finality to it all. A big part of my life was now in the past. The money didn’t seem real. I didn’t feel richer. I was in transition, like stepping off a boat onto a dock. There was loss, but also freedom. Once the paperwork was out of the way, I could move forward with a clean slate and a clear head.”

And move forward is exactly what he did. Within hours of signing, we drove to the airport. We entered through the DFW departure terminal’s automatic doors with only backpacks on our shoulders. He was setting out on a three-month-long trek along the Pacific Crest Trail, and I would join him for the first week. He would “celebrate” selling his business by sleeping on the ground and walking alone for fifteen hours a day.

Unusual? Yes. But I respected it. It was bold.

Together we flew to San Diego, drove to Campo, touched the border wall, and began walking north. That’s where our conversations began—the first steps of his journey to discover purpose beyond business, and the first steps of my own journey to learn how great decisions are made.

This is that story.



# Introduction

I grew up with two fathers. Not because of divorce or a stepfather—but because the man who raised me changed dramatically in the summer of 2014. He became a new person.

For decades, my dad poured himself into building a financial advisory practice in North Texas. He started with nothing—no investors, no inheritance, no safety net. Seeking clients, he went through dumpsters outside other advisors' offices, looking for names and phone numbers they had thrown away. He spent long days driving through unfamiliar neighborhoods in the Texas heat with no air conditioning, knocking on doors with nothing more than hope and determination.

When he started his business in the early 1990s, half of new advisors would leave the industry within a year. By year three, nine out of ten had quit the financial field for good. My dad refused to be one of them. Through grit and persistence, he went from dumpster diving for contacts to managing over half a billion dollars. By the time I was grown, he led three offices, employed twenty people, and was named among the nation's top advisors by *Barron's*, *Forbes*, and *The Financial Times*.

From the outside, it looked like success. On the inside, the cost was high. As a child, I rarely saw him. He left before I woke up and

often returned after my sisters and I were asleep. His reward for relentless *doing* was finding more to do. He was celebrated for his drive, his production, his growth. But what he didn't realize until much later was that he had neglected something essential: being.

We are human beings, after all, not human doings.

After the summer of 2014, he had gained a quiet confidence that only comes from a recognition of what matters and the knowledge of what decisions need to be made to achieve it. That transformation and new knowledge became the basis for the Decidedly Wealth framework.

## AIR DOES NOT HAVE AN EGO

My favorite American poet, Buddy Wakefield, wrote in *A Choir of Honest Killers*:

“Air does not have an ego.

Pay attention, then, when it enters and exits.”<sup>1</sup>

The summer of my twentieth birthday, my dad finally paused to pay attention.

He took two months away from the office—no client meetings, no emails, no checking in on the staff—and walked five-hundred miles across northern Spain on the Camino de Santiago, a Christian pilgrimage that has drawn travelers for centuries.

When he returned, he was different. The man who once measured life in meetings and deadlines now carried a

---

<sup>1</sup> Buddy Wakefield, *A Choir of Honest Killers* (Write Bloody Publishing, 2019).

calmer patience. Things that once made him irritable no longer seemed worth his attention. He was wiser. He had paid attention to his breath, his being.

That's why, years later, it wasn't surprising that the day after he sold his business to me, he left again—this time for a thousand-mile backpacking trip along the Pacific Crest Trail (PCT). He wanted another experience that would strip away the noise of doing and force growth in the silence of being.

### **Day 1. Morning.**

As we started north from the US–Mexico border with heavy packs on our shoulders, I asked him, “What made you decide to walk the Camino?”

He replied, “I wanted the challenge of being on an unfamiliar trail in a foreign country where I didn't speak the language. But more than that, I wanted growth. Experiences like that force growth upon you in a way books and conferences never can.”

“And how did you actually decide to go?” I asked. “A lot of people want change. Few act on it.”

He paused. “The moment I decided gave me a unique rush, almost like relief. Thinking about something and deciding to do it are two very different things. Once I decided, I knew I wasn't going to back out. It was like asking your mom to marry me—there was a day, a time, a commitment. These three things made it real.”

That's when I understood: The most critical moments in our lives are the short, fleeting spaces between stimulus and response—between thinking about something and deciding to do it. That's the gap where our future is written.

## DECIDE TO DECIDE

When we truly decide, the decision comes with action. A date gets circled on the calendar. Without that, it's not a decision—it's a wish.

In our work with clients, my dad and I noticed three outcomes whenever someone is at a crossroads:

1. **Deciding to Act:** A clear yes, followed by concrete next steps. Even if the first step is small—like meeting with an advisor—you know what comes next.
2. **Deciding Not to Act:** This is a clear no. As my dad's career grew, he became better at this. He learned to *decide to fail* at certain things so he could succeed at others.
3. **Not Deciding to Act:** This is the dangerous default. You tell yourself you're still deciding, but time and passivity are making the choice for you.

Of these, the last is the most common—and the most costly. A passive approach to life removes your agency over your experiences. A passive approach to money removes your agency over your wealth.

## THE DECIDEDLY WEALTHY MINDSET

Money itself is neutral. It is simply a tool—a way to accomplish goals, help others, enact change, and express your values. When understood properly, it can create a more fulfilling life and a lasting legacy.

But when wealth without purpose slips away. It simply gets left over when we die. It drifts to fund someone else's dreams. To transform wealth to significance, you must choose intentionally.

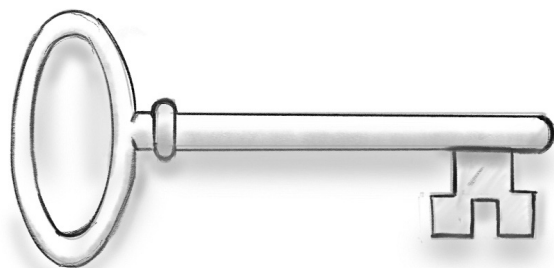
For us, that choice is rooted in faith: We believe we've been entrusted by God to steward wealth for His glory. For you, the "why" may look different. Whatever it is, it must be bigger than accumulation.

Being Decidedly Wealthy means using your financial resources with clear intention and purpose. Those who are Decidedly Wealthy see money as a tool to live out their bigger purpose. Their relationship with money advances their achievement of significance in the lives of others—the lives of those they touch through their time, talent, and treasure.

This book is about the Five Key Decisions you must make. They are as follows:

1. **Decide Who You Are:** Understand your values and what drives you to make decisions.
2. **Decide Where You Are:** Become as self-aware as possible so you can be honest about your decisions.
3. **Decide Where You Are Going:** Set clear, purposeful destinations.
4. **Decide How You Are Going to Get There:** Create your roadmap.
5. **Decide Who Matters:** Identify who and what deserves your treasure.

These Five Key Decisions are the difference between having money that merely funds a lifestyle and having money that achieves significance and fuels a legacy.



## FINDING SIGNIFICANCE

The subtitle of this book is *5 Key Decisions to Transform Wealth to Significance*. Significance means putting your wealth toward your highest purpose, aligned with your deepest values. As one of our Decidedly podcast guests, Natalia Matveeva, a Chernobyl survivor, put it: “Your values are a gift from God.”<sup>2</sup> This is why significance lies in transferring not only dollars, but ideals.

Plenty of people achieve wealth without significance. But history is clear: after a couple of generations, that kind of wealth rarely remains. Without values attached, it’s spent, squandered, or redirected. Significance, on the other hand, echoes. It shapes families, communities, and institutions long after you’re gone.

Being Decidedly Wealthy means knowing what worthy purpose you want your wealth to do for you—and then choosing to make that happen. The good news is that you’ve already accomplished the first step. You picked up this book. You decided that your wealth should mean more.

And that’s where our journey begins.

---

<sup>2</sup>Sanger Smith, Shawn Smith, Decidedly Podcast, episode 34, “Natalia Matveeva | Deciding to Return to Chernobyl: A Survivor’s Values-Based Journey,” [April 28, 2022] [<https://open.spotify.com/episode/6MXLZUKeg5E3kMGyxQBA8?si=c5db2669774c4c80>].

KEY DECISION 1

# Decide Who You Are





## CHAPTER 1

# What Is Important About Your Wealth?

### **Day 1. Afternoon.**

It was colder than I expected a desert to be. To my surprise, a sharp wind still cut through my thick beanie. Against better judgment, I walked along the rugged trail with my hands in my pockets. Although wool gloves covered my palms, they were fingerless, and my knuckles hated me for that. I felt silly packing winter gear to go hiking through southern California in the spring, but on this day, I wished I had been more prepared for Mother Nature's unpredictability.

My father stayed five paces ahead of me all day. This was standard because I had followed him my whole life. Even though I am thirty years younger and spryer, I had a tough time keeping up. My pride would not allow me to ask him to slow down. I kept pushing forward despite the ache in my thighs. This was my punishment for not training with him back home on the weekends.

I foolishly thought backpacking 109 miles through the desert would be a cakewalk, but my dad was wiser than that. He was determined not to let fitness interfere with starting this important journey. He'd spent the past eleven months preparing for this day

physically, mentally, and emotionally. Two days ago, we were in his office signing the end of a different journey. Cardio did not matter then.

It was a monumental moment for both of us, and it marked the end of his time as a business owner. It was a journey that spanned the entirety of his adult life; a journey that started before I was born. Two days ago marked the moment I followed in his footsteps both literally and figuratively—not only along the Pacific Crest Trail, but in his career.

I, along with my business partners at the time, purchased the company from him. Suddenly, there were many responsibilities that called for my attention. Just as suddenly, my dad had no one calling for him. Instead of burying myself in work, I joined him for the first week of his thousand-mile hike along the West Coast. Even though my hike would be much shorter than his, I knew I was not ready. I hadn't put the same time into preparing as my dad did.

For the last several months, I'd frequently seen my dad walk ten miles from his house to downtown Fort Worth and back with a thirty-pound dumbbell in his pack. His Saturdays were devoted to preparing the logistics. He knew where to find water and how to filter it, which towns were optimal for resupplying, and where post offices had his scheduled resupply boxes. A laminated spreadsheet went with him on every hike, detailing his planned stops, coordinates for camping, and daily mileage.

Day one was ambitious. He had planned a twenty-mile hike from the US—Mexico border wall near Campo, California to Lake Morena. The allure of Lake Morena was the small convenience store a stone's throw from the water. This pit stop was rumored to have the “best burger on the trail” by many—albeit not a high bar for a remote trail through the wilderness. The promise of a juicy burger

kept me moving when I desperately wanted to lie down. To distract myself from the discomfort of a backpack that did not quite fit and hiking shoes that were not yet broken in, I started interrogating my father. I was determined to learn everything I could from him while I had the benefit of a distraction-free environment. To add to it, there was nothing he could do to avoid my questioning. He'd built a successful career as a financial advisor, and I wanted to replicate that success. I hoped it would ease my anxiety about returning home. As much as I wanted to stop walking, I was not looking forward to returning home where I would be left alone to figure things out.

I was determined to use our time together to learn how to run the business and how to help others along their own financial journey. I wasn't about to miss this opportunity. Avoiding the subject of my sunburn and blisters, I asked my father: "What makes those who are financially successful different?"

It would be difficult to answer this deceptively simple question succinctly. I knew that, though. By this point, I had spent eight years working inside my father's company. I knew enough to recognize that the answer is not investments alone. In my senior year of college, I made my spending money by tutoring classmates in my investment planning course while getting an A myself without ever opening the textbook. I was no Warren Buffet, but I knew what I was talking about. I knew enough about wealth management at the time to recognize that the question I asked my father would provide me with several miles worth of distraction. There is no magic answer to why some people seem to have it all. That is what puzzled me about his response.

"Decision making," he said, without even spending two strides to ponder the topic.

“Yeah, yeah, yeah.” I nodded in agreement. Yet I failed to recognize the hidden complexity of what appeared to be a flippant, obvious answer. I continued, “But like...what do wealthy people do differently?”

“You don’t understand,” my father responded. He shattered my ego without a hint of judgment in the way only a father can do. “That *is* what they do differently. Decision-making is the foundation of success. Our life is the accumulation of the decisions we make and how we deal with the consequences. Most wealthy people don’t inherit their wealth; they build it. If it falls apart, they rebuild it. They’re able to build and rebuild it because they make better decisions. The best long-term investment decisions are not made by the smartest people, but by the best decision makers. Decision-making is the most important thing we have 100 percent control of. And our life goes in the direction of our decision-making.”

I knew there was more waiting for me behind these words. But my embarrassingly sluggish pace positioned us about three miles from Lake Morena by the time the sun was setting. “Let’s camp here,” my father suggested, eyeing a rare flat space where two tents could fit.

I became disinterested in our conversation and more intrigued by the idea of stuffing Ramen noodles down my throat and chugging the heavy water I had been carrying all day. I dropped my backpack from my shoulders because its straps felt like barbed wire. Then I stared at the dirt for a moment, hoping to catch my breath, and reveled in the newfound calm.

“You’d better put your tent up before it gets dark!” my father hollered from beside his already assembled tent.

That night, sleep eluded me for hours. I replayed my father's words in my mind. I stared upward at the inside of my green tent as it flapped in the wind. Decision making... *It can't be that simple, can it?* I thought to myself as coyotes howled in the distance. I understood my father wasn't saying certain choices guaranteed success. After all, bad decisions sometimes work out by pure luck, while good decisions can fail because of unfortunate timing. I knew better than to assume that the quality of a decision was solely based on its outcome.

Carl Icahn's \$20 billion net worth proves he doesn't base every investment decision on short-term stock fluctuations. If Bill Belichick spent his Monday mornings evaluating play calls by counting the

---

Consistently making great decisions over  
a lifetime matters more than what you  
decide to do once.

---

number of yards gained, he would not have won enough Super Bowl rings to cover both his hands. Sometimes we make the right call given the circumstances and things still do not work out. I have seen people make excellent decisions and still get hit with bad financial luck or unfortunate family circumstances. That does not mean their decision-making framework is broken. Outlier results are not enough on their own to give credence to nor cast doubt upon a strategy.

Building wealth is not the result of one choice. It results from thousands of choices made over years, even decades. Consistently making great decisions over a lifetime matters more than what

you decide to do once. After counting more sheep than Abraham herded in his life, I figured out my next question for tomorrow:

“What decisions do successful people make?”

Setting my agenda for the next day gave me the perfect distraction from worrying about the miles of hiking ahead and gave me permission to close my eyes.

## Day 2. Morning.

We woke before the sun. Hard ground and whistling wind made an alarm clock unnecessary. We packed our things in silence and hiked toward Lake Morena before morning light. There was no relaxing morning coffee; we had to make up for lost time. We spent the first mile or so in silence. Talking is not as enjoyable when it is cold enough to see your breath. By the time I could feel the warmth of the sun, I spoke what was on my mind.

“Yesterday you said that decision-making is what makes people successful. What decisions do they make?” I asked.

“First, before doing anything else,” my dad said, “they must decide who they are.”

*What kind of hippie nonsense is my dad talking about right now?* I thought, too confused to formulate a response at the moment. *Decide Who You Are*—what does that even mean? You are who you are. There is nothing to be decided. We do not get to choose—we just *are*. I wrestled internally with his answer for a few hundred yards before he interrupted my thinking.

“There’s the burger place!” my dad exclaimed. He pointed just over a hill at a small white building off in the distance. For the next half hour, we described our burger orders in perfect detail to one another.

“Gah, I hope they have bacon,” I prayed out loud.

“I’m getting a double-double, I don’t know about you,” my dad said, quickening his pace.

We debated the merits of chili on a burger, and whether jalapeños should be fresh or grilled. Finally, we arrived. We stepped into the old, grimy, nondescript convenience store we had spent the last day and a half dreaming about. To the normal passerby, it’s an unremarkable place. To a hiker, it’s heaven.

We each gave our orders to the cook in the exact detail we had spent the last half hour perfecting along the trail. After this, we sat down in a rickety, almost-clean booth near the large glass window at the front of the store. As my dad brought the burgers back to our table, I noticed a man outside the window. He was dirty and clearly had not showered in several days. In any other scenario, I would assume the man was homeless. However, he had a backpack that looked a lot like mine. He was a fellow hiker. He had long, ratty, curly hair sticking out from underneath a red bandana tied around his forehead. I mentally dubbed him Bandana Man.

“Hey, man, can I get uhm—do you have uh... I think I want a-a-a burger...yeah!” The Bandana Man stammered to the cook who was standing underneath a large wooden sign painted red with the letters B-U-R-G-E-R-S.

After placing his order, the Bandana Man turned around to see my dad and me sitting down, burgers in hand, staring suspiciously right back at him.

“Oh, duuuuude,” Bandana Man bellowed with a smile.  
“You guys got burgers too! Rad!”

Knowing we could not avoid an interaction, my dad attempted to engage in conversation by asking the obvious question,  
“So, are you a hiker?”

“Yeah, man, my buddy and I are out here. It’s been so cool!”

“Glad to hear it,” my father responded with his right hand outstretched in front of him, greeting the man. “I’m Shawn and this is Sanger. What’s your name?”

Bandana Man did not reply. His eyes dropped to the ground as if he were searching for the answer to the simplest question anyone can answer.

Another man, who was in the middle of placing his order at the counter, turned around to look at us. “He’s Puff and I’m Kushy.”

“Yeah, yeah, yeah. Puff! Anyway, nice to meet ya guys,” Puff interjected.

These were clearly not the names given to them by their mothers. Along the PCT, hikers seldom go by their legal names, or even nicknames they had back home. Hikers leave the burden of the past behind when they are bestowed a “trail name” by their fellow hikers. A trail name is the name you assume in order to be reborn on the trail.

The most dedicated hikers—those who embrace not only the physical hike, but the spiritual and emotional journey as well—do not answer to their old labels. For any thru-hiker of the PCT, the trail name is an essential aspect of the experience. Neither my dad nor I had yet earned a trail name. Rule number one of trail names is that another hiker must give them to you. We were only on day two, after all.

“So, Puff,” I asked, “how far are y’all planning to hike the rest of today?” I wondered if we would have the pleasure of Puff’s company at the night’s campsite.

“Man, I don’t know. However far we get, I guess.”

“Are y’all on day one or two?” I asked, trying to make some small talk.

Again, Puff appeared to be utterly confused by the question. I figured maybe if I reworded it, I would have better luck.

“Are y’all on your first or second day hiking?” I asked again. I hoped they had not made it this far in a single day. Part of me was seeking validation that I was not the least capable hiker on the trail.

Puff again responded as if he had been asked to find the square root of the color magenta. “Dang, man, I guess like three or four days probably.”

My dad and I both looked at each other in amazement. The trail only spanned twenty miles from the starting point to the burger joint. The vast majority of hikers trekked that distance on their first day. We felt embarrassed because it took us two days to get there. Further, even if Puff and Kushy were slower hikers, how could anyone forget how long they had been hiking when they could still count the days on one hand?

After lunch, my dad broke the silence by saying, “That is what I mean. That guy back there was lost.”

“Because he hadn’t decided who he was?” I asked, puzzled.

“Exactly!” my dad responded enthusiastically. “He didn’t even know how long he had been on the trail, for crying out loud! He didn’t know who he was, where he was, or where he was going. You don’t see that with people who have transformed their wealth to significance and make great money decisions.”

## HOW TO DECIDE WHO YOU ARE

Just like Puff, many of us are lost in our lives. Worse, we might not even recognize it. We realize we lack direction only when someone asks us about it, or when we become self-aware enough to question ourselves. Like Puff, sometimes we may respond in confusion—which

is especially true when it comes to our wealth. Most of us have not been asked deep, thought-provoking questions. Even a coworker asking if you contribute to the 401(k) plan is taboo, and it's also taboo for a neighbor to ask if you've paid off your house. Those questions rarely come up, much less the deeper questions about our money.

Financial advisors are not surprised when people don't understand their financial situation. You may wonder, "But what does that even mean?" It starts first with understanding what is truly important to you about your wealth. If we had asked Puff why he was on the PCT, he would not have answered. After all, he could not answer any other question definitively either.

When asked this question, "What is important about your wealth?", many people reflexively, or perhaps defensively, answer that they "want more of it." This is often our gut reaction because thinking about money introspectively is difficult. Introspection itself is a learned skill, and it becomes even harder when society treats certain topics—like money—as taboo and off-limits for discussion. The shame of it is that the very people who lack the self-awareness to be introspective never know they lack the skill of self-awareness, for that very reason. That's why my father made a point of asking his clients penetrating questions we rarely would ask ourselves: "What's important about my money?"

When my father started his career, he read *Values-Based Selling* by Bill Backrach. It changed how he approached interactions with clients. The book taught him to focus on what his clients *thought* was important to them. Most of them, he learned, did not know. Building the skill to dig deeper and help them find out became crucial. Bachrach's key question became central to his practice: "What is important about your wealth?" A deceptively simple question, but one that requires a thoughtful answer.

## What Is Important About Your Wealth?

What is important about your wealth to you? Is it simply possessing it? Well, then what makes possessing it so important? You may be reluctant to give a thorough answer because it seems self-evident. After having thousands of money conversations, we have learned quite the opposite. Each answer is unique and individualized, just like you and your family. There is no right answer to the question—but there is a final answer. Dig deep to find your true answer and then keep digging until you cannot dig any more.

Is your wealth important so that your family has enough? What makes your family having enough money important to you? Ask yourself these questions and write your answers. Study them. If you said (your original answer) is what is important, then ask what makes (your original answer) important to you. Seriously, write it out even if it seems obvious to you.

Chances are it will be the first time you have articulated the importance of your wealth this thoroughly. Then ask yourself what makes that second answer important to you. Keep going until it feels silly, then push past that point. Keep going until the questioning loops back to the same answer. Keep going until your answer is the single most important thing you can name, and nothing is more important to you than that!

Many times, people answer that their wealth is important for what it can do for others. For example, if you said your wealth matters because you want to provide for your spouse, avoid burdening others, or pay for your children's education, you still haven't reached the core reason.

What makes being able to provide those things important to you? If you get stuck, imagine that you have arrived at a place where your original answer to the question has already happened. What is important to you about arriving at that space? For example,

sometimes people tell us they want to have enough money to care for their kids. We ask them, “Imagine you already have that money. What is important about knowing you have enough?” They pause and what pours forth comes from their deepest inner beliefs and fears. They share things they have never revealed—even to themselves.

## FINDING YOUR TRAIL NAME

My father spent eleven months building a foundation for his thousand-mile journey. This is how successful people prepare for their financial journey—by first understanding who they are and what matters to them. Without this foundation, we risk becoming like Puff, wandering through life without knowing how long we’ve been on the trail, where we’re headed, or even our own name.

The exercise of discovering what’s important about your wealth isn’t just philosophical meandering. It’s a laminated spreadsheet for your financial journey. It has the coordinates for where you’ll camp and the map that keeps you moving forward when the trail gets steep and your feet blister. My father didn’t just pack a thirty-pound dumbbell and walk twenty miles a day to prepare his body—he prepared his mind by knowing exactly why he was taking this journey.

As I continued walking, I realized my father had given me something more valuable than investment advice or business strategies. He’d shown me that before you can build wealth, rebuild it, or transform it into something significant, you must first *Decide Who You Are*. You must dig deep enough to find what drives you—deeper than the surface answers, deeper than what sounds good to others, to your core.

## What Is Important About Your Wealth?

The trail ahead was still long. I had many more miles to walk with my father, many more questions to ask. But now I understood that this journey—both on the PCT and in taking over his business—wasn't about following in his footsteps. It was about discovering my trail name, my own reasons for walking, my answer to what makes it all important.

By the way, the burger was worth the wait. And yes, they had bacon.

## ACTION STEPS

### **Step 1: Set the Stage**

Find a quiet space with ten to fifteen minutes of uninterrupted time. Get a pen and paper—this exercise works best when you physically write your answers rather than type them.

### **Step 2: Start with the Core Question**

Write at the top of your page: “What is important about my wealth to me?”

Answer honestly. Don’t write what sounds good or what you think you should say. Write what’s true for you.

### **Step 3: Dig Deeper, Five Layers Down**

Look at your answer from Step 2 and ask: “What is important about [that answer] to me?”

Write your response. Then repeat this process at least five times, each time asking what makes your previous answer important to you. The key is that this is about you. If you answered something that points to helping others, then what about that is important to you? Push through when it feels silly or redundant—that’s often when you’re about to break through to something meaningful.

### **Step 4: Test Your Final Answer**

You’ll know you’ve reached your core value when:

- Your answer loops back on itself
- Nothing feels more important than what you’ve written

## What Is Important About Your Wealth?

- The answer feels both deeply personal and universally true to you
- You get emotional or feel a strong resonance with the words

### **Step 5: Create Your “Trail Name”**

Summarize your final answer in three to five words. Like Puff’s trail name on the PCT, this becomes shorthand for your deeper purpose. This becomes your financial “trail name”—the core identity that will guide your money decisions going forward. Write it somewhere you’ll see it regularly.



## CHAPTER 2

# What Do You Want Your Money to Do for You?

### **Day 2. Afternoon.**

“Before doing anything,” my dad said, as we walked toward camp, the violet dusk coloring the PCT, “you need to know what you hope to gain from it.”

After a couple of miles of hiking, the burgers my dad and I had stuffed down at Lake Morena were no longer sitting like kettlebells in our stomachs. We were back to walking at a respectable pace and on track to reach the campground by nightfall. This was a real campground, meaning it was not a flat piece of dirt like where we stayed on the first night. It had a parking lot for families to drive their trucks and trailers up to, a faucet with clean water, and even a restroom! That was heaven. Even the dirtiest gas station bathroom seemed much more civilized and dignified than holding onto a tree branch for balance.

As we walked along the rocky trail, dusk crept upon us slowly, turning the sky shades of violet and fire only Monet could capture. I could almost taste the packet of tuna waiting for me in

my food bag. Almost anything sounds appealing after fifteen miles of hiking with thirty pounds strapped to your back. Lost in thought, I was deciding whether I should eat another granola bar for dinner. I suddenly remembered the promise I had made to myself the day before. I would not lose this opportunity to learn!

“Hey, Dad,” I called out, watching my step to avoid loose rocks. “You mentioned yesterday that you walked the Camino for a transformational experience. That must be why we’re doing this, right?”

“You’re right, it is,” he responded, seeming somewhat disgruntled at the interruption of his own daydreams of dinner menu preparation.

“I want to hear more about that,” I said, giving myself permission not to spend all evening preparing the perfect question only to forget about it later.

My dad tightened the shoulder straps on his backpack as we started downhill with the campsite now in view. He glanced back over his shoulder to make sure I could hear his voice over the sound of rocks clattering beneath our feet.

“Well...anytime you are going to do anything,” he said, “you have to know what you want it to do for you.” He paused, looking out at the landscape.

“I wanted to be able to reflect thoughtfully upon my life and the decisions I had made. I wanted to be able to consider my future. I wanted a transformative experience. I wanted to grow as a person, as a man. That’s what made it an easy decision to sacrifice the time and money to go on the Camino. That’s also what made it an easy decision to come here now.”

His clarity was absolute. He wasn’t walking five hundred miles across Spain or a thousand miles through California just to say

he'd done it. He had defined exactly what he wanted these experiences to provide: transformation, reflection, growth. That clarity made every sacrifice—time away from family, physical discomfort, lost income—worthwhile. Without that clarity, he might have quit on day three when his feet were screaming or day seven when the loneliness set in.

## THE BRIDGE FROM EXPERIENCE TO WEALTH

Like my dad, you must first define your goals before deciding how to use your wealth. First, determine what you want your wealth to achieve. This parallel isn't coincidental. Whether we're talking about time, energy, or money, the principle remains the same: Clarity of purpose must precede action.

---

Whether we're talking about time, energy,  
or money, the principle remains the same:  
Clarity of purpose must precede action.

---

Think about it this way: My father could have chosen many experiences for transformation. He could have gone on a silent meditation retreat, gone on a sabbatical to write, or traveled the world. But because he knew what he wanted—physical challenge combined with solitude and spiritual reflection—the Camino became the obvious choice. Your wealth works the same way. Until you know what you want it to do for you, every financial decision is just a guess.

## ANOTHER QUESTION TO ASK

The next Decidedly Wealthy question you must ask yourself is, “What do I want my wealth to do for me?” This is often as tricky to answer as the previous question regarding your money’s importance. Rarely is the first thought that comes to mind the truest and deepest answer you can give. The more thought you put into answering this question, the more useful your answer will be in *deciding who you are*. The very question implies a decision is necessary: What do you want your wealth to do for you?

Your answer may be different from what *others* think you should want your wealth to do for you. We all carry the baggage of the expectations others have placed on us, often without invitation. When it comes to your wealth, you get to decide what you want it to do for you. It is yours, after all, no one else’s. To be clear, we are not talking about investment capital here, nor the money from income you need to meet family obligations or responsibilities. Think about it in the larger sense—think about your wealth in its entirety. I am not talking about focusing on yourself, but rather focusing beyond yourself by finding your wealth’s bigger purpose.

## THE FOUR LAYERS OF WANT

Most people stop at the surface when asked what they want their wealth to do.

“Pay the mortgage.”

“Fund retirement.”

“Buy nice things.”

But these aren't endpoints—they're vehicles. To understand what you want your wealth to do for you, you need to dig through four distinct layers.

### **Layer 1: The Surface (What You Think You Want)**

This is where most people start and stop. It's the tangible, the obvious, the things you can point to:

"I want to buy a beach house."

"I want to retire at fifty-five."

"I want to pay for my kids' college."

"I want a new car every three years."

There's nothing wrong with these wants. They're real and valid. But they're not the whole story.

### **Layer 2: The Functional (What Those Things Provide)**

Regarding your money, perhaps you have never thought about a deeper answer to this question. That is normal. Maybe your gut reaction was to answer "to buy stuff," "to pay the mortgage," "to pay tuition," "to put food on the table" or something similar. Push beyond the surface here. What makes you want those things as opposed to others?

Is the beach house a gathering place for the family? Will early retirement provide time freedom? Will a college tuition fund provide opportunities for your children? Will the new car provide reliability or perhaps status? See, now we're getting somewhere, but we're not there yet.

### **Layer 3: The Emotional (How You Want to Feel)**

If your money did all those things, how would you feel? That feeling is what you're really after, not just the purchases or paid-off debts.

After all, money is a tool for exchanging goods and services. It can buy almost anything this world offers: transportation through a car or bus ticket, relaxation through a deep tissue massage at a resort, celebration through a custom cake for your daughter's graduation party. You could have answered with almost anything in the world. So what makes you want your money to do what you originally said as opposed to something else? What is at the heart of wanting your wealth to do those specific things?

Is it because the beach house for family gathering makes you feel connected and loved? Is it because early retirement, which provides time freedom, makes you feel autonomous and in control? Is it because the college tuition fund makes you feel like a good provider, a protector? This emotional layer is where the truth emerges.

#### **Layer 4: The Identity (Who You Want to Be)**

The deepest layer is about identity. You want to feel connected because you see yourself as the family patriarch or matriarch who brings everyone together. You want autonomy because you see yourself as an independent thinker who shouldn't be constrained by others' schedules. You want to be a provider because you see yourself as someone who opens doors for others.

You will not arrive at the true answer until you are able to identify the rawest feeling that you want your wealth to make you feel. The real answer to this Decidedly Wealthy question is a feeling. You may want your wealth to give you freedom, independence, stability, security, the ability to help others, or something along those lines. Yes, money can buy those things. Not directly, of course. We do not go to the local supermarket and pull "autonomy" off the top shelf—but a purposeful plan can be designed so your wealth can give you what you want most deeply.

## STORIES OF DISCOVERY

Let me share three stories of clients who thought they knew what they wanted their wealth to do, only to discover something deeper.

### **The Executive and the Sailboat**

Graham came to us with a clear goal: He wanted to buy a sailboat. He'd done his research, picked out the model, even chosen a funny nautical name. But when we took him through these four layers, something interesting emerged: The desire wasn't about the boat.

- Surface: "I want a sailboat."
- Functional: "I want to go on trips with my family."
- Emotional: "I want to feel connected to my kids before they leave for college."
- Identity: "I want to be the dad who creates adventures."

Once Graham understood this, his entire financial plan shifted. Yes, he still bought a sailboat—but a much smaller one. He used the difference to create an "adventure fund" that paid for monthly experiences with his kids: skiing trips, scuba certification, even a month-long RV trip across America. The boat would have provided maybe four weeks a year of family time. His new plan created a twelve-month connection.

### **The Entrepreneur Who Couldn't Retire**

Nadia built and sold a successful marketing agency. At forty-eight, she had enough money to never work again. Her stated goal: "I want

my wealth to let me retire early.” But six months into retirement, she was miserable.

Going through the layers revealed:

- Surface: “I want to retire.”
- Functional: “I want to escape the stress of managing people.”
- Emotional: “I want to feel creative and challenged.”
- Identity: “I’m an innovator who solves problems.”

Nadia didn’t really want retirement; she wanted autonomy. She ended up using her wealth to fund a new venture with no employees—a solo consulting practice where she only took projects that excited her. Her wealth didn’t buy her an escape from work; it bought her the freedom to do work on her own terms.

## **The Couple and the House**

Marcus and Quinn were convinced they needed a bigger house. Their current home was “too small” for entertaining, they said. They wanted their wealth to provide a space worthy of their success.

Digging deeper, we found:

- Surface: “We need a bigger house.”
- Functional: “We want to host gatherings.”
- Emotional: “We want to feel connected to our community.”
- Identity: “We are people who bring others together.”

Instead of upgrading to a much larger home, they kept their current home and used their wealth to create a family foundation focused on community building. They now host quarterly grant

celebrations that bring together hundreds of people—far more connection than any house could provide.

## COMMON MISTAKES TO AVOID

As you work through what you want your wealth to do for you, watch out for these common traps:

### **Confusing Means with Ends**

A beach house is a means, not an end. Early retirement is a means, not an end. Even financial security is a means to something deeper. Always ask: “And then what?” If I have the beach house, then what? If I retire early, then what? Keep pushing until you hit emotional and identity bedrock.

### **Adopting Others’ Definitions of Success**

Understanding what’s truly important reveals who you are. Understanding what you want your wealth to do creates your plan. Answer both questions with reverence, introspection, and thoughtfulness before setting out on your journey.

Your parents might value security above all else. Your neighbors might prioritize status. Your colleagues might chase growth. None of their priorities are wrong, but they might be wrong for you. Your wealth should reflect your values, not theirs.

### **Stopping at Material Goals**

Wealthy individuals who don’t first decide who they are never achieve true fulfillment—they never become Decidedly Wealthy. Their lives remain incomplete because they never determined their wealth’s purpose.

Material goals are easy to articulate but ultimately unsatisfying as endpoints. “I want a car, a house, a boat” tells us nothing about who you are or what drives you. These are props in a play, not the play itself.

### **Ignoring the Shadow Side**

Sometimes what we think we want our wealth to do is actually about avoiding something we fear. “I want security” might really mean “I’m terrified of being vulnerable.” “I want to leave a legacy” might mean “I’m afraid of being forgotten.” Understanding both the positive pull and the negative push helps you make more conscious decisions.

## THE IMPORTANCE TEST

Here’s a practical exercise to dig deeper into your wants. Start with your surface-level desire and keep asking, “What’s important about that?” until you can’t go any deeper:

“I want my wealth to let me retire early.”

*What’s important about that to you?*

“So I can stop working.”

*What’s important about that to you?*

“So I have more time.”

*What’s important about that to you?*

“So I can pursue my interests.”

## What Do You Want Your Money to Do for You?

*What's important about that to you?*

“So I can feel like I’m living my own life.”

*What's important about that to you?*

“So I can be true to who I really am.”

Now we’re getting somewhere. The real want isn’t early retirement—it’s authenticity.

## QUESTIONS FOR COUPLES AND FAMILIES

If you’re married or have a family, these questions become even more complex and important. Here are some questions to explore together:

- Do we want our wealth to do the same things, or do we have different visions?
- How do we balance individual wants with collective needs?
- What do we want our wealth to teach our children?
- How do we want to be remembered as stewards of this wealth?
- What values do we want our financial decisions to reflect?

## INTEGRATION WITH YOUR DECIDEDLY WEALTHY JOURNEY

Deciding what you want your wealth to do for you makes the next Key Decisions clearer. For my dad, he decided he wanted a transformational experience to give him time to grow and think.

That deliberate action made it easy for him to determine the next step—walking the Camino and later hiking a large section of the PCT.

Once you're clear on what you want your wealth to do for you, the next three decisions become much more straightforward.

**Decide Where You Are:** You can assess whether your current position serves what you want.

**Decide Where You're Going:** You can set targets aligned with your true desires.

**Decide How to Get There:** You can choose strategies that honor your deepest values.

## YOUR TURNING POINT EXERCISE

Before moving to the next chapter, spend real time on this exercise. Don't rush it. This might be some of the most important thinking you do about your wealth.

### Part 1: The Stream of Consciousness

Set a timer for ten minutes. Write continuously about what you want your wealth to do for you. Don't edit, don't judge, just write. Let everything pour out—the noble and the petty, the generous and the selfish, the clear and the confused.

### Part 2: The Layer Analysis

Review what you wrote and categorize each want:

- Surface (things, milestones, purchases)
- Functional (capabilities, opportunities, access)

- Emotional (feelings, states of being, relief from fears)
- Identity (who you want to be, how you want to be remembered)

### Part 3: The One Thing

You'll often hear people speak about their top priorities for their business or for the upcoming year. The problem is that while it's praise-worthy to focus on growth and have objectives you want to accomplish, you can *not* have multiple priorities. You can only have *one* priority. If your wealth could only do one thing for you—provide one feeling, enable one identity, create one possibility—what would it be? This is your north star, the thing that all other financial decisions should be evaluated against.

## YOUR WEALTH, YOUR WAY

Deciding what you want your money to do for you isn't about finding the *right* answer—it's about finding your *true* answer. The clearer you are about what you want your wealth to do for you, the more likely you are to build a financial life that provides it.

The intense afternoon sun was rapidly sinking in the sky when my dad made a statement I've never forgotten: "People spend more time planning vacations than what they want from their wealth. Then they wonder why wealth doesn't make them happy," he said.

"Whenever I am doing an estate plan for someone, I ask them what they want the money to do when they're done with it. They usually chuckle at the question and then go on to share with me their beneficiary wishes. A list of people. I'll stop them and point out that I didn't ask *who* it should go to but rather *what* it

should do. We have a finite time here on Earth, but our money doesn't. It keeps living."

Decide what you want your wealth to do for you. Then, think beyond that. Then make it happen.

## ACTION STEPS

**Ask yourself these questions:**

- What do I want my wealth to do for me?
- If I get my wealth to do that, how will I feel?
- Who will I become when my wealth is doing what I want it to do?
- What would have to be true about my financial life for me to feel like I'm living my purpose?
- How will I know when my wealth is working for me rather than the other way around?



## CHAPTER 3

# What Is Your Relationship with Money?

### **Day 2. Evening.**

My dad and I arrived at the campground with enough sunlight still crawling its way over the mountains. We could set up our tents without using headlamps. We hiked a quarter mile off the Pacific Crest Trail to the campground. This campground seemed designed for families enjoying a weekend, not people like us. It felt almost sinful to indulge in the comfort of a public toilet and water that we did not need to filter ourselves from a stream nearby. It was as luxurious as we had expected—that is to say, not at all.

I ran to the latrine only to find an out-of-order sign. Dejected, I got my mind off my disappointment by breaking out the camp stove. I tossed every calorie I could find into my tin cup, heating it on the stove. I was trying to refuel for another long day. I stirred my cheesy rice concoction with my wooden spoon—my most treasured item in my pack. It had a long, slender handle no wider than a Ticonderoga pencil.

I carved it with a pocketknife from a juniper branch in Utah six years prior. There was a small, dark brown knot by the branch that became the spoon's bowl. After years of campfire cooking, the knot wiggled itself loose and fell out of the spoon. It left a tiny, circular hole no wider than an eraser a quarter of an inch from the neck of the utensil. When I scooped up rice, macaroni, noodles, or whatever else I cooked on the trail, the juice holding all the spices would drain out before reaching my lips. That saved the best part of the meal for last, letting me hold the warm silver cup with both hands and sip a chicken-broth-like drink to stay warm.

Looking at that spoon, I realized how our imperfections and experiences shape what we become. That hole—what seemed like damage—had actually improved the spoon's function for me. Our relationship with money works the same way. Every financial scar, every money memory, every lesson learned through lack or abundance creates holes in our perfect theories about wealth. And sometimes, those imperfections make us better if we learn to work with them rather than against them.

I sat cross-legged on a concrete picnic bench, both hands holding the steaming cup below my chin as my dad unrolled the laminated itinerary on the adjoining table. He pointed to the furthest right-hand column. To my relief, we only had a ten-mile day to reach Mount Laguna tomorrow.

Just as I exhaled, I noticed that an old, white-haired gentleman had tip-toed his way to within a few feet of the concrete table we had claimed. He raised his left arm slightly above his waist, palm facing toward us and index finger extended upward to say without words, 'Do you mind if I interrupt?'

My dad and I both softened our eyes to show the man he was welcome here.

“Do you mind if I...” the old man said while motioning toward the dirt next to us.

“Of course, of course!” my dad said, allowing the man to keep his dignity by not making him beg to set up his tent right next to ours. After all, we had found the flattest spot in the campground, and we didn’t own it.

His lightweight gear identified him as a fellow hiker. Most people we saw on the trail were closer to my age than my father’s. This man looked old enough to be my grandpa. He moved slowly as one does when he fears setting off the wrong trip wire in one of his joints.

*It must be lonely hiking by yourself*, I thought. I was happy to have my dad’s company. It kept my spirits up. Walking through the wilderness can get repetitive. The temptation to extend a rest break much longer than necessary is strong when no one is around to motivate you to keep moving forward. Instantly, I admired this man’s strength to undertake such a feat—one I can only hope I have the resilience to commit to myself when I reach his age.

“How was your hike today?” I asked.

“It was nice. It’s beautiful, just as beautiful as it is every year.”

“Oh, you’ve been here before?” my dad asked. He hoped the man could share some helpful tips to make the journey less uncertain.

“I have, my son and I would hike for a week at a time every summer,” the elderly man said while hammering the final stake of his tent. “Work, school, or life always got in the way, so we couldn’t stay long.”

“Are you a thru-hiker or a section hiker?” My dad asked, seeking clarification on whether the man twenty years his senior planned to make the long trek to Canada or was out for another weeklong excursion. I had to hold back a smile listening to my dad ask that question. For as much ego death he experienced walking the Camino

several years back, he still had to measure himself against other people sometimes—we all do. My dad had been more than a little nervous about being the oldest person on the trail we had seen up to this point. As much as he was measuring his physical fitness against a stranger's, he was also looking for inspiration as well.

“I sure hope to be a thru-hiker,” the man replied. “But, I’m going day by day. That’s all we can do. Maybe I make it all the way, maybe I don’t. I don’t move too fast, so the winter weather may catch up to me by the time I get to Washington. If it does, so be it. That’s why my son gave me the trail name Slow Bird. He used to make fun of how slowly I moved. He was always a much better hiker than I was, even when he was little.

Hiking was something he was built for. I brought him out here once when he was in grade school, and then he begged me to bring him back. It was never really my thing, but...ya know.” Slow Bird spoke while glancing at my father to share a moment only they could understand about the lengths a man will go to see his boy smile.

“Haha! That’s funny. I guess I thought we couldn’t give each other trail names, but who better to anoint you than your own son, right?” I said, now brainstorming which embarrassing name I could bestow upon my father later.

“That’s right,” Slow Bird nodded. “I’m glad that he did. He used to love calling me that when we were out here.”

“Is your son coming to hike any part of the trail with you?” I asked.

“Unfortunately, no. My son passed away a couple of years ago.”

“I’m sorry to hear that,” I said. My heart broke for Slow Bird. As I could see tears well in his eyes, I became eternally grateful for the time I was spending with my father at that very moment.

“That’s why I’m here now—to do what we never got to do together, complete the trail,” he said.

As I watched Slow Bird carefully arrange his gear, I understood something profound. His relationship with this trail wasn’t about hiking—it was about identity, memory, and meaning. The steps he’d made before with his son shaped every step. The trail meant something different to him than it did to any other hiker because of the experiences that formed that relationship.

Our relationship with money works the same way. We don’t see money for what it is—a neutral tool, a medium of exchange. We see it through the lens of every experience we’ve had with it, especially those early, formative ones. Slow Bird couldn’t separate the PCT from memories of his son. Similarly, we cannot separate money from our childhood experiences. Those past experiences become the invisible script that guides every financial decision we make as adults.

## YOUR EARLY MONEY MEMORIES

Slow Bird knew his purpose on the trail because he had a strong relationship with it. His memories of trekking with his son defined his current journey. He could embark on his own hike and honor their relationship. Slow Bird’s presence on the trail was significant. To *Decide Who You Are*, you must understand what your relationship to your own trail is. What is your relationship with your wealth? We all have one. Just as Slow Bird’s son’s love for hiking defined his reverence for the Pacific Crest Trail, our parents or families of origin often define that relationship.

A couple of years ago, a client named Shauna hired me because she was going through a difficult end to her marriage.

Our first meeting went smoothly. She came in and said, “Look, I’m going through a divorce. It’s for the best; I just need someone to help me organize everything and navigate through this process. Can you help?”

I evaluated her situation, reviewed her assets, and asked a few questions, and it was clear that I could help her through this difficult time. From a planning perspective, it looked like she would be fine. Shauna’s divorce would leave her financially comfortable, allowing her to maintain her lifestyle and retire in ten years. She had a high-paying job and could earn enough on her own to live comfortably and continue to save without having to spend down her assets. It was the shortest first meeting I have ever had with a prospective client. It took me about ten minutes to decide whether I could help her get where she wanted to go. And it took her about the same amount of time to decide that she wanted to hire me and our team.

We scheduled our second meeting for a Friday afternoon at four o’clock. I was expecting another short and painless session. Why else would I schedule it at the end of the day on a Friday? We did not leave my office until well after dark.

The meeting began with a values exercise. This process helps clients discover the values that are important to them. Typically, clients can pinpoint their top five core values in fifteen to twenty minutes. We then use these as a north star for decision-making to align their goals with their values, and their actions with those goals. Shauna did not need fifteen minutes. She did not need thirty. She needed the entire evening. After struggling to narrow down what was important to her, she stopped staring at the cards and looked up at me. Tears had formed in her eyes.

“Sanger, I’m scared,” she admitted.

“Moving on from a marriage can be scary. That’s normal,” I replied.

“No, that’s not why I’m scared. I will be fine; the divorce is for the best. I’m scared I’m going to spend all my money.”

“What do you mean? Remember, we’ve already established you have more than enough money to meet your goals.”

“You don’t get it,” she said. And then she poured out her soul. “I grew up poor on a farm in East Texas. We had nothing. We lived on food stamps and government assistance. I never thought I was going to make it out of that place, but here I am now. I have more money than my entire family tree combined, and that is exactly the problem.” She continued, “Growing up, when we had money, we spent it. We didn’t know when it was coming back, if ever. No matter how hard I try, I can’t shake loose from that feeling. I can’t break free from what that experience did to me. Every single day I wake up terrified of being what I used to be.”

That is when it clicked for me. The reason our early experiences with money are so important is that they shape our perspective. These early perspectives tend to change over time. My father and I have had many conversations with folks who are successfully retired. They will not run out of money. The challenge we have in our discussions is not that they are going to have to cut back. Not that they are going to have to spend less money. The challenge is that they are not spending enough. They are going to leave a gigantic pile of money at the end of their story. While that may seem nice, we rarely meet anyone who lists that as their primary goal. They are happy if it happens, but it’s not the most important thing.

I heard a story from the book *Still Standing* by Tom Dreesen, who was the opening act for Frank Sinatra for fourteen years. As Tom tells it, there was a woman who waited outside a venue for Frank so

she could get his autograph after the show. When Frank heard this, he exited the limo before it pulled away and approached the woman. She explained that her husband was terminally ill and she was hoping she could get an autograph for him. Not only did Frank give her an autograph, but he took off his custom-made cufflinks and handed them to her to give to her dying husband.

“Frank, those were expensive cufflinks, what are you doing?!” Dreesen recounts saying.

Frank replied, “Tom, we are all just renting. Someday, someone else will be wearing those cufflinks instead of me, someone will be living in my house and driving my car. If I can’t give what I have away, what’s the point?”

Frank knew things only have value when they create joy for others. Frank went on to say, “Tommy, if you possess something that you can’t give away, then you don’t possess it, it possesses you.”

If our objective is making the greatest use of our wealth, the question becomes: How do we become good stewards of this money? Maybe the answer is philanthropy; maybe the answer is spending it to create experiences for yourself and your family; maybe it’s helping others. But to be a good steward, you should not leave money behind for others to spend with no thought about how that money should be used. We each have an obligation to pass along values and not just “stuff.”

Their challenge isn’t the money—it’s the mindset. A lifetime of frugality, careful spending, and money-consciousness built their wealth. Those habits earned constant reinforcement. Breaking through to spend on themselves now feels impossible after decades of doing the opposite.

We often share with clients that it’s okay to spend money to fly first class. Recently, I had a conversation with some clients who asked

if it was okay to spend money to fix up their house. This is a debt-free property and the place they plan to live in for the rest of their lives. They were afraid to use money they did not need. Their current pensions outstripped their lifestyle. They were asking to spend money from assets they did not use. If those assets disappeared, they would still be financially fine. We found it simple, but they couldn't grasp that they could double the house's value and still be fine. Yet they remained hesitant.

Your relationship with money won't change just because a spreadsheet says you have enough. If you grew up asking permission to spend and hearing "no," that framework still shapes your decisions today.

---

Your relationship with money won't  
change just because a spreadsheet  
says you have enough.

---

## YOUR MONEY STORY

What comes to mind when you think about money? How did you first come to be aware of money and how it interacts with our lives? Think back. Was money discussed in your family when you were growing up? If so, was it in hushed whispers after they went to bed? Was it about how your parents were getting screwed over by someone who had wealth: a landlord, a boss, the government officials, or the big fat cats in business? These money stories form the basis of how you make decisions. They matter. Negative money stories can be challenging to overcome, but you cannot overcome them if you do not acknowledge them.

**Here are some questions to ask yourself to help determine your money story:**

- Were you taught to save and budget or to spend and regret?
- Was there a time when you didn't have enough? How did that impact you? How does it impact you today?
- Were you taught to work hard and earn your money or that a parent or government should give it to you?
- Were you taught to borrow and use debt or to pay cash?
- Were you taught to invest and grow for the future or to spend now?
- Were you taught that investing is a way to put your money to work for you and build wealth or that the stock market is like a casino?

Ask yourself these questions to uncover what your wealth philosophy is so that you can articulate it. This will give you the power to understand your internal biases and find areas where they may hold you back, just like the values exercise helped Shauna do.

Without first understanding her wealth philosophy, Shauna would have struggled to become Decidedly Wealthy. Shauna began taking steps to overcome her negative childhood biases about money.

She was getting educated about money; she was hiring a financial advisor as a guide; and—most importantly—she was beginning to understand her own money story. By understanding the money misconceptions her parents had taught her, she overcame them. So can you.

## THE POWER OF AWARENESS

Slow Bird was on that trail because he understood his relationship with it. Every step carried meaning because of the memories that shaped that meaning. Shauna began to assume control of her financial future once she understood how her past poverty still controlled her present wealth.

Your money story—whether it's one of scarcity or abundance, fear or entitlement, shame or pride—is shaping every financial decision you make today. You might seem financially stable according to spreadsheets and advisors. But you'll remain trapped in old habits until you understand your relationship with money.

The beautiful truth is this: Unlike our childhood experiences, which we couldn't control, we can choose to rewrite our money story. We can decide what relationship we want to have with wealth going forward. But first, we must do the work of understanding the story we're living.

Just as my father decided to walk the Camino to transform his relationship with *doing* versus *being*, you can decide to transform your relationship with money. Just as my imperfect wooden spoon became my greatest asset, your money wounds can become your financial wisdom—but only if you acknowledge, understand, and consciously choose what to do with them.

The goal isn't to erase your money story. The goal is to understand it so thoroughly that it no longer controls you. When you can see your money patterns—when you can name them, claim them, and choose whether to keep or change them—that's when you begin *Deciding Who You Are*.

## ACTION STEPS

### **Step 1: Excavate Your First Money Memory**

Write about your earliest vivid memory involving money.

It might be:

- A time you wanted something but couldn't have it
- Overhearing your parents talk (or argue) about money
- Getting your first allowance or paycheck
- Watching how money affected someone you loved

Once you've written the memory, answer these questions:

- What emotion did you feel in that moment?
- What conclusion did you draw about money?
- How might this memory still influence your financial decisions today?

### **Step 2: Identify Your Inherited Money Beliefs**

Complete this sentence based on what you learned growing up:

"When it comes to money, I was taught that..."

Examples might include:

- "Money is a tool and is available in abundance."
- "We can't afford it."
- "Money is the root of all evil."
- "There's never enough," or "There's always enough."

Now ask yourself: Is this belief serving me or limiting me? If it's limiting you, rewrite it to reflect what you choose to believe now.

### **Step 3: Write Your New Money Story**

In one paragraph, write a new narrative about your relationship with money that begins with “I am someone who...”

Include how you want to relate to money, what you want to use it for, and what you’re committed to changing. Keep it positive and present-tense.

Example: “I am someone who views money as a tool for creating security and opportunities for my family. I make financial decisions based on my values, not my fears. I’m learning to trust my ability to create wealth and use it wisely.”



## CHAPTER 4

# What Matters to You?

### Day 2. Night.

After Slow Bird had retired to his tent, neither my dad nor I could sleep. We sat stone-faced on the concrete slab where we'd eaten dinner. The stars scattered across the sky were unlike anything either of us had ever seen. It was magical. It was a picture so unbelievable it almost looked fake. I was so used to the city lights polluting the sky. Even looking up into the nighttime sky when on a hunting trip in Texas didn't touch the beauty above us. After a couple of minutes, my dad broke the silence.

"You know what Slow Bird made me think about?" my dad asked, his voice quiet in the darkness. "Sometimes we don't know what truly matters until we're forced to choose. I learned that with Ben and Kristy a few months ago. They taught me the difference between what we think matters and what actually matters."

## HAVING MORE MONEY THAN TIME

The first three questions help you *Decide Who You Are*—what's important regarding money and your relationship with it. This leads to the crucial question: What matters to you?

This isn't about your values in abstract terms. It's not about goals you might pursue someday. It's about forced prioritization—what you would choose if you had to choose. Values are what you believe and advocate for; what matters is what you'd sacrifice everything else to protect. Goals are what you want to achieve; what matters is what you can't live without achieving. Your relationship with money is how you interact with wealth; what matters is why that wealth exists in the first place.

Ben and Kristy met my dad and me because they were looking for a financial advisory team to work with them as they were selling their business. The business had been in the family for two generations but was now being sold to an out-of-state competitor. My dad and I both could tell it was a bittersweet topic for Ben. He had poured his soul into the business and built it up from what his father had left him. The family name was on the building, and the building was well known in the community. That journey was ending.

Ben had an energy about him. It was almost as if he was treating this meeting as another one of the business negotiations that had led him to become so successful over the years. He began the conversation by talking about the money that was coming his family's way from the sale. My dad outlined tax strategies and investment income methods. I ran a back-of-the-napkin calculation while they talked and could tell they would be set for life after the deal was done.

The room was oddly tense given what would be a celebration for most people. When people sell their business, they're usually anxious but excited to receive a check representing decades of hard work, risk, and leadership. My dad attempted to cut through the tension

by asking the first of the Decidedly Wealthy questions: “What is important about your wealth to you?”

Ben and Kristy were dead silent. The question had triggered something, and I did not know what. My dad, misreading the room, joked with Ben, “You’re going to have all the money in the world now! What do you want it to do for you?”

“I’ll have ‘all the money in the world’, but I won’t have all the time in the world,” he replied. He slouched. It was as if he had been deflated. There was a long pause; no one spoke. I could tell my dad wished he had not been so flippant.

“Can I say something?” Kristy said, chiming in for the first time, saving the awkward moment. She looked at Ben. “Why don’t you just tell him?” she said.

Ben glanced at her with reassuring eyes and then shifted toward my dad, his chest now puffed out again as if he remembered he had to be strong.

“I just got diagnosed a few weeks ago with something that’s going to be pretty awful. It’s terminal. I will not go quickly and painlessly,” Ben said. “It’s going to destroy me. I’ve likely only got a few years left.” He spoke with the confidence that came from wrestling with the topic privately and with doctors for months.

Ben continued, “Our son, Jack, he’s disabled. I just want the assurance that Kristy and Jack will be well taken care of.”

My dad and I stayed silent as Ben continued to open up.

“I want to spend the time I have left not having to worry about all this stuff we’ve just spent the past half hour talking about.”

Ben had shared with us what was important. Discussing taxes and investment strategies wasn’t giving him peace of mind. It only added more items to his list of responsibilities—things he needed to

handle correctly for his family while he still could. He needed peace of mind knowing his family was going to be financially secure and able to enjoy their time on earth. Ben and Kristy wanted to spend as much time as possible with their son at their favorite place—the beaches of Florida’s Emerald Coast—while they still had the chance.

Their relationship to their wealth became clear because they saw the real issue—knowing what they wanted their wealth to do for them. We’d focused on investment and tax planning at the beginning of our conversation because at the start, Ben and Kristy had thought that mattered most. In reality, the more pressing issue was estate planning, and the most pressing issue was creating peace of mind. My dad and I had both missed the cue. We had wasted time talking about tax strategies and income distribution methods when we should have been talking about what mattered most to them. We had skipped the first Key Decision and jumped ahead.

Ben and Kristy just wanted to pursue their dreams and avoid regrets. They wanted us to assure them they’d be financially secure and guide them through it for peace of mind.

The first Key Decision is to *Decide Who You Are*. Answering these four questions will help you build your wealth philosophy. Simply put, your wealth philosophy is the way you view your money.

**Ask yourself:**

- What is important about my money?
- What do I want my money to do?
- What is my relationship with money?
- What matters to me?

For Ben and Kristy, knowing their money philosophy became easy. They understood they wanted to accomplish their most

important goals quickly without losing peace of mind in their future financial security. The question shifted from “How do we save money on taxes?” to “What do we want this wealth to do for us?” If you can answer the latter, the other answers fall into place.

Ben had to answer the question of what he would do if he had all the money he needed, but had limited time. This brought everything into focus in a way nothing else could. If you can consider how you would react if you had all the money you needed but limited time to spend it, your priorities will rise to the surface. From there, you can become Decidedly Wealthy.



**Ask yourself these questions about your money and time:**

- If I had all the money in the world but limited time, what would I do?
- If I had ten years to live, what would I do?
- If I had one day to live, what would I regret *not* doing?

By asking yourself these questions and giving honest responses, you will understand what matters. You will understand who matters. From there, you can refine your wealth philosophy.

Ben's clarity came from constraint—limited time forced him to identify what mattered. But here's the truth: We all have limited time. We just pretend we don't. Most people I talk to speak in terms such as *if I die*, when we all know it's *when*, not *if*. The difference between Ben and most of us isn't the reality of our mortality; it's the awareness of it.

The awareness that our time on this Earth isn't forever transforms everything about how we approach wealth. When you understand what matters—not what should matter, not what others say matters, but what matters to you in your bones—your entire wealth

---

But here's the truth: We all have limited time. We just pretend we don't.

---

philosophy shifts. You stop accumulating for accumulation's sake. You stop comparing yourself to others. You use money as a tool to protect and pursue what matters most. You give away the cufflinks.

## THE THREE CIRCLES OF WHAT MATTERS

To determine what matters to you, imagine three concentric circles.

**The Outer Circle—The Negotiables:** These are things you value and enjoy but could live without if necessary. Nice cars, regular vacations, dining out. They enhance life but don't define it. They're the things you do with discretionary capital.

**The Middle Circle—The Important:** These significantly impact your quality of life and sense of self. Career achievement, financial

security, community involvement. Losing these would hurt, but you'd survive and could rebuild.

**The Inner Circle—The Non-Negotiables:** These are what matter. Without them, life loses meaning. For Ben, it was Kristy and Jack's security. For Slow Bird, it was honoring his son's memory. These are the things you'd sacrifice everything else to protect.

Most people never distinguish between these circles. They treat everything as equally important, nothing is prioritized. But when you're forced to choose—by illness, loss, or the clarity that comes from honest reflection—only the inner circle remains.

## YOUR WEALTH PHILOSOPHY

Before moving beyond the first Key Decision, it is important to define your wealth philosophy. In essence, you'll need to build a framework to approach Key Decisions so you can make them in advance by determining your philosophy. Your wealth philosophy is what you decide your relationship to your wealth will be. To begin, ask yourself what comes to mind when you think about money. Is it fear, reluctance, or some other strong emotional reaction?

What we have noticed is that Decidedly Wealthy individuals have a vastly different relationship with money than those who are not. It is not about the amount of money they possess or the assets they have gained. Instead, it's about their philosophy of wealth and relationship with it. They pay attention to their money without obsessing over it. They invest for growth and establish goals for their money. Their money serves them as a tool rather than something to accumulate. They respect money rather than fear it. If you try to switch from scarcity thinking to abundance thinking too late in life, you might create real scarcity. And as Shauna's story showed us,

once you're in that situation, it's difficult to get out. Individuals with a Decidedly Wealthy philosophy know what they want their money to do for them. They know what matters.

**Here are some philosophies we notice about Decidedly Wealthy individuals:**

- They do not expect money or the things it buys to make them happy.
- They respect money and learn about it.
- Money or discussions about it do not frighten them.
- They are reluctant to use money that is not theirs and minimize debt.
- They see their money as a tool to grow their freedom rather than as an end in itself.
- They give generously.
- They save first instead of trying to only save what is left.
- They think about, and relate to, money differently than most in that they embrace it and use it to meet their goals without the money itself becoming the goal.
- They're confident they'll have enough, and this confidence compels them to use their wealth for something greater than just their own comfort.
- They use their wealth to make a difference.

## THE CLARITY OF CONSTRAINT

As my dad and I sat under those stars, listening to Slow Bird's gentle snoring from his tent nearby, I understood something fundamental.

I'd met two men on this trail—Slow Bird and my father—who had both discovered what mattered through different kinds of constraints. Slow Bird through loss, my father through choosing to step away from doing to focus on being.

And I recalled Ben, who found clarity through the ultimate time constraint of a terminal diagnosis. But you don't need tragedy or pilgrimage to discover what matters. You just need the courage to ask the tough questions and the wisdom to listen to your truest answers.

What matters to you is not what you think should matter. Not what impresses others or looks good on paper. Not what sounds right. What matters is what you would choose if all the noise fell away—it's what would make you feel complete at the end of your story, knowing you honored it with your time, energy, and wealth.

Your wealth philosophy isn't just about how you view money—it's about using money to protect and pursue what matters most. When you achieve this alignment, you don't just become wealthy. You become Decidedly Wealthy, using your resources with intention, purpose, and clarity.

The stars above us that night were always there, but city lights had hidden them from view. What matters to you is the same—always there, but often obscured by the noise and obligations of daily life. Find somewhere quiet, look up, and see what's been there all along.

## ACTION STEPS

### **Step 1: The Life Question**

If you had all the money you needed but only ten years to live, what would you do?

Write your answer in detail. Be specific about experiences, people, and places. This reveals what matters to you when money is no longer the constraint.

### **Step 2: Write Your Wealth Philosophy**

Complete this simple statement:

“I believe money exists to \_\_\_\_\_. Therefore, I will use my wealth to \_\_\_\_\_ because what matters most to me is \_\_\_\_\_.”

Example: “I believe money exists to create freedom and security for my family. Therefore, I will use my wealth to fund experiences over things because what matters most to me is time together while we have it.”

### **Step 3: The Alignment Check**

Look at your bank statement from last month. Do your biggest expenses align with what you wrote in Steps 1 and 2? Essentially, are the actions you are taking with your wealth aligned with the values you used to define yourself on your best day? If not, identify one specific change you'll make this month to better align your actions with your wealth and with what matters most.

## CHAPTER 5

# What Are Your Core Values?

### Day 2. Night.

We sat in silence for a few moments, absorbing everything we'd discussed. Then my father spoke again. "You know, there's something else—probably the most important part of *Deciding Who You Are*," he told me. "You must first uncover your core values. I learned that from a mentor of mine, Doug Lennick."

Doug was the general sales manager at the company where my dad started his career as a financial advisor. His perspective differed from other sales leaders. Other sales leaders taught advisors how to say and what to sell; Doug taught people how to think. He taught people how to think about life—a broader message about how to become more self-aware so that you could lead others and live a fulfilling life. His lessons were more applicable and transcendent than how to sell investments or how to convince someone to trust you with their life savings. It was deeper.

"Success comes down to fulfillment, and fulfillment is determined by alignment," my dad said while standing up to fold up his camping chair.

"What do you mean—alignment?" I asked.

“Fulfillment is the inner calibration that tells you whether what you are doing actually matters to you. It’s the feedback loop between external success and inner truth. You have to be lined up. Aligned. Each of us has an ideal self. We have the perfect image of who we could be on our best days—who we want to live up to. That ideal self is constructed in our minds based upon the values that are most important to us. But then we have our real selves, how we act in reality. The closer we can make our real self align with that perfect self-image, the more in harmony we will be, and the better we will perform. But we must be self-aware enough to recognize both. Then align them. Sometimes it’s being self-aware enough to know who you are, but most times it involves deciding to act differently.”

My dad set his folded camping chair to the side and bent down. He grabbed three softball-sized stones and placed the first one by my feet.

“This stone is how you imagine yourself to be.” He then placed another stone next to it.

“This one is what you want to accomplish. The third stone is your actions. See how they line up? If they don’t line up, you go off course. You end up in an undesirable place.”

He paused and asked, “Sanger, what are your top five values?”

“I don’t know.”

“That is where you have to start. Once you decide that, the other decisions become easier.”

## THE IMPORTANCE OF KNOWING WHAT YOU VALUE

After my time on the trail, when I returned home, I became a student of Doug Lennick’s work. I spent months learning how

## What Are Your Core Values?

to help my clients uncover their values. I learned about the “Alignment Model.” To achieve the kind of fulfillment my dad was talking about, you need to live a life that looks like your ideal self. How do you do that? You do that, I learned, by aligning your values with your goals, and your goals with your actions. The way you imagine yourself must align with who you really are so that your ideal self aligns with your real self.

---

The way you imagine yourself must align  
with who you really are so that your ideal  
self aligns with your real self.

---

To this day, I have never seen a client with a goal that conflicts or contradicts one of their values. I’ve also never heard someone say they value stability and security, then add, “So I want to buy a helicopter and learn to fly it.” That might be a goal for someone who values adventure and freedom, but a high-risk hobby is not going to sound fun to someone who values safety.

Instead, what I see almost every single day are people whose actions conflict with their values. That is because we are human—we are imperfect beings. We cannot consistently live up to any set of values—even our own—without stumbling every now and then by losing sight of what is important. Even my most successful Decidedly Wealthy clients occasionally become misaligned, although far less often than those who have not yet begun their journey to become Decidedly Wealthy.

Equally concerning is when I see someone who espouses values but makes no plans for those values to express themselves through goals or actions. They’re just words, like some dusty motivational

poster in a corporate break room. It becomes almost impossible to have those values express themselves if you don't even know what those values are.

Most people don't achieve alignment because of actions they neglected—goals they didn't know to pursue—not because of mistakes they made. Sometimes our goals conflict with our values. But more commonly, we cannot create opportunities to express our values. Both problems leave us feeling misaligned.

The most powerful example of the alignment model came from a conversation with my client Jeff. I had been working with Jeff for a few years at the time. He and his wife had worked with my father as their financial advisor for many years before I started working with them. Although we both felt as if we had known each other before we ever met. In meetings with my dad, Jeff had heard stories about my life. I knew him from the back-office work I had been doing in the company for many years before I ever got to shake his hand. By that I mean I knew his name, his daughters' names, how much money he had in his IRA, and how much his net worth had grown over the years.

The day I met Jeff wasn't what I'd imagined for two people who'd heard of each other for a decade and were finally meeting face-to-face. There were no smiles. The day we met, Jeff drove nine hours from his home in a small New Mexico town to meet me in my Fort Worth office.

Jeff's wife had passed away after a long fight with cancer we had all hoped was in remission. My heart broke for Jeff—I can only imagine the pain of losing my loving wife and the mother of my children. To add insult to injury, at this point in their lives, Jeff's wife was making a significantly higher income than he was. Understandably,

## What Are Your Core Values?

this made him nervous about his future. I felt relieved that I could share that he did not need to worry about money.

Based on the work he and his wife had done over the years with our firm, he was going to be financially secure. In fact, based on the numbers, the life insurance proceeds he received had created a new problem—how to handle passing on this substantial wealth to his children. People are not numbers, though. And numbers do not always capture what is important.

I met with Jeff every two to three months from that point forward. Each time, he would drive nine hours to see me in person. Yes, Jeff and I both knew that telephones and the Internet exist. But deciding who he was had become so important that he drove all day just to have this conversation in person.

Every meeting lasted a minimum of three hours. I spent that time showing Jeff every variation of every chart of every data point I could get my hands on to prove he did not need to worry anymore. Yes, his wife was gone. Yes, that pain was real and unabating—but he would not go broke. Each time he left, Jeff thanked me, saying he felt better because of our conversation. Each time, I was hopeful I had done my job—given Jeff the confidence to go through his new life without worrying about finances.

I wanted to be a good steward of the work my father had started and that his wife had hoped we would do. Jeff would call a month after each meeting. He would tell me that the worry and the anxiety were still there, just as strong as they ever had been. It was not until I understood the importance of core values and living in alignment that I could do the job that Jeff needed me to do. The next time I saw Jeff was at his house. I decided it was my turn to make the nine-hour drive. As we were sitting around the table in his

dining room, I reached into my briefcase and pulled out a special deck of cards from Doug's company Think2Perform.

I asked, "Can we try something different this time?"

"Of course. Whatever you think," Jeff replied. Though I could tell he was a touch skeptical.

"Close your eyes," I said. "I want you to think of the person you want to be. If your best day was every day, what would you be like?"

I paused and allowed Jeff to sit with his thoughts for a moment before continuing.

"Think of this ideal version of you. What are his habits? How does he eat and exercise? What is his daily routine? Now ask, who does he spend his time with? How does he treat those people? Who does he care about?"

I could see Jeff was less skeptical of where this was headed.

"Now, what is that person proud of having done?" Again, I paused. "Open your eyes. We all have an ideal version of who we are. Unfortunately, for everyone, that ideal self is often different from who we are today. The good news is that we can become the ideal version of ourselves. We must first understand what makes that guy—that ideal Jeff—tick. In other words, what is important to him? That ideal version of you is an image created from your core values. That's why I brought these cards. Let's figure that out together."

I opened the orange box, pulled out the cards, and turned them over on the table.

"Each card has a value written on it," I said. "None of the values are better or worse than the others. In fact, they are all good in their own way. We are going to find out which ones are the most important to you."

I asked Jeff to start with a speed round. He would glance at the value written on each card and, based on his first impulse, place it

## What Are Your Core Values?

into one of two piles. One pile for the values that resonated with him, one pile for the values that did not. Jeff went through the deck, then I removed the discard pile from the table. I asked him to go through the remaining value cards and pick the top fifteen.

As he mulled them over, I told Jeff to read the definition for each value that was written on the card. This seemed like an unnecessary step, but I learned through experience that vocalizing the definition allows for more precise thinking. It is hard to narrow a list of fifty-two values down to fifteen, much less five. That is why we went through the exercise in steps. Once Jeff had fifteen, I asked him to lay them all face up on the table so he could see them all.

“Now remove five,” I said.

This was hard for Jeff. It is difficult for most people who go through the exercise. At this point, many people are hesitant to discard any because they all resonate on some level. Further, discarding a value may feel like rejecting it or, worse, embracing its opposite. That is not the case. Because love is not in your top five values does not mean you are a hateful person.

As Jeff stared at the table with ten cards evenly spaced apart, I asked him to narrow it down to the top five. I remembered what I had learned from watching my father go through this exercise with clients. “You may notice that some of the cards are similar to each other. It might be helpful to find the value that is most important to you out of those two.”

I saw Jeff struggling internally over the choice between family and relationships. I gave him space to think in silence until he said, “You know what? My family is important to me. My daughters are important, and my siblings are important, but I feel that if I choose ‘family’ it will exclude the importance of other deep, connected relationships I want to have with people. On the other hand, I feel

like I should choose family.” He seemed concerned I’d judge him for not ranking family among his top five values.

“Jeff, this isn’t an exercise designed to find what ought to be important to us or what other people think we should place importance upon. It’s designed to find what is important to you. It is designed to discover who you are.”

With that, he slid the family card off to the side, keeping relationships in front of him. Instantly, it hit me. I finally understood why none of my charts, graphs, or spreadsheets ever eased Jeff’s anxiety. It was because he was not living in alignment with his values. Sure, Jeff had all the money he would ever need, but I was not helping him use it to fulfill what was deeply important to him—building relationships.

I asked, “Who have you met here?”

“Oh, I don’t think I’m ready to date anyone yet. Maybe one day, but not now.”

“No, I mean, who have you met in this town? Who are your friends? You and your wife moved here five years ago. Who is here that you would call if you just wanted to hang out?”

He looked at the ground, then said, “I guess no one... It’s not that easy here. There’s only five hundred people in this town. My wife and I moved here because this is where she wanted to retire. I didn’t care about making friends or meeting people when I was with her. She didn’t either, so we never did.”

“What could you do to meet people here?”

“Honestly, Sanger, I’m not sure there’s much I could do. Sure, I could go out more, but it isn’t like there’s much to go out for. We don’t even have a grocery store here.”

“You’re right. That would make it hard to meet people. What if you could go anywhere in the world? Literally anywhere—it

## What Are Your Core Values?

doesn't matter. Money won't hold you back; just imagine. Would you want to move somewhere else?"

"Well, yeah... now that I think about it, I probably would."

"Where would you go?"

"Colorado or Texas."

"What made you choose those places?"

"Colorado because it would be fun to live near the mountains. I live near the mountains now, but they are small. Colorado is much prettier. They also have good-sized towns in beautiful areas. Maybe I would fit in better there. Texas because I know more people there. I still have friends who live in Texas from when we lived there for thirty years. It would be nice to be around friends again."

"Jeff, I have good news. You don't have to choose. You can do both."

Jeff had identified relationships as one of his top five values. Yet nothing in our previous discussions about estate documents and death certificates had given him a way to make that value real. We had not set up aspirational goals Jeff could achieve that would allow his top value to be realized. Our discussions had not been in alignment, and, as a result, neither was Jeff. All of that was about to change. Jeff was about to go from wealthy to Decidedly Wealthy.

**Decidedly Wealthy individuals do the following with their core values:**

- Identify their top five values individually or as a family
- Establish a corresponding goal for each of their five core values
- Reject or deemphasize goals that do not fit within the framework of their five core values

- Remind themselves of their five core values (as often as multiple times per day), writing them down and posting them somewhere visible.
- Observe their actions daily to evaluate whether they are in alignment with their five core values
- Filter big decisions first by their five core values

## Day 2. Midnight.

After listening in awe as my dad wisely illustrated the importance of uncovering your core values in order to first *Decide Who You Are*, I was hooked. It reignited the passion inside of me for the work we do together. I took a break from finding constellations in the sky and asked, “So what is the next decision you have to make to be successful?”

“That’s for tomorrow,” he responded. “We’ll have plenty of time to talk then.”

# DECIDE WHO YOU ARE: DISCOVERING YOUR VALUES

A framework of values that guide your decisions

| Character Values<br>(Who You Strive to Be) | Relational Values<br>(How You Treat Others) | Performance Values<br>(How You Create,<br>Build, and Steward) |
|--------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| Integrity                                  | Trust                                       | Discipline                                                    |
| Wisdom                                     | Respect                                     | Responsibility                                                |
| Courage                                    | Generosity                                  | Accountability                                                |
| Contentment                                | Empathy                                     | Excellence                                                    |
| Humility                                   | Collaboration                               | Stewardship                                                   |

## What Are Your Core Values?

| <b>Character Values<br/>(Who You Strive to Be)</b> | <b>Relational Values<br/>(How You Treat Others)</b> | <b>Performance Values<br/>(How You Create,<br/>Build, and Steward)</b> |
|----------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Gratitude                                          | Service                                             | Diligence                                                              |
| Faith                                              | Loyalty                                             | Focus                                                                  |
| Patience                                           | Kindness                                            | Consistency                                                            |
| Authenticity                                       | Fairness                                            | Adaptability                                                           |
| Hope                                               | Open-mindedness                                     | Growth                                                                 |
| Purpose                                            | Forgiveness                                         | Innovation                                                             |
| Peace                                              | Appreciation                                        | Resourcefulness                                                        |
| Self-Control                                       | Humility (outward)                                  | Prudence                                                               |
| Clarity                                            | Inclusion                                           | Long-Term Thinking                                                     |
| Vision                                             | Gratitude (shared)                                  | Empowerment                                                            |
| Adventure                                          | Relationships                                       | Stability                                                              |
| Creativity                                         | Compassion                                          | Learning                                                               |
| Faithfulness                                       | Diversity                                           | Meaningful Work                                                        |
| Health                                             | Justice                                             | Flexibility                                                            |
| Fitness                                            | Cooperation                                         | Environmentalism                                                       |
| Education                                          | Philanthropy                                        | Freedom                                                                |
| Resilience                                         | Harmony                                             | Purposefulness                                                         |
| Religion                                           | Empowerment<br>(of Others)                          | Sustainability                                                         |

## MY TOP FIVE VALUES

Use the values chart above to identify the five values that matter most to you. Rewrite each value below, then translate it into an action statement—a clear sentence describing how you will live out that value in daily decisions. For example:

Value: Integrity → Action Statement: “I will tell the truth even when it costs me something.”

## Decidedly Wealthy

| Value | My action statement |
|-------|---------------------|
| 1.    |                     |
| 2.    |                     |
| 3.    |                     |
| 4.    |                     |
| 5.    |                     |

### Reflection

After writing your top five values, answer the following:

1. Which of these values and actions shows up most consistently in your financial decisions? Essentially, which value do you advocate for? Which would you say is non-negotiable for you?
2. Which one do you tend to neglect when under stress?
3. How might aligning all five bring you closer to being Decidedly Wealthy in every dimension of life?

## ACTION STEPS

**Step 1:** Circle your top ten values from Chart 4.

**Step 2:** Write out your top five core values on Chart 5 narrowing down to those you advocate for.

**Step 3:** Convert each one-word value into an action phrase that can allow that value to express itself in your life.

**Step 4:** Post your value phrases somewhere you will see them.

**Step 4:** Reflect on your top five core values frequently and consistently.



KEY DECISION 2

# Decide Where You Are





## CHAPTER 6

# Your Starting Point and Money Habits

### **Day 3. Sunrise.**

We began hiking just as the sun peeked over the ridge. The chilly air threatened to turn our lips blue. I pulled my neck gaiter over my nose to make the freezing morning bearable. That made it hard to talk. We moved quickly—the promise of pizza in Mount Laguna that evening kept us motivated. Neither of us talked much for the first few hours of the morning. We spent our time blowing warm air into our palms and munching protein bars for energy. I regretted staying up so late pondering Slow Bird's words. He knew what his purpose was. He knew what he wanted the trail to do for him—provide the connection he needed.

After several miles, we approached a small lake that forced a diversion in the trail. As we approached the lake, we noticed a primitive, worn-out camp area just visible through the trees. My dad lumbered toward it. We were past due for a sit-down break, and lunch always sounds better when you are not eating off the ground. I followed him.

My dad made his way toward the brown, rotting, wooden information sign at the entrance to the narrow trail of the

small campground. Notices, rules, warnings of fire hazards, and occasional teenage graffiti covered it.

“You see that?” he asked, motioning me to come closer.

“See what?” I replied, puzzled.

“The map!” he said. He seemed amazed at my ignorance.

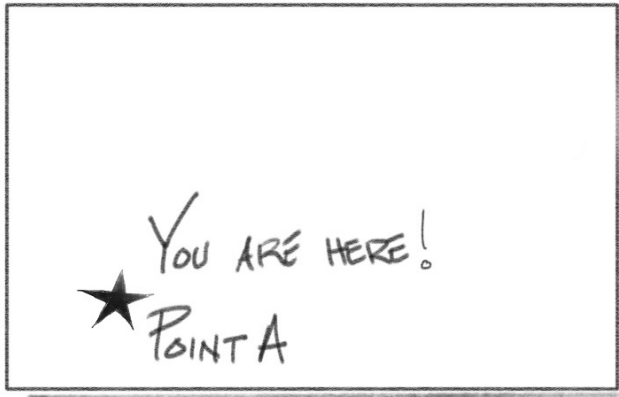
“Oh yeah, the map. What about it?”

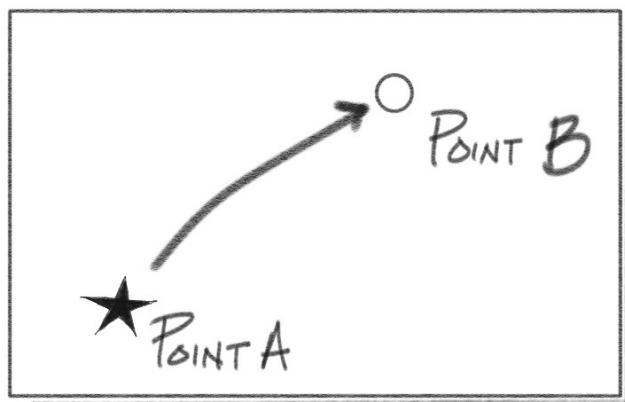
“What do you think is the most important thing on this map?” he asked. His tone signaled that a valuable lesson would soon follow.

“The lake...?” I answered. I motioned to the largest feature on the map, but unsure I was correct.

“See that little red star that says, ‘YOU ARE HERE?’” he said, thumping his pointer finger against the wood. “That is the most important thing on this map. Without the little red star, this map would have no value. You must know where you are. That’s Point A. Where you want to go is Point B. Without knowing Point A, you can’t determine the direction to Point B.”

I got the sense we weren’t talking about hiking.





## USE DELIBERATE ACTION WITH YOUR TOOLS

To become Decidedly Wealthy, you must *Decide Where You Are*. The deliberate action we discussed earlier is important here. This differs from *finding* where you are, as my dad and I did by using the map next to the lake. Rather, you must make a conscious decision.

“That is impossible!” you may say. “You are where you are.”

That is what most people think, yet that is why most people are not Decidedly Wealthy. It is rational to believe that *you are where you are*. You have the tools to achieve your goals—the money, the investments, the cash flow, the brokerage accounts, and the rest. Simply speaking, *they are where they are*. However, you can decide what those tools are, thereby deciding where you are. Those tools are your starting point, your Point A.

The decision is yours: apply them to your goals and nothing else. Prioritize what matters and direct those assets accordingly. *Decide Where You Are*.

Your cash flow has natural limits—you can't save what you don't earn. But within those limits, you must decide how much to save. Decidedly Wealthy individuals deliberately allocate a significant percentage of their income to savings before even calculating what's necessary to achieve their goals, so decide how much of your money gets saved and invested to build your wealth and achieve your goals.

During conversations with new clients, we often ask in the first meeting, “What is your capacity to save?” and “How much can you confidently and consistently save each month?” What we have found is that Decidedly Wealthy individuals already have that figure in mind. Folks who are not Decidedly Wealthy are never sure.

---

Until you *Decide Where You Are*,  
the direction you need to travel will  
be unclear.

---

The distinction: Decidedly Wealthy people commit to saving a certain amount before knowing what's actually required. Often, the figure they state is far more than needed to achieve their primary goal. What we see in people who are not Decidedly Wealthy is an extreme difficulty in identifying a figure at all—even a small figure relative to their income.

Many times, even when we figure out the amount they could save, they are reluctant to commit to it. They cannot identify an amount they can consistently save because any regular savings would mean a corresponding reduction in their lifestyle expenses. They haven't decided to save first, so any future decision to save feels like cutting

back on luxuries they've already mentally allocated. Maybe it's consumerism, maybe it's fear. Whatever it is—it holds them back.

So yes, those two main tools—assets and cash flow—are there, but you first must *Decide Where You Are*. You, and only you, get to decide where Point A is located. Until you *Decide Where You Are*, the direction you need to travel will be unclear.

Knowing where you are isn't just about your assets and income—it's about understanding the habits that got you there and will either propel you forward or hold you back. Just as we'd nearly gone on the wrong trail before checking that map, our financial habits can lead us in circles if we don't examine them.

## THE WEIGHT OF OUR HABITS

My father and I continued toward Mount Laguna after reading the map posted on the notice sign at the lake. The route we took led us up along the side of a large hill. We realized the trail ahead was actually a mile-long loop that would have wasted half an hour of precious daylight.

"Aren't you glad we stopped to look at the map?" my dad asked with a sly grin.

"Yeah, that loop would have been a big waste of time," I conceded.

Just as my father had stopped our momentum to admire his navigation skills, we heard the familiar clunking of heavy hiking boots on the gravel trail. Footsteps like those could only belong to one hiker; we knew that.

Before he moved within our sight from around the bend, my dad called out, "How's it going, Magellan?"

Magellan, whom we had met before, was the hiker who had given my dad the most confidence he could endure the long journey ahead of him. We have all met someone who has accomplished something we want to tackle ourselves and thought, if that person can do it, I certainly can. For us, Magellan was that guy. He was the type of hiker who showed up to the trail one day with a fully grown, poorly manicured, never-shampooed wild-man beard that screamed, “I’ve been here before.” He made sure you knew that, too. Give Magellan three minutes and he’ll rattle off four stories of harder, more grueling hikes.

Magellan was braggadocios in the least admirable way. That had earned him his trail name. It was given to him by a hiker who recognized him for what he wanted to be recognized for: someone who had, most certainly, been everywhere. As is always the case with folks who need the validation of others, the irony of this name—and its subtle insult—was lost on him.

“Another easy day,” Magellan boasted, despite his heavy breathing that was loud enough to have every doe within three hundred yards convinced a black bear was tailing them.

“You got any coffee to spare?” my dad said while turning to wink at me.

Magellan’s ears perked up like a dog who just heard his owner mention going for a W-A-L-K. “Of course. Do you want some?”

“Oh, not really. It’s a little late in the afternoon for caffeine. Honestly, I’m just surprised you’re still carrying it.”

Magellan stopped dead in his tracks and unstrapped his pack from his shoulders. He could not contain his excitement. In that moment, he became an annoying trope—the CrossFitter asked about his workout or the vegan preaching plant-based benefits. He reached into his pack and pulled out a full French press. It shone

as if he spent his evenings around the camp stove polishing it. He caressed the handle and displayed it like a trophy for us to gawk over—which we did not. In some ways, it was a trophy for making the hike harder than necessary—lugging two unnecessary pounds and sacrificing pack space for a morning fix that a caffeine pill could satisfy.

“You know, I just gotta have it,” Magellan said. He proudly made coffee, of all things, the cornerstone of his personality. “It’s a habit,” he continued, “and one I’m not quitting.”

It would not be long before Magellan was off the trail. His habits were weighing him down, despite how much he enjoyed them.

## YOUR HABITS AS A STARTING POINT

A while back, I decided I was going to complete two Ironman triathlons in the same month. That is 2.4 miles of swimming, followed by a 112-mile bike ride, topped off with a 26.2-mile marathon run. It was a lofty goal for someone who could not have told you the last time he had run a 5k fun run.

I learned that it would require an immense amount of planning, training, and suffering to reach the finish line twice within a few weeks of each other. After five or six months of training alone, I made the smart move to hire a coach. When I arrived at my first strategy session with Coach Jerett, I expected him to have formulated a detailed plan for my success. Just like I had expected a personalized training plan, clients expect us to present a complete investment plan before they’ve *Decided Who They Are*. It did not go that way. Personalized advice cannot go that way, whether it’s triathlon training or financial planning.

Coach Jerett started the conversation by asking me, “So, what are you doing right now for training?”

I gave him what I thought was a very complete answer. “Oh, I run about three times a week, ride my bike four times a week, and swim three times a week. I also do some jiu-jitsu too because I enjoy it.” He stared back at me and said, “No. Tell me exactly what you’re doing.” The questions came rapid-fire: miles, pace, heart rate, nutrition before, during, and after workouts. What type of bike did I have—outdoors or indoors on the trainer? What shoes did I run in? Was I doing any open-water swimming or staying in the pool?

After about half an hour of questioning, it became clear there was no end to the amount of information Coach Jerett wanted. Understanding as much as possible about my current training would allow him to create a plan that worked for me. Coach Jerett needed to know my Point A—doing exactly what my father and I do for clients: helping them *Decide Where You Are*.

I realize the importance of habits now. At the time, my understanding was inadequate. Understanding first the habits that I had made it possible to identify which ones should be removed and which ones should be improved upon. In addition, Coach Jerett could not make a plan tailored to me without first understanding what habits had worked for me initially.

Our habits can weigh us down, just as Magellan was weighed down by his habit of coffee from a heavy French press. Some habits can bring us up, like my habit of waking up at 5:00 a.m. to work out before getting started with my day. Your habits might weigh you down. Alternatively, they might be foundational to your success and thus protected within your routine at all costs.

## UNDERSTANDING YOUR FINANCIAL HABITS

Observe yourself and your behavior to determine your financial habits. If you find this difficult, talk to a financial professional.

They will know which questions to ask to draw those habits out of you.

- Do you have a habit of dipping into your savings for “emergencies” rather than planning for those expenses?
- Do you regularly consume information through media sources that cause anxiety and worry?
- How often do you check the balance of your accounts?  
Is it too often or not enough?
- Do you regularly review your financial plan?
- What expenses do you incur regularly outside of your bills and obligations?
- How often do you save?
- Do you save automatically?

## SAVING AUTOMATICALLY: THE DECIDEDLY WEALTHY DIFFERENCE

Through our work as advisors, my father and I have had thousands of money conversations. By observing Decidedly Wealthy individuals and those who aren't, we've identified the behaviors most likely to lead to success. One of the simplest and most obvious is how people choose to save. At the most basic level, there are only two ways to save money: systematically or intermittently.

Systematic saving means scheduling regular contributions—monthly, weekly, or bi-weekly—for a set dollar amount or percentage of income. Any savings that are not systematic will become intermittent as they rely on human behavior.

When we rely on ourselves to decide to save each month, we are essentially saying, “we will save when it feels right.” Saving the amount we can at the time we want.

The problem is that it rarely, if ever, feels right.

When the market is struggling, it’s easy to delay savings in hopes of the outlook appearing more promising in the future. When the market is high, it’s tempting to wait for an upcoming discount or pullback so we can jump in at a lower price. Those pullbacks often feel just around the corner, but rarely are. When our household expenses are a little higher this month because of unplanned circumstances, it’s tempting to say, “We will hold off on saving just this once.”

Intermittent saving requires thousands of individual decisions over a lifetime, hoping we never get it wrong. We must decide when and how much to save, where to place it, which goal to fund, and how to invest it. Each month, each paycheck, each bonus—every single time money comes in, we must make all these decisions again.

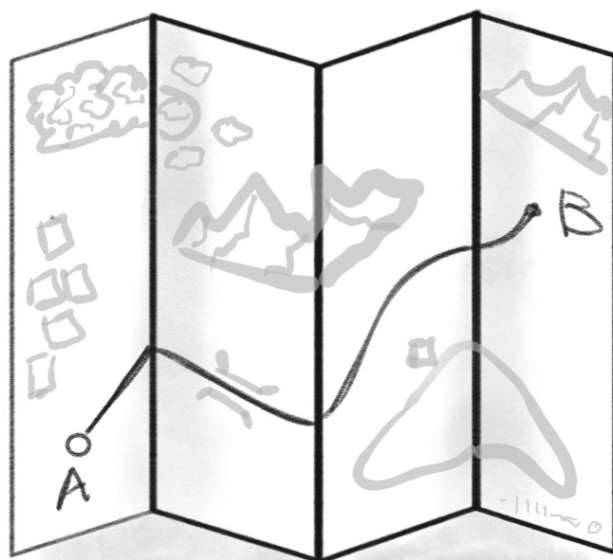
Saving systematically is one decision made at a point in time. Deciding to automatically save from your paycheck into your company’s retirement plan is a good example of this. From there, we can put our savings on autopilot until the next time we need to reevaluate our financial plan.

Save systematically so that your saving becomes a habit. Once regular saving becomes a habit, you don’t have to think about it because you do it habitually. Save mental energy from endless decisions and redirect it toward aligning your wealth with your values and purpose.

## THE POWER OF DECISION

The difference between those who achieve financial goals and those who don't often comes down to one thing: systematic habits versus chance and willpower.

You *Decide Where You Are*—when you look at that little red star on your financial map and accept it as your starting point, you gain the power to chart your course. When you understand your habits and consciously choose which to keep and which to change, you stop being controlled by them and start using them as tools.



Magellan never made it very far on the trail because his habits weighed him down more than his pack ever could. Don't be Magellan. Choose habits that serve your journey, not complicate it. *Decide Where You Are*, decide what habits will get you where you're going, and systematically execute on those decisions.

## ACTION STEPS

### 1. Map Your Starting Point

- List all your assets and their current values
- List all your debts and what you owe
- Calculate your monthly cash flow (income minus expenses)
- Decide how much you will save each month: “I will automatically save \$\_\_\_\_\_ or \_\_\_\_\_ percent of my income toward my goals each month.”
- Identify which accounts hold money for which purposes

### 2. Complete Your Habits Audit

Answer these questions honestly:

- What are three financial habits that are helping you progress?
- What are three financial habits that are holding you back?
- Which habits happened by accident versus by design?
- What is one habit you need to change immediately?
- What is one positive habit you need to protect at all costs?

### 3. Build Your Systematic Approach

Act on these today, not tomorrow:

- Set up automatic transfers of the savings amount you identified in Step 1
- Choose specific dates for transfers (tie them to paycheck or income deposits)

## Your Starting Point and Money Habits

- Schedule a recurring six-month financial review in your calendar right now
- Set a reminder one week before each review to gather your statements
- Determine what specific metrics you'll track at each review (net worth, savings rate, portfolio return, asset allocation, progress toward specific goals, etc.)



## CHAPTER 7

# What Is Your Cash Flow?

### **Day 3. Afternoon.**

After a few miles, Magellan had fallen off our tail, presumably enjoying a French-style coffee break underneath a shady cottonwood. It was tempting to spend all afternoon in the shadows. The desert heat seemed to worsen with every step. That is the tricky thing about hiking through the desert—the lack of humidity causes inconsistent temperatures. It is not uncommon for your teeth to chatter through the night only to sweat your backside off by lunchtime.

I stopped five separate times to remove layers, hoping my body would breathe and stop sweating so much. The trail was leading us toward a small patch of shade at the base of a hill. But until we reached that point, every tree worth resting under was several hundred feet below. We were fully exposed to the heat. The only weapon we had to fight it was our water, and we drank easily twice as much as we had on any prior day. In a different scenario, this would have meant danger as there are no corner stores to stop by along the PCT to buy more, Gatorade, of course. Rather, hikers must find the water on their own. Thankfully, this stretch of the trail ran close to a stream.

Several times throughout the day, my dad and I stepped off the trail, through dense thickets, and knelt at the edge of the stream to collect water. It is quite tempting to drink straight from moving water that is crystal clear and ice cold. Some hikers do. They risk drinking water that contains bacteria, viruses, and parasites that can cause severe intestinal distress—a situation that becomes remarkably inconvenient on the trail. My father and I both made it a habit to filter our water first, a habit we never broke. It was time-consuming and tedious, but the peace of mind was worth the extra effort.

As I knelt close to the water and dumped my filter bag beneath the surface for the third or fourth time that day, my curiosity about my father's comments on decision-making was reignited. I turned to him, crouching a couple of feet away, and asked, "You've been telling me about deciding where you are, that you need to find yourself on the map and understand your habits, but what else do you have to do?"

"Hmm," he grunted, almost as if I had stumped him. "Let me think about that. For now, let's walk."

I poured the filtered water from my bag into my three plastic bottles and screwed on the caps. Then I turned back toward the trail to Mount Laguna.

We had moved about half a mile, maneuvering through the curves of the trail before we stumbled upon a frightening scene. As the trail straightened out, we saw a group of four female hikers huddled together. Clearly, something was wrong. Our pace quickened as we approached the women, ready to help however we could. As we got close, we saw one woman had fallen. She lay on her left hip, propped up by her elbow, with her right hand clutching the side of her head. Two of her companions were crouching down to help.

My dad asked, "Oh my gosh, are you alright?"

“We’re okay. Thank you, really,” a tall, slender woman responded, standing a couple of feet off to the side. She held up her cell phone and then slid it back into her pocket. “I just got off the phone with emergency rescue. They should be here soon.” She crossed her arms and bit her lip.

“What happened?” I asked.

“Dehydration,” she answered. “She just didn’t drink enough water. Like I said, we’ll be okay, but we appreciate you being willing to help.”

We wished the women good luck and pressed on. My dad and I both felt horrible. Not only did that group of women have their day, and possibly their entire hike, ruined, but somebody got badly hurt. To top it off, it could have been avoided, and everybody knew it. Within fifteen minutes we saw a uniformed EMT pacing toward us along the trail, headed back to where we had been. Without breaking stride, he asked, “Did you see them? Are they this way? How much further?”

“Yes, just down that way. Less than half a mile,” I confirmed.

As soon as he passed, a powerful gust of wind exploded against our backs, and the faint chuff-chuff-chuff of helicopter rotors came within earshot. My father and I turned to see a rescue services helicopter hovering above the ridge where the women waited.

We watched the chopper until my dad broke the somber silence. In an uncharacteristically tone, he said, “You asked me earlier what else you have to do to *Decide Where You Are*.”

Wondering why he had chosen this moment to return to the conversation we’d had an hour prior, I nodded. “Yeah...”

Without taking his focus off the scene unfolding along the hillside, he continued, “You have to know how to manage your energy. We’ve been drinking consistently all day long, and we’ve

attempted to do that even though it's been hard. You can risk it and run on E, but if it goes south on you...it goes south hard."

I could not disagree with what he was saying, but its relevance to wealth still eluded me. "Sure, but what does that have to do with wealth?"

"Out here, energy comes from water and food. There's no luxury of constant supply—it must be gathered along the way to keep going. Running out leads to that," he said, pointing to the red and white helicopter still floating in the clouds. "Ending the day with surplus means we could have pushed further. Planning refueling and energy use is essential. Wealth works the same way. Decide how to use your financial energy."

## THE COST OF FINANCIAL DENIAL

Many years ago, my dad met a couple in their mid-thirties named Theo and Tammy. A friend from church had referred them, saying they really needed help. In our business, when someone "really needs help," it means they're in financial trouble.

They sat down in his office and got down to business. My dad asked what they hoped would be the biggest benefit he could provide.

"We just paid off our last credit card, so we are ready to get started," Tammy said confidently.

"Congratulations. When did you pay off the credit cards?"

"We received an inheritance from my father when he passed away. We paid off all our credit cards and still have about \$40,000 we want to invest."

"How much did you leave for emergencies and cash reserves?" my father asked.

“\$40,000. This is what we have left to invest.”

“Well, typically we would want to leave money for emergencies in something safe and available. A good rule of thumb would be three to six months of committed expenses in cash reserves. Do you have a sense of what your monthly expenses are?”

“Probably about \$5,000 per month,” they agreed after going back and forth.

“Okay, so that would mean we would need about \$15,000 to \$30,000 in cash reserves. Since Theo is the sole income earner, I recommend the conservative approach—six months. The \$40,000 you have now will allow you to set aside a good cash reserve for emergencies and still have \$10,000 left over.”

Before he could ask what was important about the \$10,000, they threw him a curveball.

“Will we still be able to get money out of the \$10,000?” Tammy asked.

“Sure, but it would change how I suggest you invest it. Tell me more.”

“Well, we use \$1,000 per month from what my dad left us. We have been taking about \$1,000 per month to make ends meet.”

“So, your cash flow is actually negative? If that’s what is happening, the \$10,000 won’t last even a year. Is this a temporary situation?”

“No. Between my income and our expenses, we are upside-down about \$1,000 every month,” Theo said, leaning back to cross his arms.

This was not going well. “Have you explored ways to improve your cash flow, like cutting expenses or improving income?”

“We can’t really cut expenses,” Tammy said.

“How about this education expense in your budget?”

“That’s the kids’ private school tuition. That’s nonnegotiable. So is our charitable giving,” Tammy responded, cutting my dad off.

“Okay, what about your mortgage costs? Have you thought about refinancing?”

“We don’t have a mortgage. We wouldn’t dream of selling the house, either. We love our neighbors, and the house my dad bought for us.”

“Have you thought about becoming employed outside the home?” he asked, instantly realizing this was the landmine he should have avoided.

“No, it’s important that I be home for the kids,” Tammy said while Theo looked down.

“Tammy,” my dad said softly, “I know all these things are important to you. But if you’re in the red \$1,000 per month, this is unsustainable. In a few years, what your dad provided will be gone. You’ll be back in debt. We have to start now by making tough decisions to get a positive cash flow.”

He was trying to help them recognize where Point A was on their map. Their cash flow was negative and they didn’t want to read the big red letters that read, “YOU ARE HERE.” Their assets were disappearing.

“What do you want this money your father provided to do for you?” he asked. They talked and prioritized. They located Point B on their map—a debt-free life with positive cash flow so they could start building wealth. Point B was rock-solid security, while Point A was quicksand.

Theo and Tammy sold their home and lowered their housing expenses while she took a part-time job that allowed her to work while the kids were in school. Point A changed and the tools for wealth became available. All of that began with locating that tiny

red star on the map representing Point A and those three words: YOU ARE HERE.

Not only should you hold some energy in reserve, like water on a trail, but hold back cash reserves for emergencies that will occur and can instantly drain your “energy” reserve. You must also get into a habit of not only assessing what your financial energy level is but also putting that excess energy toward your goals. There are people who don’t do this, and they pay a heavy price. You too will pay a price if you do not control your financial energy.

---

You too will pay a price if you do not  
control your financial energy.

---

## THE MARGIN OF SAFETY

As my father and I approached Mount Laguna that evening, we could smell pizza wafting through the air—our reward for maintaining our energy throughout the day. We had consumed nearly a gallon of water each, stopped multiple times to filter more, and eaten even when we weren’t hungry. It felt excessive, but we made it.

The woman who was airlifted probably started her day with the same amount of water we did. The difference wasn’t in our starting point—it was in our habits along the way. She likely waited until she felt thirsty to drink. By then, it was already too late. Dehydration doesn’t announce itself with sirens; it whispers that “you’re fine” right up until you’re not.

Theo and Tammy were the same way with their cash flow. They waited until they felt the pain of negative cash flow to acknowledge it. They treated their inheritance like a rescue helicopter—something to save them from crisis—rather than using it to build sustainable habits. But here's the hard truth my father shared with them that day: "The inheritance didn't create your negative cash flow. It just hid it for a while. Anything that hides your financial reality is not a blessing—it's a postponement of the inevitable reckoning."

You must get into the habit of not only assessing what your financial energy level is but also directing that excess energy toward your goals before you think you need to. The hikers who make it to Canada aren't the ones who are strongest on day one. They're the ones who manage their energy every single day, especially when it feels unnecessary.

Along the trail, my father and I purposefully drank water even when we weren't thirsty. We filtered the water even when it looked crystal clear. We ate when we had energy, not when we were depleted. These weren't acts of paranoia—they were acts of respect for the journey ahead. Those were the habits that would take us from Point A to Point B.

Your financial energy demands the same respect. Build your surplus when times are good, not when you desperately need it. Increase your income when you have options, not when your back is against the wall. Cut expenses when you have choices, not when the court orders it.

That evening in Mount Laguna, as we sat in a small restaurant, my dad said something I'll never forget: "You know what the difference is between the hikers who make it to their intended destination and the ones who get rescued? The ones who make it act

as if every mile matters. The ones who get rescued act like only the hard miles matter.”

Your cash flow is the same. Every month matters. Every paycheck is a chance to build or deplete your financial energy. Every expense is a decision about your future flexibility. You can pretend otherwise, but as we learned that day watching the red and white helicopter hover over the mountain, reality doesn’t care what you pretend.

The good news? Unlike the woman on the trail who needed a helicopter rescue, you can see your financial energy levels anytime you choose to look. Unlike Theo and Tammy, who ignored their reality until a crisis hit, you can locate your “YOU ARE HERE” star today and decide whether you like where you’re standing.

Check your financial energy. Often. Systematically. Honestly. The time to build reserves is not when you need them—it’s right now, while you still can.

## ACTION STEPS

### Step 1: Calculate Your Financial Energy

- List all monthly income sources: \$ \_\_\_\_\_
- List all monthly expenses: \$ \_\_\_\_\_
- Financial energy (surplus/deficit): \$ \_\_\_\_\_
- Savings rate: \_\_\_\_\_ percent ( $\text{savings} \div \text{income} \times 100$ )

### Step 2: Create Your Energy Plan

If in surplus: Where will you direct excess energy? (specific goal/account)

If in deficit: Identify your “Tammy and Theo” moment—what must change?

- One expense to cut/reduce: \_\_\_\_\_
- One income opportunity to explore: \_\_\_\_\_
- Target date to achieve positive cash flow: \_\_\_\_\_

KEY DECISION 3

# Decide Where You Are Going





## CHAPTER 8

# What Is Your Primary Goal?

### **Day 4. Morning.**

It was Monday morning, but it hardly felt like it. Neither of us had anywhere to be. Of course, the laminated agenda had its expectations of us, but we had learned to view that with a grain of salt by now. My dad and I were both much more efficient at packing and unpacking a campsite by this point. It was almost second nature. We could talk while we disassembled our tents without risking losing a pole or leaving behind a precious piece of food.

My dad emerged from his tent, holding his phone, with a broad smile on his face. “I found a tent site for us to sleep tonight. It’s about halfway to Julian.”

The next major stop on the route was the small town of Julian. Thru-hikers knew it as a favorite pit stop for resupply. It has everything a tired hiker could ask for: a greasy-spoon diner with obscenely large pancakes, a well-stocked general store, a hotel for weary feet, and—word on the trail—the best apple pies in California. We were a two-day hike away from gluttony.

Using his downloaded map, my dad had scouted a perfect spot for a tent site. His phone’s grainy pictures revealed a small patch of

sand at the base of a towering cliff. It was perfectly placed to block the strong winds of the night and to give plentiful shade in the afternoon. The spot was only a step off the trail and had a perfect view of the valley, toward Julian, where pie was waiting.

Before we even started walking, we had already set our goal for the day. “Did I ever tell you the story of when Pop and I went hiking up Pikes Peak?” my dad asked as I was stuffing my sleeping bag back in my pack. He was referring to my grandfather whom we both called “Pop.”

“No,” I said with an inquisitive look on my face, wondering where this was headed.

## KEEP YOUR SIGHTS ON POINT B

Dad and Pop optimistically began their hike up Barr Trail on a cool September morning, each wearing brand-new hiking boots, shorts, and matching backpacks. They were visiting Colorado Springs to celebrate the birth of my cousin, Hannah. The path to the 14,110-foot summit was wide and smooth at first, sloping as they set off on the thirteen-mile trail. The hike would lead them to the top and back again—26.2 miles total. It fooled them, and it fools many hikers into believing they were in for an easy day.

After 6.8 miles, they reached Barr Camp at 10,200 feet elevation around 11:00 a.m. They were off their thirty-minute per mile pace, but still unworried. After all, they were both fit men. Pop had run several marathons in the months prior, and Dad worked out almost daily. After a quick snack break, they pressed on.

Their muscles grew increasingly fatigued with every mile they hiked. Dad stopped to catch his breath and calculate the time once more. Shocked, he realized that their constant breaks and slowing

pace had added so much time that they were unlikely to get back to town by nightfall. With just under five miles to the summit, he figured they could make the peak by 4:00 p.m. But that meant abandoning all hope of returning before dark.

Dad swallowed his pride and pulled out his cell phone to call his sister, Stephanie. She lived in Colorado Springs and had watched the weather forecast the day prior. She had more than mildly suggested rescheduling the hike. Living up to their reputations as stubborn adventurers, they had ignored her counsel.

“Ugh, sure,” Stephanie responded to Dad’s plea for help. “I’ll drive Pikes Peak Highway and meet you at the summit at 4:00 p.m.”

As soon as Dad put the phone in his pocket, things changed. He felt tiny white snowflakes collect on his shoulders and bare legs. The next pitch of the hike was above the tree line. As they moved out from beneath the shelter of the pines, the trail hid beneath the powdery snow. Only a few minutes passed before a blanket of white covered the trail. The only way to make certain they were heading in the right direction was to keep their focus on the original goal, their Point B—the summit. Freshly fallen snow buried the path they had traveled. The only way to be sure they were making progress was to go up—toward Point B.

Each mile took longer as their pace slowed. Dad begrudgingly dialed Stephanie again with an update.

“Can you make it 5:00 p.m. instead of 4:00 p.m.?” he asked sheepishly.

This time Stephanie let it fly. “It’s snowing now! I said this was a bad idea! You guys are idiots,” she said without holding back her laughter.

“Yeah, okay, you were right,” Dad said, conceding victory to his younger sister. “How about 5:00 p.m. though?”

“I’ll see you then. You owe me.”

The snow continued at a relentless pace as Dad and Pop slowly made their way up the mountain. Every couple of minutes they drifted off the trail, forced to pause and reorient themselves. They continued to focus their eyes on the summit, their point B, now barely visible in the distance. At about 5:00 p.m. they arrived exhausted, nearly frozen, and dizzy from the altitude. Their eyes darted around searching for what they had spent hours fantasizing about—a car with heat. But the smiles and vague sense of accomplishment faded as they realized Stephanie and her car were nowhere to be found.

In mild panic, Pop muttered the obvious. “No one is here.”

Not only was Stephanie not at the summit, but they were the only two souls on the snowcapped mountain. Dad frantically dug his cell phone out of his bag and called his sister’s number again.

“Hello...” she answered, with a tone reserved for heartbreaking news.

“Hey, where are ya?” Dad said, trying to sound upbeat.

“Well, they closed the road about an hour ago because of the snow.”

His heart sank. “So... what do we do now?”

“I called the park service, and they said you shouldn’t have been up there in this weather. Basically, you’re hosed,” she told him matter-of-factly.

As Pop searched for a way inside the mountaintop observation building, his repeated backward glances said it all: *This is going to be a long, cold night.* They circled the building like people who had lost their keys but kept checking their pockets hoping for a different result. As a last resort, Pop picked up a baseball-sized rock from

## What Is Your Primary Goal?

the ground, ready to break in. As he cocked his arm back, aiming for a small window, he heard a metal door creak open.

“What are you doing here?!” a young, wide-eyed college student yelled, startling both of them. Pop dropped the rock. They didn’t know that the park service stationed someone at the observation building each night.

“Please let us in,” Pop begged.

“I can’t do that,” the young man responded, crossing his arms in the doorframe.

“Look, friend,” Pop negotiated, “It’s snowing out here. We’ve got nowhere to go; we’re wearing shorts. We can’t hike down in the dark, we’ll freeze.”

Realizing his life would be much easier if he didn’t spend the next day being interviewed by the local news, the young man lowered his arms. “Fine, but I’m not supposed to be doing this.”

Much to their relief, they were able to sleep inside that night. When they woke early the next morning, they saw a sight that few people ever see: the sunrise from the top of Pikes Peak overlooking Colorado Springs.



## FINDING YOUR TRUE POINT B

Sometimes you have to reach your goals by overcoming unexpected obstacles, even when the path forward becomes unclear. When we help people become Decidedly Wealthy, we must help them keep their eyes on Point B even when things get difficult and they lose the trail. The rewards are often greater than they imagined, and often it is the memory of the journey they value even more than the destination.

When looking at making the third key decision, *Decide Where You Are Going*, you must determine your Point B. How you define Point B needs to be specific enough to allow you to recognize when you arrive. A vague, ill-identified Point B has little chance of being reached.

---

“If this goal became impossible, would I continue pursuing my others or stop funding them so I could achieve my primary goal?”

---

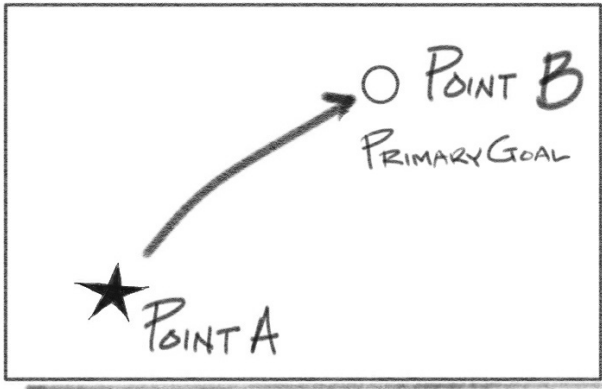
When Dad and Pop hiked Pikes Peak, their Point B was obvious—the summit. It made it easy to orient themselves toward their goal, and it was obvious when they had arrived. A vague Point B like “having more money” or “having enough” will never yield accomplishment because you’ll never know if you’ve arrived. A map never defines Point B as “somewhere over in that direction.” You will know when you have arrived at your Point B.

Your primary goal is your Point B. You have only one.

## What Is Your Primary Goal?

This goal rises above all others—it's what makes every other effort worthwhile. If you're unsure which goal is primary, use this test: "If this goal became impossible, would I continue pursuing my others or stop funding them so I could achieve my primary goal?"

The goal you absolutely cannot sacrifice is your primary goal.



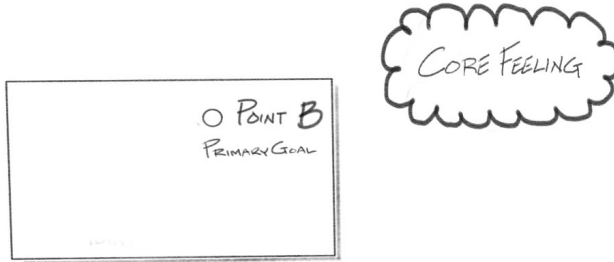
When deciding where you're going, your Point B must align with who you are. It must also be realistic and achievable from your current position, Point A.

Point B should inspire action. If it's grounded in who you truly are, it will. And if you're honest about where you currently stand, setting an achievable destination becomes simple.

Your primary goal must align with the answers from the first key decision:

- What do you want your money to do for you?
- What is important about your money?
- What would you do with unlimited money but limited time?
- What are your core values?

Primary goals often have the closest connection to having your wealth deliver on its purpose. Perhaps, for example, that could be gaining a sense of peace of mind or freedom. Your primary goal then, once defined, is arriving at the point.



## ACHIEVING THE FEELING

Achieving your primary goal is not about monetary accomplishment. To be Decidedly Wealthy, your primary goal must mean more than a simple dollar amount. It must achieve a core feeling. Sure, there are dollar amounts involved, but they are never the goal—they are a measurement of the goal.

Many people have written about SMART goals. You have probably heard that goals must be specific, measurable, attainable, relevant, and time bound. That is not only *smart* goal setting, but necessary for measuring progress. SMART goals make it possible to map out a plan, to Point B as well.

By setting goals in this way, it allows your financial advisor to do the work of calculating what you'll need to do to meet that goal. We have never had a client share a primary goal that was time-based

## What Is Your Primary Goal?

and dollar specific. The variables simply help calculate what is needed to achieve the core feeling—the true primary goal—within a specific timeframe.

Over the years, we have had clients say they would like to have a certain amount of money by a specific age. They will say something like, “I want to have five million dollars by the time I’m fifty years old.” As we dig down and answer the questions from the first key decision, such as, “What is important about having five million dollars by age fifty?” We discover that money is a marker for financial security. The five million dollars represents achievement. It’s security or a sense of achievement that are their primary goals. The core feeling is the ultimate objective. Your core feeling is your primary goal. It is your summit in a snowstorm. It *is* your Point B.

As we approached our camping spot that afternoon, the sun still hung high in the clouds. The site was more beautiful than we had imagined. It was quiet, cool, and tranquil, with the cliff to the west blocking the wind and heat from the sun. The boulders were smooth. The desert floor was so soft and inviting we decided we would leave the tents in our packs and lay out our sleeping bags beneath the stars that night.

I had spent every step of my day since sunrise dreaming of being where I was sitting at that very moment. I dreamt of lying down next to that very cliff, in that very spot of dirt, gazing upon that very valley. We had reached our Point B for the day. Yet, something my father would share with me the next morning would make me realize that arriving at Point B was never the point at all.

## ACTION STEPS

### **Step 1: Identify Your Primary Goal**

Ask yourself: “If I knew one of my financial goals was in jeopardy or no longer possible, which goal would make me abandon all the others to protect it?” The goal you cannot sacrifice is your primary goal.

### **Step 2: Define Your Core Feeling**

What feeling are you trying to achieve with your primary goal? Security? Freedom? Legacy? Generosity? Achievement? Write it down in one word or a short phrase.

### **Step 3: Make It SMART**

Transform your core feeling into a specific goal:

- Specific: What will achieving this look like?
- Measurable: What dollar amount represents this achievement?
- Attainable: Is this realistic from your current Point A?
- Relevant: Does this align with who you decided you are?
- Time-bound: By what age or date do you want to achieve this?

## CHAPTER 9

# Retiring *to* Something

### Day 4. Evening.

As we huddled around the camp stove for an early dinner, slurping spiced noodles and savoring each drop of water, my dad asked his usual question: “What was your favorite thing you did today?”

With the realization of having learned another valuable life lesson, I smirked and answered, “Listening to your stories.”

Chuckling, my father responded, “It’s funny, isn’t it? How reaching the goal is never as satisfying as the journey.” The thin tarp beneath his knees crinkled as he crossed his legs beneath him. He continued, “I felt the same way when I hiked the Camino. I spent all those days focused on getting to the Cathedral of Santiago.”

I sat my cup down on the desert sand next to me, giving him my full attention.

“Your Aunt Stephanie had joined me for the last leg from Sarria to Santiago, about sixty miles. When we finally reached Santiago, we walked straight to the cathedral. Having gotten an early start, we arrived well before mass that day. I walked around the cathedral and took it in, as it was more beautiful than I had imagined. We sat in the pews as the priest presided over the swinging of the Botafumeiro.

The giant incense burner swung two-hundred feet above our heads from the cathedral ceiling.

The fragrant smoke billowed from the incense in the Botafumeiro as it travelled back and forth across the transept of the cathedral. The priest blessed the ceremony in a mix of Spanish and Latin. Of course, I didn't know what he was saying, but I knew what was being said to me. 'Relax,' it said, 'you can have peace.' I realized I had been on a journey, but arriving at the cathedral wasn't really the destination after all. It was just a symbol of arrival. The actual destination was the transformation."

As a child, I never saw my father cry. He was too tough for that, or that's what he would have said at the time. That changed after he walked the Camino. Ever since, every so often, mid-sentence his cheeks redden and his eyes well up. Still, a tear never drops. Sometimes it happens when he recounts the plot of a poignant movie he watched. Other times it happens when he shares a heartfelt story from a speaker at a conference he attended. Many times, it happens when he recalls a meaningful moment in his life. Most often, it's when he talks about the Camino.

"I had just walked over five hundred miles," he said. "I had pushed myself from various points to a fixed Point B, but that Point B was never the 'point' at all. All I wanted to do when I got there was start over again. I wanted to learn more and to grow more. I wanted to arrive at something that wasn't a fixed destination but a transformative point of realization."

## THE REAL DESTINATION

For my dad's walk along the Camino, the cathedral was just a measuring point. The kilometers measured a distance along the path

but the journey was measured in growth and reflection. The real achievement was the spiritual journey. In a way, it was achieved by deciding to even start the journey in the first place. The cathedral was no more the walk's goal than a dollar amount is a primary goal of retirement. No more than breathing is the point of life. Necessary, yes, but not the point.

He knew that he had done something worthy and transformational. Once he arrived at the cathedral, he had no interest in resting and reveling in his accomplishment. He did not care about the certificate that was presented to him in the small building near the cathedral. What he wanted most of all was to experience that feeling again—to seek a connectedness with God and walk a

---

Your primary goal is about achieving a core feeling, not hitting a number or date.

---

path laid out for that very purpose, then take what he'd learned and share it. Otherwise, what is the point?

Your primary goal is about achieving a core feeling, not hitting a number or date. The target dollar amount and retirement date are calculation tools—they tell you what's necessary to reach that feeling. The date isn't the goal, neither is the dollar amount; they're just part of the math.

When we as financial advisors identify the point where your assets generate enough income for your desired lifestyle without running out, we've achieved a primary goal that doesn't require retirement or selling your business.



## RETIRE *TO*, NOT *FROM*

Unfortunately, many times my father and I see people who retire without having a bigger future they are moving toward. They either find themselves unfulfilled with their newfound free time or return to their old job. They return to the state that provided fulfillment. Without something you are retiring *to*, you are retiring *from*.

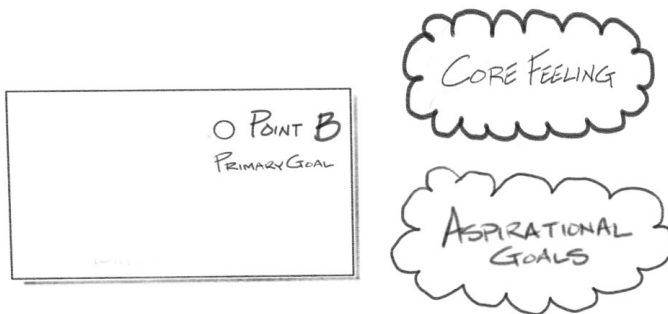
No amount of money can satisfy that primary goal or desire if you retire *from* something. Maybe that is why when my father completed the Camino de Santiago, all he wanted to do was to go back and travel it again. It provided him with something he did not realize along the way. The journey was providing him with purpose, connectedness, and an inner sense of achievement. It was transforming him.

When all of that stopped at the cathedral, there was an inescapable desire to fill the void.

## The Retirement Chart

**Try this:** Pull a piece of paper and divide it down the middle so there are two columns. On the left-hand side, write all the positive things you get from working. At first, you will probably write things like money and health insurance. Keep writing. You will keep including things like friends, challenges, learning, community, connectedness, a sense of purpose, and more. Every positive thing you write on the left side of that paper needs to be present in your life when you retire.

Label the right side of the paper “I will get these things in retirement.” You will need to have a way to provide income and to find health insurance. Equally important, though, you will need to cultivate friendships, learn, and have a sense of purpose. Every positive thing you write in the left column must be provided for when you are no longer working. We need that energy; without it, we are operating at a deficit. Once you have provided all those benefits after leaving work, you have discovered the answer to the third Key Decision: *Decide Where You Are Going*.



## THE FREEDOM OF CHOICE

Many of our clients have met their primary goal, knowing they have enough assets to provide for their lifestyle and achieve the core feelings from that goal. There's no party. No gold watch. No packing up office supplies or marching into the boss's office to give him the finger. Instead, these individuals stay where they find purpose and pursue what matters, but with more bounce in their step and a smirk on their face.

The work becomes even more meaningful because it's a choice, not a necessity. No longer slaves to income, these clients do what they want with their time and lives. That freedom is worth more than any paycheck. Meeting the primary goal feels great.

Sometimes, clients walk into their boss's office and, more delicately than Johnny Paycheck, they say, "Take this job and shove it. I'm done, see you later." They do this not to leave a bad situation, but to go toward a bigger future. They go toward their Point B.

A primary goal is reaching the point where they attain their core feelings without portfolio stress, moving toward a bigger future—retiring to something. What is that something to which we retire? That is the next phase of your journey.

## THE CONTINUOUS JOURNEY

Understanding Point B is difficult because the financial planning industry promotes a fallacy: that Point B equals retirement, some fixed destination. This begs the question, "If someone is already retired, where is their Point B?"

The problem is that Point B is a mirage. Once you reach Point B, it becomes your new Point A and you must locate a new Point B.

Similar to a false summit when hiking, what initially appears to be an end point turns out not to be once you arrive there and can see more clearly. Retiring *to* something means reestablishing your new Point B. We must create a new Point B in order to grow.

Just as my father wanted to walk the Camino again after reaching the cathedral, just as he hiked the PCT after selling his business, we all need something pulling us forward toward the bigger future. The achievement of a primary goal is not an ending—it's a graduation to a new beginning. It's not the beginning of the end but the end of the beginning. It's the freedom to choose your next summit, your next point B, not because you have to climb it, but because you want to.

That night, sleeping under the stars in the desert, I understood why my dad kept seeking new trails. Each Point B we reach reveals a new horizon, a new possibility, a new version of ourselves waiting to be discovered. The retirement industry sells you an end. Being Decidedly Wealthy means creating a new beginning.

## ACTION STEPS

### **Step 1: Complete the Retirement Chart**

Draw a line down the middle of a page. On the left, list everything positive you get from working (income, purpose, social connection, challenges, structure, etc.). On the right, identify where you'll get each of these in retirement. If you can't identify a source for something on the left, that's a gap in your retirement plan.

### **Step 2: Define Your “Retiring *To*”**

Complete this statement: “When I achieve financial independence, I will use my freedom to \_\_\_\_\_.”

This cannot be about what you're leaving (no “I won't have to...” statements). It must be about what you're moving toward. What will you create, contribute, explore, or become? This is your next Point B after achieving your primary goal.

## CHAPTER 10

# What Are Your Aspirational Goals?

### **Day 5. Morning.**

My pack was strapped to my aching back before morning light. I stumbled along the trail for half a mile before my brain joined me. Tired and groggy, a nice pour from Magellan's French press did not sound like such a bad idea at the moment. If only he had been with us.

We had slept under the stars the previous night, leaving our tents stashed in our packs. The trail nudged us awake before the morning started, so we gathered our gear and began the downhill climb before the sun rose to light the way. We were determined to make it to Julian before the diners closed and we lost our chance at a delicious pie.

By mid-morning I had developed a blistering headache which had me convinced not even the sweetest pie in all of California could soothe it. My shadow had disappeared beneath my feet before I wised up and removed my tightly strapped, now unnecessary, headlamp that was squeezing my skull. The relief was immediate. I sipped some water and scolded myself for making an already hard day even worse. Once I calmed down, I remembered why I was there.

“Hey dad,” I said, “yesterday you told me about the third decision you have to make—*Decide Where You Are Going...*”

“Uh huh,” he responded, focused on the trail ahead.

“Setting just one primary goal can’t be all there is, can it? I mean, so many people have tons of goals. What’s wrong with that?”

“There is nothing wrong with that. That’s part two. You remember Don and Nancy, right?”

## PART TWO OF YOUR POINT B

Don and Nancy had been my father’s clients for years. When Don retired from a long career at AT&T, the two of them came to meet with my dad on the advice of a friend. Don was a systems engineer, and Nancy had stayed at home to raise three kids, all of whom were grown and married now. Don was looking forward to cutting back and spending more time volunteering at their church. Nancy was excited about having Don around for more time with their grandkids.

They had been frugal throughout their whole marriage, never spending lavishly and avoiding debt. These habits had served them well and rewarded them with the means to spend their golden years however they wished.

“You two have done a nice job saving,” my father said. “What do you want this money to do for you?”

“Just make more money and not go down,” they both agreed.

“What’s important about the money not going down?” my dad asked.

“We just do not want to lose it.” They both nodded and laughed in agreement.

Again, he pressed deeper. “Of course, this may sound silly but what’s important about not losing it?”

“I guess...” Don paused. “I just don’t want to worry about Nancy not having enough.” Don had some serious health issues, and my father knew where he was going with this. “I just don’t want her to worry about anything.”

Nancy nodded along timidly, crossing her arms and hunching her shoulders, acknowledging the unspoken issue.

They were circling in on the first Key Decision: *Decide Who You Are*. After some discussion about the topic, the three of them agreed to meet again to look at the numbers and “put a sharp pencil to things,” as Don put it. As my father had already suspected, they had done very well financially. They had invested conservatively, but with even modest growth their portfolio would be more than enough to continue living by their current standards.

In fact, Don’s pension plus his Social Security would fund the entirety of their household expenses in perpetuity. The stress rate on their portfolio would be less than half a percent. They could put every dollar they owned into a money market fund, and still they would not run out of money.

During the meeting, my father guided them through the second and third Key Decisions: *Decide Where You Are* and *Decide Where You Are Going*. My father showed them some financial modeling tools and sophisticated projections. Don fired “what if” questions at my father, trying to lodge a bullet in a vital artery of the plan. He offered dozens of alternative scenarios for my father to illustrate.

“What if we lower the investment return? What if inflation is higher? Are taxes included in this illustration? What if tax rates go up?” Don was relentless.

Nancy's attention was fading as her eyes drifted from the screen and towards the various family pictures and art pieces that decorated my dad's office.

"Hey guys, let me show you something," my dad interjected, looking over to Nancy to draw her back in. "Do you see how your projected income, including the pension and Social Security, almost meets all of your expenses?"

"Yes..." Nancy responded as Don nodded along with the look of a man who had not yet recognized the breadth of his own freedom.

"How much do we have to pull from your investments to make ends meet?" my dad asked.

"Almost nothing," they responded in unison. The math was easy.

"Right, so the stress rate on the portfolio is almost nothing. This portfolio isn't stressed—it's happy. It doesn't need to work hard at all."

"Ah, but what if the stock market goes down next year?" Don asked, still determined to find a reason to continue reducing spending to the bare bones.

"It might," my dad replied nonchalantly.

"You won't need much stock market exposure to get the growth you need. Even if we invested everything in stocks—which we wouldn't—and the market dropped 30 percent, you still wouldn't run out of money. Don and Nancy, if what you want is the core feeling of 'not having to worry,' you're already there. I can't keep you from worrying, but I can tell you that you no longer need to. There are ways to secure this money and provide ongoing income for the two of you."

Don glanced at Nancy with a sly smirk—they'd clearly discussed this before, and my dad was now confirming Point B. But there was a part two.

## VALUES WITHOUT EXPRESSION

“If ‘not having to worry’ is the primary goal, let’s look at your aspirational goals,” my father said. Don and Nancy furrowed their brows, trying to understand. “What is something you have always wanted to do but haven’t done? To put it a different way, what is something you would regret not having done?” he asked.

“We’re simple people, Shawn. We don’t go in for all that fancy stuff, we don’t need fancy cars or a lake house,” Don said. Their modest assets—old automobiles and a simple home—had already made that obvious.

“Oh, I get it, but do you remember when we went through the values cards in the first key decision, and you selected your top values?”

“Sure, we do.” Nancy pulled out the notecard upon which she had written them down during their last discussion. “Let’s see, we have family, faith, helping others, relationships, and security,” she read.

“Okay, so what I find is that when we decide where we are going, it needs to align with those values. When we decide where we are going, it needs to provide a Point B that fulfills your primary goal of allowing you to not have to worry. I wouldn’t expect that after years of being frugal and cautious with your money that you’re all of a sudden going to become different and start spending lavishly like a couple of drunken sailors.” The three of them laughed at the absurdity of that scenario before my father continued.

“There are things that most people want to do but they haven’t done. I find they don’t do those things not because of a lack of funds, but because of a lack of confidence. They don’t have confidence in the core feeling they desire. They retire, but they are never quite

certain they won't run out of money. So, they continue to worry. It is uncertainty that holds them back. If you are uncertain that you have enough money for your needs, you may not give to charity and spend on experiences because you are being held back by the doubt of reaching your primary goal."

"But there is nothing we want to buy. We are content. Like I said, we aren't big spenders," Don contended while holding Nancy's hand as if the two of them had just been asked to violate their religion.

"You see those values that Nancy has written?" my father asked. "In all my years of doing this work, I have met no one who wanted to fund an aspirational goal that conflicted with their values. It may happen in the future, but it hasn't happened yet," he joked. "What I see more often is that people don't have an outlet where they can express their values. Many people have values that do not have corresponding aspirational goals which allow those values to be lived out. When that happens, there is a misalignment between the imagined self and the actual self."

"What you say is important and what you're doing is different. You are saying something is important to you, but you're not living in a way that reflects that belief. That misalignment causes a disharmony in your life, and you can't be Decidedly Wealthy without alignment. It is important to express your values intentionally. Look at your values of family, faith, helping others, relationships, and security. You have lived a life that has provided you with financial security. All the work we are doing now will help align with the value of security. The giving to your church we discussed in your budget allows you to honor your value of faith. The volunteer work you're doing is honoring the value of helping others. That will continue in the financial plan. So, what about family and relationships?

## What Are Your Aspirational Goals?

How do we create an aspirational goal with intentionality to allow those values to express themselves?”

My father paused, allowing Don and Nancy to consider the question.

## THE FAMILY CRUISE REVELATION

“As an example, you mentioned you would like to go on a cruise someday. Nothing fancy, of course.” My father smiled, poking fun at the two of them as they chuckled. “That sounds like a great idea—a nice cruise to celebrate your arrival at Point B. Now, what if you could get the whole family to join you? Spend some time with the family, with all the kids and grandkids together. You mentioned that it’s hard to get the whole family together. What about a family reunion of sorts—all of you together on the cruise?”

“Oh no, the kids don’t have that kind of money.” Nancy shook her head sternly.

“I’m not expecting them to pay for it. You would pay for it. All of it,” my father said, leaning back to let it sink in. “You could pay for every single family member to go on this cruise, pay for all the flights, all the excursions, all the silly Panama hats in every port of call and not miss the money at all! You’ve got part one nailed. You can now live with the feeling of knowing you won’t run out of money. That’s part one. What we are talking about now is part two. This gives those values an outlet.”

## RETURN ON LIFE

If we are to transform our wealth to significance, that wealth must do something more than provide us the core feeling we want in

Part One of Point B. If we are to transform our wealth to significance, that wealth must align with our values and express itself. Our wealth must be put to use. To achieve significance, your wealth becomes focused on creating a return on life rather than just a return on investment.

All we have to give is our time, talent, and treasure. However, if we give none of those things, the financial success we have achieved remains just that—financial success. It never moves toward, or transforms into, significance. To achieve significance, something must be given away. Your time is not significant unless it is given away to be shared with family, friends, or those who need you.

Your talent is not significant unless it is put to good use. Volunteering time to a favorite charity, using your talents for good,

---

Your talent is not significant unless it is  
put to good use.

---

gifting treasure to philanthropic endeavors, or spending the money to allow your values to express themselves can all move you closer to transforming wealth to significance.

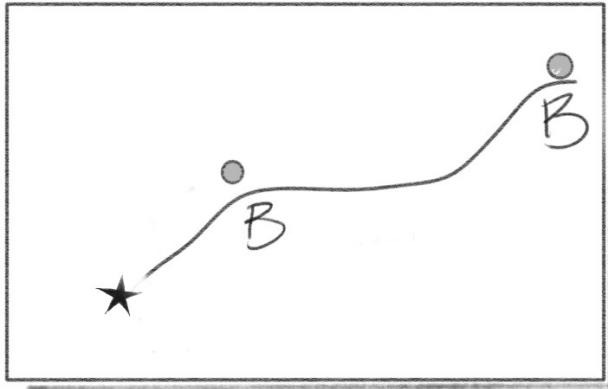
A year and a half later, my father got a postcard from Don and Nancy telling him that the grandkids loved their Panama hats. He keeps that postcard in the small wooden box in his office. After hearing his story on the trail, I remembered seeing the postcard myself when I rummaged through that box before we left to go to the airport to fly out for this trip together. I didn't know the backstory behind that card until that very moment, and I was just

## What Are Your Aspirational Goals?

beginning to realize that I was now playing a part in an aspirational goal my father had set for himself years ago.

Walking this trail with me, sharing these lessons, passing on this wisdom—this was his Part Two. It's why I was invited. His aspirational goal wasn't about completing another long hike. It was about transformation through connection, about passing values from one generation to the next, about creating significance through shared experience. The PCT wasn't just a trail for him; it was a classroom where he could teach what mattered most.

I also realized I hadn't thought about my headache in a while.



## ACTION STEPS

### **Step 1: Identify Your Values-to-Goals Alignment**

List your top five core values. Next to each, write any current goals or activities that express that value. Any value without a corresponding goal or activity needs attention—that's where your aspirational goals should focus.

### **Step 2: Define Your Aspirational Goals**

Answer these questions:

- What is something you've always wanted to do but haven't yet done?
- What would you regret not having accomplished?
- If you knew Part One (your core feeling) was secure, what would you do with your freedom?

### **Step 3: Make It Real**

For each aspirational goal:

- Assign a timeline (when will you do this?)
- Attach a dollar amount (what will it cost?)
- Identify the value it expresses (why does this matter to you?)

## CHAPTER 11

# The Freedom to Pursue Significance

### Day 5. Mid-Morning.

As we continued our descent toward Julian that afternoon and the heat began to break, I thought about Don and Nancy's cruise. They had spent their entire lives being responsible, saving, living below their means. Now they had permission—not just financial but emotional—to express their values through their wealth. But I wondered how many people never get to that point. Not because they lack money, but because they lack the confidence to use it.

There is a saying, “If you aim at nothing, you will never miss.” In chapter 6 of Alice's *Adventures in Wonderland*, Alice asks the Cheshire Cat which path she should go down. The cat responds that if you do not know where you are going, any path will get you there.

In *12 Rules for Life*, Dr. Jordan B. Peterson wrote, “What you aim at determines what you see.”<sup>3</sup> Many people aim no further than retirement. When asked about what they want for themselves beyond that day, they struggle to come up with anything. The truth of

---

<sup>3</sup> Jordan B. Peterson, *12 Rules for Life: An Antidote to Chaos* (Random House, 2018).

Dr. Peterson's statement applies to life, and especially resonates with our financial hopes and dreams.

Our financial life is a direct representation of our life. Our wealth is an extension of who we are, who we can be, who we will become, and who we will be remembered as. To aim at nothing at all for your future means to see a future that's unremarkable. A future aimed at nothing cannot be one that is aligned with your values.

---

Our financial life is a direct representation  
of our life. Our wealth is an extension  
of who we are, who we can be, who  
we will become, and who we will be  
remembered as.

---

A future aimed at nothing cannot be a future of significance, financially or otherwise. Instead, aim at the best possible realization of your core values you can imagine. Having aspirational goals creates a mindset of envisioning a bigger future for yourself.

Your pursuit of this may be clumsy at first. It may be less well-defined than it could be. That is to be expected. Still, it is far better to aim at something than to wander aimlessly through life. To hit the target, you will need to know three things.

As a financial advisor, I work with people every day to answer these three questions about their target:

- How do you define it?
- What is your timeframe?
- What will you do once you have arrived?

## WHY DREAMS REMAIN DREAMS

Remember the question my father asked Don and Nancy, “What is something you have always wanted to do but haven’t done?”

I now ask this question to my clients to help them put their target into focus. The answers vary, with responses like spending more time with family or traveling to exotic locations. Sometimes the answers are more centered on personal achievement, like running a marathon or climbing a mountain. My father and I have both found that finances are rarely the reason people do not accomplish these things.

This raises the question: Why don’t people achieve these dreams? The main reason is straightforward—most people have never sat down to figure out what those dreams even are. This question often prompts people to think beyond retirement for the first time in their lives. They’ve never asked themselves this question, and no one else has asked them either. We all get so caught up in day-to-day life that we forget to pause and think about what kind of life we want to be living.

Far from asking, ‘What is something I have always wanted to do but haven’t yet done?’ most people never *Decide to Decide*. They let the small space of time between stimulus and response pass by without a decision. To achieve your aim, you must *Decide to Decide*. Sometimes the decision is that an aspirational goal is not worth the sacrifice of pursuing. That is good. To know and then decide is immensely valuable, as it means you can now redirect your focus to another target. Having decided not to pursue a goal gives you the freedom to set your sights upon another, more focused, more precise, more significant aim for you. That isn’t failure—that is a decision!

## THE CONFIDENCE REQUIREMENT

For those who decide to pursue their original aspirational goal, the question remains: Why have they not done the things they'd regret not having accomplished? Is it because they lack the money for the big trip, the boat, or the major donation—or is it something else?

For most people who've made the previous Key Decisions, I can look at their finances and see that they could spend or donate large amounts of money if they wanted to. So what's stopping them? The answer is right there in what I just said—they should feel free to do it. Many people just don't feel like their aspirational goals are within reach. And that feeling has nothing to do with facts, numbers, or spreadsheets. The reason they don't pursue their goals isn't just because they haven't defined those goals—it's also because they're not confident about Part One of their Point B. The fear that setting a goal to achieve Part Two (aspirational goals) may negatively impact their ability to achieve Part One (core feelings).

If you retired yesterday, would you immediately book an exotic trip, buy a mountain cabin, or make a major donation? Most wouldn't—not because they lack funds, but because they lack confidence in Point B.

They retired by default, *from* something rather than *to* something. Without the security of Part One (core feelings), Part Two (aspirational goals) never materializes. The peace of mind from being Decidedly Wealthy—from answering all three Key Decisions—is missing.

Uncertainty about having enough assets makes Part Two impossible—and rightfully so. If you're not confident you can achieve your core feelings without financial worry, don't pursue the aspirational goals of Part Two. That would be irresponsible.

## Day 5. Afternoon.

The heat was waning in the afternoon by the time we arrived at the end of our hike for the day. The wind had joined us in the San Felipe Valley and provided a cooling, comforting breeze. I had not paid enough attention to the map, though. As we emerged from the hills and entered the valley, I expected the heart-of-Americana town of Julian to be there waiting to welcome us with open arms and warm coffee.

In its place, I saw what looked like a homeless encampment where a handful of hikers had pitched tents way off in the distance next to a two-lane blacktop highway. It wasn't until we approached the other hikers that I cared to ask my father, "Where is Julian?" I knew this could not be the town every hiker spent their first five days on the PCT dreaming about.

"It's down the road a bit," he said, pulling out his phone to check how far "a bit" was. He didn't acknowledge what I was worried about—which was that at this hour, there was no chance we'd make it to any town before all the diners and convenience stores we needed were closed for the night.

After thumbing through several versions of the same map on his phone and checking the agenda he had prepared months prior, he lifted his head up, looking west along Highway 78. He said, "It's about twelve miles that way," motioning to the nothingness that stretched out before us.

Deflated, I lost all hope of rewarding myself for a long day's hike with a delicious pie. Walking twelve miles along a highway seemed dangerous, of course, but we would need at least three hours. By then, Julian would be shut down for the night. Not to mention the three-hour hike back, in the dark, even if we were lucky enough

to stumble upon a restaurant that was open. I was “hiker hungry,” but I’ve never been “walk twenty-four miles in the dark just for a chicken fried steak” hungry.

My dad’s silence was not providing the answers I was looking for. After all, this was his plan, so I was prepared to have a snotty attitude and wait for him to tell me what we were going to do next. I barked in an ungrateful tone, “Well, what are we supposed to do now?”

Throughout my life, my dad prepared for every possibility. He always seemed to know something I didn’t. My dad dropped his backpack off his shoulder and let it fall to his feet. He unzipped a small exterior pouch, reached in, and pulled out a white, laminated piece of paper that he had kept rolled up with a rubber band. He peeled the rubber band off, unraveled the paper, and held it facing toward me.

“PCT HIKER TO TOWN,” it read in bold, black letters beneath the official PCT logo.

“Hitchhike,” he said with the smile of an adventurous man who had found the rationale for doing something unnatural to the two of us.

“Wait a second... So we’re just going to wait here and hope that a random stranger is nice enough to drive us to town and then pray that they don’t murder us and steal our stuff?” I said.

“The PCT forums online all talk about hitchhiking from here. Hitchhiking is common on the trail, apparently. The local people along the trail are familiar with PCT hikers. Most of them really enjoy helping. We’ll be fine,” my dad said. He held his chin high and focused on the road as he talked. I could tell he wasn’t faking his confidence.

## THE UNLIKELY ANGEL

Frankly, I had no other option but to trust this plan anyway, so I relented as we both began the awkward reverse walk, with our thumbs pointed out. For half an hour we shuffled along the road, trying to make eye contact with drivers who were trying not to look at us as they barreled past. Each vehicle forces a gust of wind in our faces like a slap of rejection.

We didn't speak much, each of us too busy in our own minds pleading with God to let anyone have mercy on us now. It wasn't long before I began suggesting changing directions and returning to rest underneath the Highway 78 overpass instead. We traded quick, skeptical glances with raised eyebrows for several minutes, neither wanting to be the first to admit this wasn't working.

Only a moment later, a beat-up van heading east and away from Julian slowed on the other side of the road. The silver-painted wagon had not met a car wash in its long life. Years spent driving through the desert had built up what appeared to be a permanent layer of brown dirt on the bottom half of the vehicle. Grime and filth hid the original manufacturer's color selection, giving the van an appearance that could only be described as "muck."

The missing hubcap and myriad of unrepaired, significantly sized dents didn't inspire trust; neither trust for our own physical safety nor trust that this vehicle could make it twelve miles without breaking down. Without looking at each other, my dad and I both hid our pointed thumbs behind our backs as if to say, "God, I didn't literally mean any car."

The driver cranked his window down, stuck his arm out, and made an exaggerated circling motion to let us know he was turning around.

“That guy is going in the opposite direction. Why is he turning around to pick us up?” I asked, knowing that this was a question my father could not answer either.

The man’s appearance paired perfectly with his vehicle. He was burly, with an unkempt chest-length beard, a decades-old tan t-shirt, and a dirt-stained brown hat. He put no more care into his own physical cleanliness than he did into his car’s. The same thin layer of desert dust that clung to the sides of the van seemed to cover the man himself. I could tell my father was as hesitant as I was about whether we should accept the ride at all, despite our hunger and desperation.

“You guys headed to Julian?” the man asked, now on our side of the westbound road.

“We sure are!” in unison we responded, as the man’s warm eyes erased our inhibitions instantly.

“My name’s Ghost,” the driver said over his right shoulder as he pulled back onto the highway. At first I thought I must have misheard him—his voice was muffled by his huge, wild beard full of wiry brownish-gray hair that hid his mouth.

“Why do they call you Ghost?” my father asked.

“That’s ‘cuz ya never know where I’ll be. Don’t like to be in one place too long. I just show up where I want.”

Ghost didn’t need to ask if we were hiking the PCT. Even without our very professional hitchhiker sign, that much was obvious. There was no reason anyone would be crazy enough to walk along that highway lugging around oversized backpacks if they weren’t planning to spend night after night along the trail. The normal hiker-and-townie small talk questions began.

“When did you start hiking the PCT?” “Where did you start from?”

“Are you thru-hiking or section-hiking?” All the questions each hiker answers multiple times a day.

Ghost then gave us updates on the trail. He shared where we could find water, how the weather was likely to change in the next few days, and what to expect as we continued our journey. As we pulled into Julian, he continued, pointing out the local hotels and places where we could get supplies. It was obvious from his rehearsed, confident cadence he wasn’t sharing this information for the first time. He rattled off the information and packed advice into each sentence with the eloquence of a man who gave this presentation multiple times a day.

Oh, I see what’s happening here, I thought to myself cynically. This old dude is picking up hikers and taking them on a quick, forced tour for tips. I bet he does this all day long and hits people up for money to make ends meet.

“Ghost,” my dad said, threading the needle between skepticism and polite conversation. “Do you live here in Julian?” He expected the man to live right in town and to be hustling a few bucks a day from unsuspecting hikers for rides.

“No, I live in San Diego.”

“San Diego?! That’s gotta be over an hour drive, at least,” my dad responded.

“Yeah, I drive up here and see if I can help hikers like you guys get back and forth from the trail. It’s a long way into town from where I picked you up.”

My father and I shared a side-eyed glare of discomfort and disappointment as we figured this could only mean the price of our shuttle ride had gone up dramatically.

“Why do you drive so far from home just to pick up hikers?” Dad asked, doing a mediocre job of disguising the real question: “Don’t you know you could drive for Uber in San Diego?”

## THE REAL TREASURE

“Well, I retired several years ago,” Ghost began, no longer in his familiar tour guide cadence. “Before I retired, I used to hike this trail a lot. I was hiking the PCT when I got hurt. Messed up my ankle pretty bad. Never could really hike again, ya know. I never made it as far on the PCT as I wanted to go. I guess doing this lets me stay connected to the trail. The people on the trail are the best folks you’d ever want to meet. I’m just happy I get to stay in touch with that.” We sat in silence as Ghost pulled the rickety van into a parking lot next to Mom’s Pies. “This is where I let you boys out!”

I walked around to the trunk to retrieve my pack as Dad dug through his pockets to find his wallet.

In a deep, booming voice he reserved for business meetings and men he respected, Dad extended his right hand and bellowed, “Hey Ghost, thank you so much! Let me help with the gas money. It must get expensive driving all the way out here,” while holding a crisp twenty in his left.

“Oh, hell no. I don’t need the money,” Ghost said forcefully, appearing to be offended. “If you want to help, donate to the community center when you get to Warner Springs in a couple of days. They do a lot for hikers and could use the money. I’m just fine.”

Stunned, Dad adopted a much softer tone. “But we want to help with gas money or something. You’ve been so nice to give us a ride. We’d still be waiting if it weren’t for you.”

“Boys, this is what I enjoy doing. If I wanted money, I’d still be working.” Ghost’s smile now emerged from beneath his thick beard. “Good luck on your hike, boys,” he extended his right hand for handshakes.

His sandpaper palms gave me a blister all on their own. Calluses like these only come from years of working with tools, fixing and building, and building and fixing. I squeezed with all the might my forearm could muster yet still felt weak.

It wasn’t the aggressive handshake of an ego-driven lawyer on the golf course, trying to prove dominance and protect his fragile superiority. It was a bone-crushing embrace with a man who did not recognize his own strength—neither physical nor spiritual.

“We’re going to need a ride in the morning back to the trail. Are you going to be back near the Stagecoach Trail RV park?” Dad asked, hoping that we wouldn’t be forced to lug ourselves along four miles of boring highway the next day just to get back on track.

“I might be, I might not be. I don’t much like to tell folks where I’ll be ‘cuz if I do, then I gotta show up. So, ya never know. That’s why they call me Ghost.”

“Well.” With a sly smirk, Dad threw out a Hail Mary. “Could we pay you to pick us up?”

With a sharp exhale through his nostrils and a short, polite, one-syllable chuckle, Ghost gave us the answer we knew was coming without ever speaking a word. He paused for a moment and then revived his commanding cadence. “No, but if you don’t wait too late, you can probably hitch a ride back to the trail before sunset. Don’t leave town without trying the pie, though,” Ghost demanded, still donning that burly grin.

Dad and I filed in line with the army of hikers and townies descending upon Mom’s Pies, each jostling to get their first choice of

flavor before provisions ran thin late in the afternoon. We snagged a table in the back corner next to a family with small children who had chosen to spend their spring break escaping to the countryside from Los Angeles.

“Is this pie really good or are we just starving?” Dad mumbled with a mouthful of sugar-soaked apples.

“Both,” I answered, without even for a moment considering the blood sugar crash I would experience within the hour. That was a problem for future Sanger. For now, I was enjoying my arrival at my personal Point B, the place and experience I had been planning for and thinking about for days.

## THE SURPRISE RETURN

Rather than stay in Julian, we stuck to our agenda and thumbed our way back to the raggedy RV park. It seemed like a great decision for Dad during the planning stage to save money and be closer to the trail in the morning. Unfortunately, it meant a four-mile walk before sunrise on a deserted blacktop road to get back to the wilderness trail.

The next morning before sunrise, we began the depressingly-long trek along the roadside. There is something soul crushing about walking on pavement. By this time, our fitness had improved, giving Dad and I the confidence we could saunter twenty miles a day through the desert without a second thought. Despite that, a singular mile along the pavement felt like torture. There’s something about this that’s familiar to every hiker. Something happens when that layer of asphalt separates our feet from the earth. It erodes the spirit of the journey. In every way, both literally and metaphorically,

it creates a separation between the hiker and the nature he wants to connect with.

In the early morning light of day six, far-off headlights approached as we walked. We moved off the road to let the driver pass. As the lights moved closer, a dirty van slowed until it rolled to a stop next to us.

“You boys need a lift?” Ghost said with a smile.

## ASPIRATION DOES NOT EQUAL COST

Aspirational goals don’t have to come with aspirational price tags. Of course, every aspirational goal costs something in terms of time, talent, or energy—everything has a cost. What I’m saying is that just because the Decidedly Wealthy framework calls Part Two of Point B aspirational doesn’t mean it has to be financially out of reach.

Like Ghost, lots of people find significance by pursuing aspirations that don’t cost much money at all. Ghost could have retired and dreamed about building a vacation home on a beautiful beach. His goal of shuttling hikers is no less worthy because it didn’t cost a million dollars or require financial planning.

It still required a plan, though. It required him to understand his own values and what significance meant to him. He was giving away his precious time to others—his gift of time was significant.

Ghost had achieved his Part One—he had enough money not to need to work. But more importantly, he had confidence in that security. That confidence freed him to pursue Part Two, his aspirational goal of staying connected to the trail and serving the hiking community. He didn’t need our twenty dollars because money wasn’t the currency that mattered to him anymore. Connection was. Service was. Being part of something larger than himself was.

His aspirational goal aligned with his values. He valued the trail, the hiking community, and being of service. His daily drives from San Diego weren't a burden—they expressed what mattered most to him. That's what happens when your aspirational goals align with your values: What looks like sacrifice to others feels like purpose to you.

As Ghost dropped us back at the trailhead that morning, I realized something profound. Don and Nancy would find their significance through giving their family experiences. Ghost found his significance in giving hikers something they needed—help from a stranger. Both were transforming their wealth—whether money or time—into something that mattered. Both were achieving returns on life rather than returns on investment.

The difference between Ghost and so many retirees we meet isn't the amount of wealth they have. It's that Ghost had clarity about both parts of his Point B—his financial destination. He knew Part One was secure—having enough to sustain his chosen life—which gave him confidence to pursue Part Two: aspirational goals that would create significance and meaning.

His Part Two wasn't about impressing anyone or checking boxes—it was about expressing his values in the most authentic way possible.

That's the secret: Part Two goals don't need to be expensive, impressive, or make sense to anyone. They just need to align with your values and give you a way to transform whatever wealth you have—time, talent, or treasure—into significance.

## ACTION STEPS

### **Step 1: Test Your Confidence in Part One (Your Core Financial Security)**

Before pursuing aspirational goals, honestly assess: Do I have complete confidence that my primary goal is achieved—that my assets will sustain my chosen life? If not, what can I do to achieve that confidence?

This might require running projections, stress-testing scenarios, or having a conversation with a trusted advisor.

### **Step 2: Define Your Aspirational Goal (like Ghost)**

What aspirational goal could you pursue that costs more in time than money but would create significant meaning? Think beyond financial aspirations to how you could use your time, knowledge, or presence to create significance.

### **Step 3: Create Your Aspirational Goal Timeline**

For your top three aspirational goals:

- If you had confidence in Part One (your core financial security—having enough assets to generate the income you need without running out of money) today, when would you start?
- What's preventing you from having that confidence?
- What will you do this month to move closer to either achieving confidence in Part One or beginning Part Two (your aspirational goals that create significance and meaning with your wealth)?



KEY DECISION 4

# Decide How You Are Going to Get There





## CHAPTER 12

# How Heavy Is Your Pack?

### **Day 6. Early Morning.**

The clumsy shuffling of sleep-deprived hikers rummaging through nylon backpacks woke me. Sleeping with nothing but a thin foam pad between my backside and the cold, rocky earth made drifting deep into the comfort of my unconscious nothing but a dream. I didn't notice the birdsong until this morning. Birds sang as I woke, marking both my physical awakening and my philosophical breakthrough about true wealth—how money transforms into significance.

Our meeting with Ghost the previous afternoon and the stories my father had shared with me throughout the week all swam within my soul and mind. I couldn't stop thinking about everything this journey was revealing to me.

As was the case every morning, by the time I emerged from my sleeping bag, my dad had been waiting, wide-eyed and antsy to start the day. That was my dad's superpower and his curse. I often joked that he had an unfair advantage over his competitors in business. "Well, of course you're successful! Everyone else sleeps."

He had always been a light sleeper. His curse was that he could never fall back asleep. His superpower was that he never missed an opportunity to put even more focus into his business and craft. However, that superpower was useless on the trail. There was no work to be done, no business to lead. Walking until we could not walk any longer was the only thing on the agenda. Each day, the schedule stayed the same. I could tell it ate away at him—to have such fiery energy, yet no field in which to let it burn freely. He was learning, though. Learning to breathe. Learning to sit. Learning to walk.

I grabbed my backpack by its straps and hoisted it over my shoulders. I grunted as the deep tissue pain within my shoulders reignited. Carrying the load of everything I needed to survive for the five days prior was taking a toll on me. My father couldn't help but notice me slumping and slowing down. Despite my efforts to put up a hardened, tough façade, my struggle was obvious.

“Come with me,” he ordered as we both lugged our bags. Without a word, I followed him towards a silver Airstream trailer that overflowed with hiking gear a couple hundred yards away. He had been up for a while and knew right where we were going. A local couple offered hikers resupply and equipment upgrades from an old trailer—perfect for anyone whose gear failed week one. At this hour we had no expectation of seeing an open sign in the window. But I had learned well enough by this point not to question my father's guidance, especially when he was silent.

My father stopped underneath a tall hackberry tree, its branches thin enough to sway with the wind yet strong enough to be useful to us in this moment. A spring scale hung from chains tied to a branch overhead.

“Drop your backpack,” my dad said. He pointed both with a glance of his eyes and a nod of his head toward the large silver hook hanging from a scale.

After just six hundred feet, my pack was already unbearable. I slipped out of the shoulder straps and hung it on the large metal hook. My father and I watched as the scale’s red indicator spun almost a complete circle before stopping at twenty-seven pounds. Unlike my father, I hadn’t researched gear or consulted experts, so twenty-seven pounds meant nothing to me. Without speaking, my father answered that question for me by removing my bag from the scale’s hook and replacing it with his own. This time, the dial moved far less violently before stopping at nineteen pounds.

Geez! I didn’t need to be a backpacking expert to interpret that dramatic difference. An eight-pound weight difference seems small. But eight pounds adds up fast when you’re taking forty thousand steps a day for weeks or months. Now I understood why my dad could hike longer and farther every day, why he wasn’t grimacing or stopping hourly to readjust his pack. His light load let him smile all day instead of counting down the miles. My father’s pack was just two-thirds the weight of my own.

He noticed the realization on my face as I understood the root cause of my suffering, then spoke for the first time in several minutes. “When I walked the Camino, Summer joined me in Pamplona,” he said, referring to the time he and my younger sister walked through Spain together. “It was my first long-distance journey,” he continued, “and I had brought a lot of things with me. Things I thought I needed. I brought extra clothes, supplies, duplicates of things in case the first one broke, and so on.”

“Why would you bring so much extra stuff?” I asked.

“I didn’t just pick random supplies on a whim because I thought I might need them. I researched thoroughly. I read articles and watched countless YouTube videos. I brought gear that other, more experienced people recommended to me. It wasn’t long before I realized that there was so much I didn’t need. There were things just weighing me down.”

By this time, my father and I were walking along the trail again, with our packs on our backs. That meant my shoulders were screaming again, and my snippy attitude had returned.

“Okay, so what did you do about it?” I asked, hoping that there was some sort of fancy way to carry my backpack that would magically make the extra eight pounds disappear.

“Summer and I stopped in this little town of Estella along the Camino and went to the post office near the town square. I sat outside the post office and just unpacked everything on the sidewalk. I laid out everything that was not important to me. I set aside all the extra weight to lighten my burden, then I shipped all that junk back home in a box.”

“Were you worried about getting all that stuff back? I’ve never shipped something that far. I would be afraid I’d never see it again,” I said.

“You know, when that package arrived back in Texas, I never used any of it. I gave it all away. After all, it was full of things I didn’t need. I didn’t care either way.

Moving toward my goal without unnecessary weight felt good—I didn’t miss what I’d left behind.”

## WHAT IS WEIGHING DOWN YOUR WEALTH?

This experience radically changed my father's and my philosophy on investment management. We thought differently. Just as my dad shed weight on the Camino, we stripped portfolios of complexity, expenses, and tax drag. We began to examine investment solutions to find things that were weighing clients down. We asked, "What are investors carrying with them in their own "packs" financially and emotionally that are not helping them move closer to where they want to be?" The more we studied, the more answers we found, finding more opportunities to lighten the burden. We sought lower cost exchange-traded funds over specialty mutual funds and even began using individual stocks where appropriate to lower expenses even more. Sometimes, we were shocked to discover how much unnecessary expense the average investor carries in their portfolio.

Here's what we concluded: The more exotic and complex an investment, the more it costs. In many cases we found that added expenses were not delivering enough extra return to justify that cost. It's like my father carrying a French press on the Camino "just in case he found good coffee beans." The weight wasn't worth the unlikely benefit.

We found that investors were paying high fees for investments that performed no better than the overall market. We also found investors paying taxes they need not have endured. They were weighed down with tax inefficiency.

## THE WEIGHT OF COMPLEXITY

As my father and I built portfolios focused on fundamentals, we discovered something troubling. Many investors think they're diversifying their portfolios, but their investments move in lockstep with the market, anyway. We wanted our clients to carry only what they needed—just like how my father streamlined his backpack in Spain. We found many investors owned strategies so complex they couldn't even explain them. Worse, these investments promised protection during market crashes but failed when people needed them most. Just look at 2008 to see how most investments reacted the same way, to the surprise of many investors.

Just as unnecessary expenses can weigh down a portfolio, unnecessary complexity can do the same. The cost of this baggage does not appear on an investor's statement, nor is there an associated dollar amount corresponding with the weight of excess complexity. This complexity weighs investors down by producing returns that do not meet investor expectations.

## INVESTORS' MENTAL BAGGAGE

Many investors carry weight that is far less identifiable than excess expenses and complex strategies. Their journey toward their Point B—the financial destination they'd like to arrive at—is weighed down by a burden they never realized they carried.

As we helped clients eliminate their excess baggage, we found that some of our own conversations carried unnecessary weight. As average consumers in Western society, we get an inordinate amount of mental garbage thrown onto us designed to instill fear, uncertainty, pessimism, hopelessness, and an array of

negative emotions. It's those negative emotions that compel us to turn on the news again and again.

People carry so much mental garbage that weighs them down. I've watched clients obsess over elections, certain that one candidate will destroy the economy, forgetting that half the country supports that person. They want me to predict how barely proposed tax bills will affect the markets. They get worked up about sensational news stories that are just clickbait.

I started redirecting these conversations. Away from the excess baggage and back to what mattered: transforming wealth into significance...becoming Decidedly Wealthy.

## THE BURDENS WE CARRY

Back on the Camino, one thing my father unpacked on that sidewalk in front of the Estella post office, but then returned to his pack, was a baseball-sized limestone rock. He placed the heavy rock back into his pack even as he searched for anything else that could go into the box to be mailed home. He searched for things that would lighten his burden but carried the rock for another 287 miles until he reached Cruz de Fierro.

At Cruz de Fierro, pilgrims leave stones brought from home, piling them at the base of a tall iron cross like a congregation gathering for a sermon. Carried from around the world by travelers on their transformational journey to Santiago de Compostela, the stones will never reach their destination. For pilgrims walking the Camino it is a significant moment to release both a physical and mental burden as they place the burden they've carried for so long at the base of the cross.

If we decide to, we can lay those burdens down. They represent the burdens we carry from Point A to Point B. In some cases, they are the burdens that keep us from discovering Point A or even dreaming of Point B. They represent burdens we may recognize when we address the first Key Decision: *Decide Who You Are*. We can decide to lay some of those burdens down and walk away. We can continue walking along our journey. Continue walking to our Point B, lightened by the decision to remove the excess baggage that was just making it harder to get there.

## THE LIBERATION OF LETTING GO

That morning, after discovering my pack weighed eight pounds more than my father's, I had a choice. I could continue suffering in silence, letting pride keep me from admitting I'd packed wrong. I could instead learn from his experience—even though I couldn't do anything about the extra eight pounds until the week was over.

For the remaining days of our journey, I carried those eight unnecessary pounds. Each step reminded me: Did I need three shirts when one would dry overnight? Was the extra battery pack worth two pounds when I barely used my phone? Why was I carrying a thick novel when I was too exhausted each night to read?

The irony wasn't lost on me when, on our last day as we prepared to leave the trail, my father handed me a few items from his own pack. "Can you bring these home with you?" he asked sheepishly. Despite his transformative experience in Spain, despite teaching me this very lesson under the hackberry tree, here he was—still carrying things he didn't need. I realized even the best lessons need

to constantly relearned. We can know something, even teach it to others, and still make the same mistakes.

Eight pounds. That's all it was. But over those seven days, those eight pounds meant thousands of extra foot-pounds of effort. Hours of unnecessary pain. Energy that could have been spent enjoying the views instead of adjusting straps. Joy was replaced by suffering, all for things I didn't need. And there was my father, the teacher of this lesson, handing me his own excess baggage on the last day. Perhaps he was teaching me the lesson again.

Your financial life is no different. Every excess fee compounds over decades. Every unnecessary complexity creates anxiety that steals your peace. Every piece of mental baggage—the market predictions,

---

Every unnecessary complexity creates  
anxiety that steals your peace.

---

the political fears, the comparison to others—weighs you down on your journey to Point B. And like my father and me, you might relearn the same lessons, catching yourself with the same unnecessary burdens you thought you'd already learned to put down.

But here's the beautiful truth my father taught me that morning under the hackberry tree, even as he was still learning it himself: You can recognize the weight anytime. You can examine what you're carrying and decide what serves your journey and what's just weight you've been carrying because you always have. Sometimes you can put it down; sometimes you have to carry it a while longer. But the recognition itself is the first step toward liberation.

## Decidedly Wealthy

The birdsong I noticed that morning? It had always been there. I just couldn't hear it over the noise of my struggle. Once I understood what was weighing me down—even if I couldn't lighten my load—I could hear the music that had been playing all along. Becoming Decidedly Wealthy means carrying *only* what matters—staying light enough to dance toward significance, not trudge.

## ACTION STEPS

### **Step 1: Examine the Weight in Your Pack**

Gather an inventory of your financial life and investments.

### **Step 2: Simplify**

What is something (an expense, a subscription, a credit card, or an account) you can eliminate or combine that no longer serves your purpose?

### **Step 3: Release the Weight**

Eliminate the dead weight. Give yourself a deadline.

### **Step 4: Realign**

Look at your aspirational goals and make sure you are specific how they will be funded. Will it be with time, talent, or treasure?



## CHAPTER 13

# Who Is with You?

### **Day 6. Late-Morning.**

We had climbed into Ghost's old van, grateful to skip the road walk. We bumped along in dirt-stained seats for several minutes as Ghost drove. But when he stopped, he didn't drop us right at the trailhead. He left us near it, sort of. There wasn't a clear trailhead sign; we could only see the shape of the trail up on the ridge above us. This left us with an impression of where we needed to go. We could see our Point B up the mountain.

"Let's just go straight up," my dad said, looking at the steep hillside. I nodded in agreement, figuring we could bushwhack a shortcut through the brush.

Big mistake.

Walking without a trail is a hundred times worse than walking with one. We knew where we wanted to go, but we were unsure of how to get there. Every step was rocky and uncertain. We second-guessed ourselves. It took us an hour to go half a mile—which is a ridiculously slow pace.

There wasn't a single moment of joy in that hour. No stopping to admire the view. No pointing out interesting plants. Just pure, exhausting struggle. When you're on a trail, you don't have to think about where your foot goes next. When the path is unclear you

can't enjoy the journey. When you're making your own path up a cliff-side, all you can think about is not falling.

Here's what I learned that morning: Trails exist for a reason. They weren't designed by a committee of trail engineers. Instead, they emerged over time because thousands of hikers before us figured out the best path. The trail is where it is because that's the easiest way to go. When there's no trail somewhere, it's because there's no good way through.

This matters for your money too. Sometimes people think they're so unique that they need to blaze their own financial trail. They think the normal rules don't apply to them, or that this time is different! But just like hiking without a trail, going it alone with your finances is exhausting and dangerous.

## FINDING THE RIGHT GUIDE

After scrambling up to the trail, gasping and sweating, my dad told me another story from the Camino de Santiago in Spain.

"I was walking alone through the countryside and I barely spoke the language," he said. "It was my first day, and it was still dark; so it took me a while to realize I had made a wrong turn, which meant I had to backtrack. I was following a trail I'd never traveled, going to a destination I'd never seen. I was yet to learn the nature of the trail. My only comfort was the tiny yellow shells painted on walls and posts that marked the way."

He paused to catch his breath after our climb.

"Miles later, I came to a fork in the road. The guidebook was useless. Someone had laid sticks pointing left. Someone else made a sign pointing right. I went left, hoping for the best."

“A few miles down the way, I met an older gentleman coming from the opposite direction. He could tell I was a pilgrim. He said, ‘Buen Camino,’ which means ‘walk well.’ I tried to ask him where the next town was in my broken Spanish. He gave me a long answer, pointing way off to the left. I understood nothing except that the town was way over there and I was lost.”

My dad smiled at the memory.

“When I asked where we were on my little paper map, he saw I wasn’t getting it. He patted his chest and motioned for me to follow him. We walked. Mostly in silence because he spoke no English, and I barely spoke Spanish. We walked about two miles to a small village. At a corner, he stopped and pointed to a yellow shell painted on a building. The trail marker. He showed me where we were on my map.”

“Then he did something I didn’t expect: He turned around and started walking back the way we came. This whole time I thought he was going in my direction. But instead, he’d walked two miles out of his way just to help me. Then he walked two miles back.”

My dad looked at me. “His name was Santiago. That’s what we’re called to be for our clients. When they start a new phase of life, when they don’t understand the rules or the language, when they’ve never traveled that path before—we should be there to guide them. To walk with them. To point out the trail markers. Even if we have to go out of our way.”

## NOT ALL GUIDES LEAD YOU WHERE YOU NEED TO GO

But not everyone who offers to guide you knows the way. A couple of months ago, a young couple came to see me. A friend who said

they needed help had referred them. They walked into our office with a plan already in mind.

“We need to raise capital for our business,” the wife said.

“We make physical products. We need money to grow. So, the more products we make, the more options we have.”

“Okay,” I said. “But why? What’s the growth for?”

They looked at each other. “Well... to grow. Everyone says we should grow.”

“In what way?” I asked.

“We need to offer more SKUs.” This is retail talk for different products. “We need more options.”

“But why are you doing this?” I pressed.

Silence.

They didn’t get it. They’d jumped straight to, “How do we raise a million dollars?”, without ever asking if they should. Without asking who they were as a company. Without knowing where they were. Without deciding where they wanted to go.

This happens all the time. People skip the important questions and jump straight to the solutions.

“What investment is best for my kid’s college?”

“What stocks should I buy?”

“Should I buy a rental property?”

But they never back up and ask: Why are we doing this? What are we trying to accomplish?

It’s like someone saying, “I want to hike the PCT; tell me the fastest way.”

Well, maybe the shortest route isn’t the point. You might want the view, a spiritual experience, to bond with friends, or simply have time to spare. I don’t know. But without asking the right questions, you’ll end up on the wrong path.

## THE QUESTIONS THAT MATTER

My dad and I met a lot of hikers on the PCT. The conversations are always the same: “When did you start?” “How far have you gone?” “Where’d you camp last night?” “What kind of pack are you using?” They were all about the “how.” But hardly anyone asks the most important question: “Why are you doing this?”

Some people don’t know. They’ve never thought about it. They just started walking because it seemed like the thing to do. Some go to find themselves without realizing you don’t find yourself, you make yourself by deciding. It’s the same with money. People come to us and say, “I’m retiring.”

---

The real value of a guide isn’t the answers they give you. It’s the questions they ask.

---

“Why?” we ask.

“Because I’m sixty-five.”

“But why do you want to retire?”

“Because I can get my pension.”

That’s not a reason. That’s just a fact. It’s not often we hear thoughtful answers about personal growth or moving on to a new phase of life, about what they want to do next. It’s just a countdown to relief: “I can stop doing this thing I don’t like.”

An excellent guide helps you understand the *why*. Why are you taking a month off to hike five-hundred miles? That answer will determine whether you stop at the cathedrals along the way, whether you pray in the chapels, what you see, and who you travel with.

This shapes your entire experience. If you're there to make friends, stay in the group camps. Explore the towns. If you're not, then none of that matters.

The real value of a guide isn't the answers they give you. It's the questions they ask.

## WHEN GUIDES KNOW THE WAY

My dad likes to tell another story about having an experienced guide. A few years ago, he and my mom climbed Mount Kilimanjaro. They hired a guide for an eight-day trek.

"On day three or four," he told me, "we hiked up to about fifteen thousand feet elevation, then dropped back down to twelve thousand. I was frustrated. Why did we climb all that way just to go back down? We had to get to the summit at nineteen thousand feet. Now we had to regain all that altitude."

"But everybody in our group of ten made it to the summit. You know why? Our guide knew what he was doing. He took us up high on purpose so we could come back down and acclimatize. He didn't even explain it at the time because that's just what you do. And we all felt stronger when we got down lower. We were ready for the final push."

"I read later about a woman who tried to do it in five days to save time and money. She got altitude sickness and had to be rescued by helicopter. When you have a guide who tries to shortcut things—especially when you don't understand the process or the nature of the journey, your odds of success drop."

## RECOGNIZING WHEN SOMETHING'S OFF

Sometimes you end up following the wrong person without realizing it. My dad learned this the hard way on a winter hike in the mountains. After a snowstorm, the trail near his campsite was buried. He couldn't see the path, but he found footprints in the snow. Someone had come through earlier that morning. Relief! He then followed those footprints for about two miles.

But something felt off. After hiking for some time, you get a sense of the trail. You notice how it flows through the mountains, the rhythm. These footprints didn't feel right.

He stopped, pulled out his phone, and checked his GPS map. He was nowhere near where he needed to be. The person he'd been following wasn't even on the trail. Were they lost too, or going somewhere different?

The return trip added four miles to an already sixteen-mile day. But my dad's anger wasn't directed at the hiker ahead—it targeted himself. Following those footprints was his choice. Map-checking had ceased. Attention to his location had slipped.

When you're working with a financial advisor, it should feel right. They should know where you want to go and should have been there before and know the way. If it feels off, it most likely is.

**Here are the warning signs you're going the wrong way:**

- Do they skip understanding who you are and jump straight to products?
- Does talking about your finances feel like applying for a mortgage—all numbers, no story?

- Are they focused only on the dollars and cents, and not on your wealth's bigger purpose?
- Are they rushing to the *how* before exploring whether you're financially and emotionally ready?
- Are they assuming your kids get everything without asking what legacy means or looks like to you? (Or worse, never ask at all!)

Good advisors are like good wilderness guides. They ask about your experience. They check your gear. They have a plan for where you're going and how to get there. They set a manageable pace. They make sure you're accomplishing your vision for the journey. Most importantly, they ask why you're on this journey.

## THE ONGOING JOURNEY

The encounter with Santiago on the Camino was a one-time thing. He helped my dad find the trail, then disappeared. But financial guidance isn't a one-time thing.

As a new advisor, I once asked my dad how long a client needs to be guided through the Five Key Decisions. "Six months? A year?"

My dad laughed. "The rest of their lives. You don't finish these decisions. You keep making them. As you grow and change, your answers change. Where you are changes. You may change, too. It's an ongoing process that stays active as long as you do."

That young couple who wanted to raise capital? They realized they didn't need to quadruple their business. They wanted what I call a lifestyle business—something that expressed who they were and let them live the life they wanted. The effort and sacrifice of

massive growth wasn't something they were prepared for because it was a far cry from their dream life.

It was like catching someone at mile one of a mountain climb who thought they were going on a nice nature walk. "The view's great up there," they'd been told. But nobody mentioned they'd need experience, proper gear, or training to reach the summit. Nobody asked if they even wanted to do the hard work to climb a mountain. Sometimes the best thing a guide can do is help you realize you're on the wrong trail, then help you rejoin the best path for you.

## ACTION STEPS

Find a knowledgeable and trusted advisor who can guide the way.

Ask yourself:

### **Question 1: Do they understand your Point A?**

- What are your values?
- What's important about your wealth?
- What do you want your wealth to do for you?

### **Question 2: Do they know where your Point B is?**

- Can they help you figure out if Point B is recognizable, realistic, and achievable?
- Have they helped identify what you're going toward, not just what you're leaving behind?

### **Question 3: Do they have the right experience?**

- Have they been there before themselves or with other clients?
- Do they know the way?
- Will they walk with you along the journey or just point the way?
- Do their values align with yours?

**Question 4: Are they exploring the right decision?**

- “Why are you doing this?”
- “What do you want to accomplish?”
- “What’s important to you?”



## CHAPTER 14

# Are You on Your Own Path?

### **Day 6. Afternoon.**

We'd been hiking for hours. There was nothing good or bad about the day—it was just a slog with nothing noteworthy to see or terrible to complain about. My dad developed a habit of checking his downloaded trail map at every landmark. He'd calculate how many miles to the next spot and knew how many minutes we'd need to get there. It was comforting hiking with someone like that. You knew where you were going, which meant you knew you were on track.

Then I saw him check his phone and throw his head back in frustration.

“What?” I asked.

“I didn't check the map back there, and now we're on the wrong trail. We veered off somehow. We missed our turn. I didn't check my map.”

“How far back?”

“Two and a half miles.”

He didn't wait to discuss it. He just started walking back the way we came. After a long silence, he laughed. “Well, let this be a lesson! Check the map.”

## CHECKING YOUR FINANCIAL MAP

When we meet with clients, we spend a little time looking at past performance and net worth growth. It's nice to see how far you've come. But that's not the real value. The real value is figuring out where you are now and looking forward. Are you on track? If not, what do you need to do to get back on track? Has your destination changed?

**Here's what you're looking for when you check your financial map:**

- Where do I stand?
- Am I on track?
- What should I be doing differently?

What you're not checking is the daily ups and downs of the market. I've had clients ask me how the market was doing at the beginning of a 10:00 a.m. meeting. That's like measuring a thousand-mile hike with a ruler. Focus on long-term performance to make sure you're on track for your goals. Don't make long-term decisions based on short-term noise.

## HIKE YOUR OWN HIKE

There's a saying among hikers: "Hike your own hike."

When my dad first heard it, he thought it meant mind your own business. Don't tell other people how to live their lives or hike their trail. That's good advice. But he wasn't hearing all the wisdom wrapped in those simple words.

He learned the deeper meaning the hard way. He'd been hiking for a few days when he met a group of hikers about twenty-five years younger than him. They'd all stayed in the same town and met at the trailhead the next morning.

"Come with us," they told him. "We're taking an alternate route. It's beautiful and much better than the regular trail."

They were convincing. Since he was having a good time with his new friends, he went with them.

As my dad tells it, they set a brutal pace. He was speed-walking to keep up while they talked and joked around. They'd mentioned the alternate trail would go around the snow-covered mountain rather than over it. What they didn't mention was that it would drop two thousand feet down and then climb two thousand feet back up through rugged terrain on a rarely used, and poorly maintained, side trail.

At the bottom, halfway through the day, my dad waved them on. "I want to get some photos," he told them, "...don't want to hold you up."

They scrambled up the trail like mountain goats. He waited, then slogged his way behind them. The uphill climb was horrible. He'd slide back two feet for every three feet forward. Fallen trees blocked the trail. There was nowhere to camp. No way out of the canyon, and he had to continue well into the night.

It had been dark for hours when he found a place to set up his tent. As he lay there exhausted, he realized the other meaning of "hike your own hike." It's not just about staying out of other people's business; it's about knowing yourself. *Deciding Who You Are*. Knowing the experience you're trying to create and not letting others dictate your journey.

My dad had been unclear about his goals, focusing only on avoiding disaster—an icy fall down a snow-capped mountain. Allowing well-meaning hikers to influence his pace came naturally. The desires were there: introspection, flexibility, freedom from group pressure. But acknowledging them, even to himself, hadn't happened.

The next morning, the young hikers were miles ahead of him. Good for them. They were hiking their hike. From then on, he hiked his.

When he told me this story, he said something that stuck with me: “I realized I was throwing away all my ‘whys.’ I wasn’t getting the entire purpose of *why* I wanted to do that hike in the first place—reflective time, being in nature, thinking through things. I was throwing all of that away just to keep up with other hikers. And I was ruining their hike too. They wanted to knock out twenty-five miles a day.” He had forgotten his first three decisions, and it was impacting the fourth, which was to decide *how* he would be hiking.

He paused and smiled. “They left me little gifts along the trail, though. Little notes and signs. It was nice. But I needed to get back to the solo hike I’d originally intended.”

## THE ONE-LINE BUDGET

Just as hikers tell you which trail to use, everyone has opinions about budgeting or investing. “Track every expense!”

“Categorize every dollar!”

“Use this app!”

“Follow that system!”

It’s like those young hikers telling my dad he had to take the alternate route—well-meaning advice that missed what he needed.

People always expect us to put them on a detailed budget. They come in ready to confess their spending sins and receive their financial punishment. But here's what my dad and I have learned after thousands of client meetings: Decidedly Wealthy people don't use traditional budgets. They've found their own trail.

Traditional budgets are like someone else's hiking pace—they might work for them but be wrong for you. My dad could have kept up with those twenty-five-year-olds for a while, but it would have been out of alignment with his desired journey. Similarly, you might follow a restrictive budget for a month, but it won't last.

Instead, we tell our clients to hike their own financial hike with what we call the one-line budget. Just one line: The amount you need to save to reach your primary goal. That's it. Save that amount first, then spend the rest however you want. No categories. No tracking apps. No guilt.

Think of it this way: those young hikers had their style—fast, aggressive, twenty-five miles a day. My dad had his—reflective, steady, sustainable. Both got where they were going. Neither way was wrong; they were just different journeys on the trail to the same destination.

I explain the one-line budget to clients with a junk food analogy. "I don't want to eat too much junk food," I tell them. "So my rule is simple: No junk food in the house. But unlimited junk food outside the house."

Sounds weird, right? But it works—for me. It's my trail.

Nine times out of ten, I eat no junk food at all. But every few weeks, I'll stop at a gas station and buy two fudge rounds. My wife makes fun of me: "Really? Two?" But it's been three weeks since I had any junk food. If I want five, I can have five. Some days I go crazy. But I never bring it into the house, so it never becomes a habit.

The same principle works with money. As long as you save your target amount each month, I don't care if you spent \$250 on a manicure. I don't care if you bought first-class tickets to Albuquerque. There's no judgment. Save first, then spend. You're hiking your own hike.

When you feel too constrained, you rebel. Just like my dad trying to keep pace with those young hikers—eventually, he had to stop. If he'd kept trying, he would have quit the trail. That's why the one-line budget works. You have total control over everything except that one sacred number—your savings. It's sustainable because it's yours.

Here's the thing: People will judge you for this approach. "You don't have a budget? That's irresponsible!" They're like hikers

---

Hike your own hike means finding the financial path that you'll stay on, not the one everyone says you should use.

---

who insist there's only one right way to hike the PCT. But you're not hiking their hike. You're hiking yours. And if your way gets you to your destination—if you're saving what you need to save—then your way is the right way.

The detailed budgeters will reach their goals their way. The one-line budgeters will reach their goals their way. Just like those young hikers blazed ahead on their trail while my dad found peace on his. Different paths, same mountain. Different methods, same financial independence.

Hike your own hike means finding the financial path that you'll stay on, not the one everyone says you should use.

## WHEN THE MARKET IS YOUR MEASURING STICK

My dad worked with a rancher named Fred, who'd sold mineral rights for a huge payday. He was set for life. We built him a conservative portfolio—only 25 percent stocks, the rest in bonds and fixed accounts. It was perfect for someone who valued security and didn't need big returns.

The problem was that Fred was obsessed with the stock market. He'd benchmark his entire portfolio against it, even though he only had a quarter of his money in stocks. His coffee shop buddies would brag about their returns. The news obsessed over every market move. So Fred did too.

If the market went down, he'd call. If the market went up, he'd worry he was missing out. Finally, my dad had to level with him.

"Fred, you're comparing yourself to something that doesn't even know you exist. The stock market isn't aware that you're competing with it. You have only twenty-five percent exposure to stocks. Your portfolio won't perform like the stock market because it's not supposed to."

Fred was like my dad, trying to keep pace with those young hikers. He'd chosen a conservative trail—one designed for steady progress and peace of mind. But he kept looking over at the aggressive trail, watching other hikers sprint past, wondering if he'd made the wrong choice. He hadn't made the wrong choice. He'd just forgotten why he'd chosen his trail.

His coffee shop buddies were hiking a different hike. They needed growth. Fred needed security. They could afford to lose. Fred couldn't. Yet every morning over coffee, Fred measured his careful, steady progress against their aggressive sprint.

“You chose your trail for a reason,” my dad reminded him.  
“Stop looking at theirs.”

## WHEN COURSE CORRECTIONS ARE NEEDED

Sometimes you realize the path you are on will not reach your destination. Maybe circumstances changed. Maybe you weren't as committed as you thought. That's normal. But you need to adjust. There are only four ways to change a goal when the path isn't working.

**One: Change the timeframe.** If you want to retire at sixty-two, push it to sixty-five. The more time to save, the more time for investments to grow.

**Two: Change the target dollar amount.** Maybe that dream retirement lifestyle costs too much. Could you be happy with less? If a private school isn't working financially, would a state university be okay?

**Three: Change the savings rate.** This one hurts today. Eliminate another less important goal and allocate those funds differently. Tighten the belt. Save more. Sacrifice now for the future.

**Four: Change the investment rate.** “Let's just assume higher returns!” This is a trap. Don't do it. Of course, if your portfolio is underperforming what it should do then you must fix that. If your cash accounts aren't getting the best rates, then fix that! Keep in mind that taking more risks doesn't guarantee more return. It might mean losing more. This is the only solution that could make things worse.

Usually, it's a combination of the first three that gets you back on track. The key is checking your map regularly so you catch problems early.

## STAYING ON YOUR PATH DURING STORMS

During COVID, the stock market dropped 33 percent in thirty-three days.<sup>4</sup> We'd never seen anything like it. The entire world was locked in their homes and the economy was frozen. Many people wanted to bail on the market. While my clients never said this, advisors all over the country were hearing, "I want to sell everything, go to cash, and get out."

I compare it to hiking the PCT during a thunderstorm. Do you think it's going to storm for the rest of your hike? No, you know the sun will come back. But will it rain tomorrow? Maybe. You don't know.

Here's what happened with COVID: It was one of the worst financial thunderstorms of all time—in the morning. By dinnertime, metaphorically speaking, it was sunny again. By the end of the summer, the market was back above where it started. By year's end, it was up 16.3 percent from January.<sup>5</sup>

Many people at 10:00 a.m. that morning were screaming, "I want to go home!" But that wasn't the appropriate response. You can't pack up and hide in your tent every time it rains. It's going to rain sometimes. That's part of the journey. As Annie sings, "the sun will come out tomorrow." The narrower your focus, the more the daily noise matters. Will it rain next Tuesday? I don't know. Fifty-fifty, maybe. Will it rain every day for the next

---

<sup>4</sup> Scorr R. Baker, "The Unprecedented Stock Market Reaction to COVID-19", Becker Friedman Institute, University of Chicago, White Paper, June 2020.

<sup>5</sup> "U.S. Stocks in 2020: A Year for the History Books." *Reuters*, December 30, 2020. <https://www.reuters.com/article/business/us-stocks-in-2020-a-year-for-the-history-books-idUSKBN29513J/>.

six months? Probably not. The wider your view, the clearer the picture becomes.

It's the same with investing. How will the market do today? No idea. This week? Don't know. This year? Two out of three years it's up. This decade? Historically speaking, it'll be positive.

## THE RULE OF 61

Here's something interesting we learned from the College for Financial Planning. They call it the Rule of 61. If you say you're going to retire at age sixty-one or younger, you will.<sup>6</sup> My dad always said he'd sell his business at fifty-five. He did.

But for every year above sixty-one that you say you'll retire, you'll retire six months earlier. Say you'll retire at sixty-two? You'll probably retire at sixty-one and a half. Say seventy? You'll probably retire around sixty-six.

Why? Because it's hard to conceptualize risk that's twenty-five years away. When I tell someone they need to work two more years or they'll run out of money in their late eighties, that seems far away. The risk doesn't feel real.

Nobody ever works longer when their plan falls apart. I had a client who needed to work until sixty-two to afford to stay in his house forever. That was the plan. That was the deal. Then he bought the house next door to expand his yard, spending \$800,000.

"Now you'll need to work longer," I told him.

But nobody ever does. People don't adjust. They anchor to an age and stick to it, regardless of reality. You don't hear from people

---

<sup>6</sup>David M. Blanchett, "The Impact of Retirement Age Uncertainty on Retirement Outcomes," Retirement Insight and Trends Newsletter, January 19, 2020, <https://retirement-insight.com/the-impact-of-retirement-age-uncertainty-on-retirement-outcomes/>.

when they lose, when they get sick, or when they're going broke. Our society sanitizes itself of those experiences. We push those people to the hospitals, the nursing homes, and the poverty housing where we don't have to see them. That's why you need to check your map; to catch the problems before they become unfixable.

## WHAT DECIDEDLY WEALTHY PEOPLE DO

After years of watching successful clients, here's what my dad and I have noticed Decidedly Wealthy people do:

Being Decidedly Wealthy is a durable, calm state of financial sufficiency earned by living below your means, keeping debt low, holding real cash reserves, and investing for decades—while tuning out market noise, comparisons, and impulse moves. It means operating from a mindset that transforms wealth into significance.

## OUTWARD SIGNS OF BEING DECIDEDLY WEALTHY

Being Decidedly Wealthy isn't only a mindset you hold quietly inside. It shows up. It comes through in the way you move through life, in the choices you make, and in the energy you give off. You can spot it. There's something steady and intentional about people who live this way. They move differently—financially, relationally, and emotionally. Here's what that looks like in real life:

### **1. Calm, Not Flashy**

They don't need to prove they've made it. There's a calm confidence in how they handle money. They are in control,

not controlled by it. They choose peace over posturing. You won't catch them chasing trends, bragging about deals, or panicking over markets. Their wealth feels settled, not fragile.

## **2. Clear Decision-Making**

They move with clarity. Every “yes” and “no” comes from a deep sense of what matters. Whether it's a business deal, a donation, or a vacation, their choices are guided by “why”, not “what if.” They don't get lost in hesitation because their direction is already clear.

## **3. Generosity Without Agenda**

They give freely, joyfully, and without keeping score. Not to impress or to feel guilty, but because giving feels like flow. They know money is energy, and energy stagnates when it's hoarded. They give to people and causes that expand impact, not ego.

## **4. Intentional Time and Relationships**

They are rarely too busy. They've taken charge of their time by aligning their commitments with their values. Their calendar actually reflects what matters most. They know who matters and they show it through presence, not just promises.

## **5. Contentment Without Complacency**

They are grateful but not done growing. They've learned to appreciate what they have without losing their drive to become better. The chase for more has been replaced with the pursuit of meaning.

## **6. Purpose in Prosperity**

For them, money is a tool, not the mission. Wealth funds creativity, impact, and legacy. Their goals sound different. They talk about meaning, contribution, and legacy, not just returns and revenue.

## 7. Emotional Centeredness

There is a steadiness to them. Market swings, business setbacks, or comparisons don't shake their sense of worth. They see wealth as stewardship, not status. Their peace comes from alignment, not luck.

In short, Decidedly Wealthy people radiate clarity, calm, and conviction. They don't necessarily have more. They simply use what they have better. They've mastered the rare art of directing wealth instead of being directed by it.

## HIKE YOUR OWN HIKE—REALLY

“Hike your own hike” means two things. First, mind your own business. Don't worry about what others are doing with their money. If someone else is spending differently than you would, that's not your concern. Don't tell other people what to do.

But it also means don't let others tell you what to do. When people try to tell you how to spend or save, that's their problem. Your behavior upsets them? That's their business. You don't even need to engage with it.

Your journey is yours. Your goals are yours. Your values are yours.

The problem is, most people don't know what journey they're on. They're following someone else's footprints without checking if those footprints lead where they want to go. They're comparing themselves to others who are on different journeys.

Fred comparing his conservative portfolio to the stock market was like my dad trying to race those young hikers. They weren't even playing the same game. They wanted to crush miles. He wanted

time to think. They wanted to prove something. He wanted to discover something.

Once my dad understood that, he could hike his own hike. Once Fred understood that, he could stop worrying about the market and focus on his own journey, a journey toward security and peace of mind, not maximum returns.

Check your map regularly. Make sure you're on your path, not someone else's. And remember: The trail that's right for someone else might be wrong for you.

## ACTION STEPS

### **Step 1: Check Your Map**

Measure progress toward goals, adjust the goals or plan if needed, and review on a set schedule (about every six months).

### **Step 2: Simplify Your Budget**

Pick your one number (monthly savings target), automate it, stop tracking every expense, and spend what's left.

### **Step 3: Stop Unhelpful Comparisons**

Remove negative influences, ignore market noise and benchmarks, and focus on your own long-term journey.

### **Step 4: Make Necessary Adjustments (if you're off track):**

- Change the timeframe.
- Change the dollar amount.
- Change the savings rate.
- Don't fall for the fourth option (assuming higher returns).



KEY DECISION 5

# Decide Who Matters





## CHAPTER 15

# Did You Leave a Trace?

My dad's Pacific Crest Trail research covered risks, physical preparation, equipment, and how to respect the natural surroundings.

There was an acronym that kept showing up in online chats and on social media: LNT. He figured out that LNT stood for "leave no trace." The idea: leave no trash, disturb nothing, and avoid camping on fresh vegetation that could be flattened. Some areas where he had hiked even required visitors to pack out bodily waste. (Yes, that means what you think it means).

It struck my dad that so many people are living their financial lives to LNT. Perhaps not intentionally, but because of a failure to plan, and to consider that if we don't plan to leave a trace, we may not leave one at all.

Years ago, my father spoke to a group of fellow financial advisors at a conference in Miami. There may have been two hundred people or so in the room. He opened his remarks by asking how many people remembered their great-grandfather. As expected, some of the hands went up. Then he asked how many knew his name. Not what the family called him, but what his full legal name was. A portion of

the hands went down. Then he asked how many knew what he stood for and what his values were. Most of the remaining hands went down. Then he asked “How many of you realized there were four of them?”

They all laughed, but the point had been made: Without intentionality, we could leave no trace. In a generation or two, the values we held dear, the causes we cared about, may not be known to our heirs, who may not even remember our real names. It’s a sobering thought, but it can motivate us to leave a positive trace.

---

Without intentionality, we could leave  
no trace.

---

## WHEN WEALTH DISAPPEARS WITHOUT A TRACE

My dad learned this lesson from his own family’s experience. When he was growing up, he and his father would travel together, driving from their home in Dallas north to my great-grandfather’s farm. It’s a neighborhood where the city of The Colony is today, part of the sprawling DFW metroplex.

At the time it was out in the middle of nowhere. My dad remembers thinking that his grandfather was the wealthiest guy he knew. He had a restaurant and bar near Love Field Airport, and when they would visit the farm, he had chickens, cows, and peacocks. There was a barn, hay bales, and a tractor, and my dad,

his sister, and cousins would play. The place felt magical to a young boy—expansive, abundant, successful.

My dad remembers when his grandfather passed away, they settled the estate, and he thought about that years later when he was in college. He started wondering: Where did his grandfather's wealth go? When he was a little kid, he remembered thinking that his grandfather had more money than anybody he knew. Maybe he did. But where did it go?

The answer is that it's still there. The wealth is still there, but it's in other people's hands. The land that my dad played on—land that is worth millions today. His grandfather doesn't own it anymore. Nobody in our family does. When people familiar with the DFW area hear this story, they're shocked. They assume our family must have a massive trust fund if my grandfather once owned that much land in what's now The Colony. But we don't, and we never did. The tractor is rusting away in some other field somewhere, owned by strangers. We spent the money that my great-grandfather gave to my granddad, and it was absorbed into our family's day-to-day expenses long ago. It all went away.

He had no plan for passing his wealth to loved ones or sharing what he knew and cared about with others. None of that wealth, those things, or his values got transferred to people that he cared about. All the physical and spiritual wealth—including what would now be a multi-million-dollar piece of prime Texas real estate—dissipated.

Truthfully, my dad doesn't even know what was important to his grandfather. He doesn't know what he cared about, because his grandfather never had a plan to pass on that part of his wealth—his values, his purpose, his passions—to the next generation. The restaurant isn't even there anymore. The farm isn't there anymore.

It's all gone. My great-grandfather left no trace. But there's something worse than leaving no trace—leaving the wrong trace.

## THE UGLY ALTERNATIVE

One time my dad was hiking outside of Los Angeles and came down a trail along a river where someone had spray-painted graffiti on a large boulder. They had left a trace, and it infuriated him. How could someone want to deface natural beauty and leave an ugly mark on an otherwise unblemished wilderness? This person violated the Leave No Trace philosophy and had left a trace of an ugly blemish for those that followed behind them.

My dad has met no one who would want to leave an ugly blemish as their legacy, but he has met plenty of people who are living a life to leave no trace. They don't answer the question posed in the first section of this book: Who am I? If you can't answer that question and the attending details, it is difficult, if not impossible, to create a trace worthy of leaving.

There's a saying: Plant green beans, get green beans; plant corn, get corn; plant nothing, and you don't get nothing—you get weeds. If we fail to imagine what our legacy should be and to create it to be left with intentionality, we won't leave nothing. We could in fact leave weeds or a blemish just as ugly as the graffiti on that trail outside Los Angeles.

So how do we create a legacy worthy of leaving? How do we leave a trace intentionally? The first step toward creating a worthy legacy is understanding what's important to us—the work we did in Chapter One. When writing up a will or an estate plan and addressing “who gets the stuff,” you first must answer the question,

“What stuff do I have?” It is no different when preparing to leave your legacy.

I’ve told clients over the years that my purpose as their advisor is to help them find the greatest and highest purpose for the wealth they leave behind. That includes both their physical wealth and spiritual wealth, such as values and purpose.

## THE HUNDRED-YEAR QUESTION

A while back, my father met with Paul and Sarah to build their financial plan. They talked about what they wanted to accomplish and what concerns they had. They worked through the first four Key Decisions and then tackled the fifth. By this time, he knew they didn’t have any children. They had both been retired for a few years, although Sarah was still working part-time to have some “running around money,” as she liked to put it.

Dad asked them what they wanted their money to be doing in one hundred years. They looked at him as if he were crazy.

“We don’t plan on being around that long!” They laughed.

“But your money will be,” he said. “What do you want it to be doing?”

Well, we have it written up to go to each other first, then to my brother and his wife, and the rest to Sarah’s sisters,” Paul said.

“Oh sure, but that’s not what I asked. I asked what you wanted it to be doing, and you told me who it was going to. That’s a different answer. What do you want it to be doing?” Dad asked again.

“That’s a good question, but I don’t know,” Sarah said.

Paul and Sarah discussed their responsibility to use wealth for a greater purpose. The money would outlast them, that much

was certain. Their identified values pointed the way: helping others, faith, health, friendships, security. Retirement was secure. Running out of money wasn't a concern. The real question: How could their wealth help others, now and in the future?

They mapped out a one-hundred-year plan. The funds they had would be needed for another thirty years or so, they reasoned. The following seventy years became more of a challenge to figure out. Without natural heirs, they thought differently. Their siblings, who were all about their same age, were doing fine financially, and didn't need the money.

They remembered a mission trip with a group from their church that had been life-changing for them.

"I don't know why we didn't think of this before. We give to this charity every year!" they exclaimed.

"Would they notice if you stopped giving? Would it be a big deal to them?" my dad probed.

"Oh, absolutely!" Sarah said.

"Why not set up an endowment with your estate to continue the funding that you are doing? We could establish an account with your estate to fund the annual giving when you are done using the money." He paused, giving them a chance to think after posing the idea.

"You mean when we kick the bucket?" Paul chimed in, laughing. "That would be great!"

They created a fund that would receive their retirement accounts at the second death, directing funds to charity and avoiding the taxes siblings would have faced. The fund would pay an annual distribution to the charity in their name for years beyond their passing. There would be no doubt where their money went

and what it was doing long after they were done with it, even one hundred years from now.

## WHAT DO YOU WANT YOUR MONEY TO DO WHEN YOU'RE DONE WITH IT?

This is the question my father asks clients who are ready to think beyond their own lifetime. The answer that he always gets is a list of beneficiaries. "I want it to go to my grandkids. I want it to go to my school. I want it to go to my church." And he has to remind them that that's not what he asked them.

He didn't ask them who they wanted the money to go to. He asked what they wanted the money to do. It's an open question. What good do you want it to do? What purpose do you want it to serve? What significance do you want it to have?

It's a different question than the easy answer of naming beneficiaries. If you get people thinking about that question, then the next logical discussion is: What would be the hundred-year plan for this money? If you can answer the question and decide what you want this money to do when you're done with it, then how long do you want it doing that? Just five years after your death? A month? How about longer?

And if you want it longer, then there are different solutions that ought to be put in place to effect, if you can. If that's something that's important to you. And it's not important to everybody. But there are people who've answered this question in a very thoughtful way. My dad has a client who established a scholarship for kids from the elementary school where she taught. He has another who created a scholarship for young women who wanted to go into nursing. He has scholarships set up for people who want to

foster dogs. These are endowments that are set up that are funding annual gifting in line with what people cared about.

If you said, “I’d like to help veterans transition back to civilian life,” we could build an enduring program that extends your gratitude for generations.

Even if you’ve decided what you want your money to do and who you want it to help, there’s another player at the table who gets a say: the government. But here’s the thing—you have more control over their portion than you might think.

## THE SOCIAL RESPONSIBILITY CHOICE

Even if your wealth goes only to your children, this conversation can prompt you to discuss what’s important and communicate your values. Many people die, and if you ask their kids, “What were Dad’s core values?” They’ll say something like, “The Dallas Cowboys, Miller Lite, and fishing.”

But there’s something else to consider. There are only two types of people in the world: Those that outlive their money and those whose money outlives them. If you’re reading this book, you’ll likely be in the second group. For those of us in the second group, we have an obligation to help those who are in the first group. For all of those who have been blessed with financial security, there is an obligation to others in our society. It is a moral contract and a social obligation.

Now, if you’re reading that and you don’t agree, it doesn’t matter, because that is what the tax law says! When you sell appreciated assets, you owe capital gains taxes. There are assets like tax-deferred retirement accounts that, when you die, trigger taxes that someone has to pay. That tax obligation is our social responsibility.

When those taxes or social responsibility payments are collected, the government allocates your money to the causes, programs, and people they deem worthy. That may be fine with you. You may be happy with how your social responsibility is spent. If you are, you'd be the first person I've met that felt that way! Most people want their social responsibility dollars to be allocated with good stewardship and to causes that they care about.

So why not direct the social responsibility yourself? Why not direct those dollars that you can't spend, use to pay down debt, invest, or keep, to causes you care about? You can do that. But before you do, you must *Decide Who Matters*. You should be directing your social responsibility dollars to people and organizations you care about in the most tax-efficient manner. For the time being, you are the steward of the wealth you call yours. You have an obligation to minimize the tax depletion so that the wealth is directed toward those who matter to you.

Sometimes that means directing taxable dollars, like retirement accounts, to charitable organizations as beneficiaries. Sometimes it means gifting highly appreciated assets to charitable organizations or trusts. Sometimes, it can mean giving an organization money for it to purchase life insurance on your life with that organization as the beneficiary. The list goes on and on, but these are dollars you can't keep. They will go to social causes in the form of taxes, and when they do, you no longer have any say in how the money is directed. If you plant nothing, you get weeds.

Decide to direct your social responsibility to the causes most meaningful to you and your family. But first you must *Decide Who Matters* to you. Decide who shares your values from the first Key Decision or decide who should benefit from the outlet for those values.

## LEARNING FROM MY FATHER'S WISDOM

As I've worked alongside my dad and now carry on his work, I understand what he meant when he talked about deciding *who* matters. He views the wealth we steward not as ours, but as resources temporarily in our care—resources that carry a responsibility to use and pass on. When you think of it that way, the job gets bigger. It is no longer about having the money to help you accomplish your aspirational goals, but about being a good steward of that wealth. It becomes your responsibility to understand your values and to put that wealth to use for a greater purpose. To be good stewards of money that outlives us, we must have a plan that outlives us.

Everyone has an estate plan. Is it the one that you put together? Or, is it the one the state puts together for you? So many families we meet have no long-term plan for their wealth. Most have no plan at all. Not only do they lack an estate plan, they don't even have updated beneficiaries on their accounts. I can't tell you how many times I have looked at someone's beneficiary statements only to feel like I am watching the movie *The Sixth Sense*: "I see dead people," I'll tell them as I point to beneficiaries who have already passed away.

But having an estate plan and updated beneficiary statements on retirement accounts and life insurance is only the start. Becoming Decidedly Wealthy means deciding who matters and building out a plan to transfer that wealth to them alongside the values and principles that are important to you.

If you made the first Key Decision (*Decide Who You Are*), you've identified your values, what's important about your money, and what you want it to do. Reflect on that for a moment and then ask yourself, "What do I want my money to do when I am done with it?"

## Did You Leave a Trace?

When we are done with our money, it will still exist. It will still be here, and it will either go back to the government, our heirs, or charitable organizations, and one of those three will put it to use. They will put it to use towards the things they value, and towards what they want it to do for them. But it doesn't have to be that way.

You can decide to leave a trace. You can decide what that trace will look like. You can *Decide Who Matters* and create a plan that ensures your wealth continues working for what you care about long after you're done hiking this trail.

The question is: Will you leave no trace where weeds will sprout, will you leave an ugly blemish, or will you create something beautiful that lasts? The choice is yours to make.

Just as hikers carefully consider every mark they make on the trail, we must consider every mark our wealth will leave on the world. The trail continues long after we've finished our hike. The question is: What will future hikers find when they reach the spot where we once stood?

## ACTION STEPS

**Step 1:** Determine your long-term vision for your wealth.

**Step 2:** Check the path you're on to determine if it will guide your wealth there.

**Step 3:** Decide to leave a trace in the form of a legacy plan.

## CHAPTER 16

# What Is Your Legacy?

On January 12, 2010, a massive magnitude 7.0 earthquake struck near Port-au-Prince, Haiti. When it was over, the earthquake had created over \$8 billion in property damage and left 1.5 million homeless. Over 300,000 people lost their lives.<sup>7</sup>

One of those who lost their lives was Brendan Beck.

Brendan was trapped in the Hotel Montana when it collapsed. He had arrived in Haiti just hours earlier as a USAID consultant working on sustainable infrastructure for eco-tourism—work designed to provide long-term benefit to the Haitian economy. He was thirty-seven years old, a University of Florida graduate with a degree in civil engineering, and he was where he wanted to be.

Sally Baldwin was his mother, and she was also a client of my father's. I remember because I was working in the office. I watched as she walked to his office with such a purpose I could tell they were talking about something impactful. When Sally came to see my dad after the earthquake, she was devastated but also at peace about one thing. She kept saying, "At least he died doing what he loved. He died doing something that mattered to him."

---

<sup>7</sup> Richard Pallardy, "2010 Haiti Earthquake," Encyclopedia Britannica, last updated July 28, 2025, <https://www.britannica.com/event/2010-Haiti-earthquake>.

Brendan had been preparing to return to the University of Florida to pursue an advanced engineering degree. In his graduate application—which Sally found after his death—Brendan had written: “Throughout the United States and the world, there are aging infrastructure systems that need repair and replacement. A thorough comprehension of the interrelation of infrastructure and environment can pay dividends in this field by minimizing costs, increasing lifecycle and decreasing environmental impacts.”<sup>8</sup>

He felt that the University of Florida faculty had expertise in diverse fields that he wanted to draw from in his studies. He wanted to make the infrastructure sustainable. He wanted his work to matter for generations.

Brendan wasn’t planning on leaving a legacy right then. He was just living his purpose. But a legacy is what he left behind.

Sally and my dad sat together weeks after the earthquake, working through the impossible task of settling Brendan’s affairs. His money had come to her. She could have absorbed it into her own retirement accounts, used it for travel, spent it however she wished. But as they talked, Sally kept returning to Brendan’s own words from that graduate application.

“What if other people could pursue the same knowledge?” she had asked. “What if Brendan’s death could help others do what he wanted to do?”

That conversation led to the creation of the Brendan S. Beck Fund for Sustainable Infrastructure at the University of Florida. The fund provides opportunities for others to pursue the knowledge and research Brendan valued. Students who might never have

---

<sup>8</sup> “Brennan S. Beck P.E. Fund for Sustainability.” University of Florida Foundation. Accessed August 27, 2025. <https://www.uff.ufl.edu/giving-opportunities/018077-brendan-s-beck-p-e-fund-for-sustainability/>.

had the chance to study the intersection of infrastructure and environment now can, because Sally transformed her grief into purpose.

Brendan didn't get to choose his legacy. But Sally honored what mattered to him. She made sure his values—not just his money—lived on.

Some people don't get the time to *Decide Who Matters*. For those that have the opportunity, and if you're reading this book, you have that opportunity. *Decide Who Matters*. Then, decide to do something about it.

## LIVING INTENTIONALLY

Not all legacies are born from tragedy. Sometimes they emerge from a simple question at the right moment.

A few years ago, I met Susan. Susan had been a high school teacher for thirty-five years and was now retired. Her husband had passed away three years earlier, and our discussions seemed to gravitate toward her beneficiary designations often. The forms felt cold, impersonal—just names and percentages on paper. But I knew there was something deeper she wanted to express.

I started by asking what led her to teaching and about how she became a teacher. We talked about her classes and students, the ones who still sent her Christmas cards twenty years later. But as we talked, our discussion turned to the difficulties she had getting into college and paying for school.

"I wasn't exceptional," Susan told me. She hadn't been a star athlete who could earn an athletic scholarship, nor an outstanding academic who would earn a scholastic free ride. Her family wasn't struggling enough to earn financial aid, nor wealthy enough to pay

for college either. She was just a girl from a middle-income family who wanted to teach kids, like the teachers who had been such an important part of her life.

She talked about how she had worked to earn the money for school and how it set her family back to cover the rest of the costs. She paused for a moment and asked hesitantly if she could set up a scholarship in her estate, for “girls like her.”

“What do you mean?” I asked her.

“So many kids have a financial leg up when they go to college, but no one seems to care about the ones in my situation.”

“Your situation?”

“There aren’t scholarships for kids with average grades, from average-income families, who just want to teach. Can we set up a scholarship for students who want to get a degree in education that may not qualify for other aid? Do I have enough to do that? I want to help those who fall through the cracks and don’t get support from other means.”

We worked through her estate plan. I explained that leaving retirement accounts to a foundation for scholarships would avoid taxes, unlike leaving them to her children, who would lose 40 percent to taxation. She loved the idea, so we built out the plan. We set up a special fund to receive the proceeds of her retirement accounts at death and pass them along as scholarships. We updated beneficiary forms on her accounts and even wrote out a letter to advise the controllers of the scholarship fund how to award scholarships after her passing.

“What if we bought life insurance for the kids? When you pass, the retirement account funds your foundation, and the policy pays them tax-free,” I proposed.

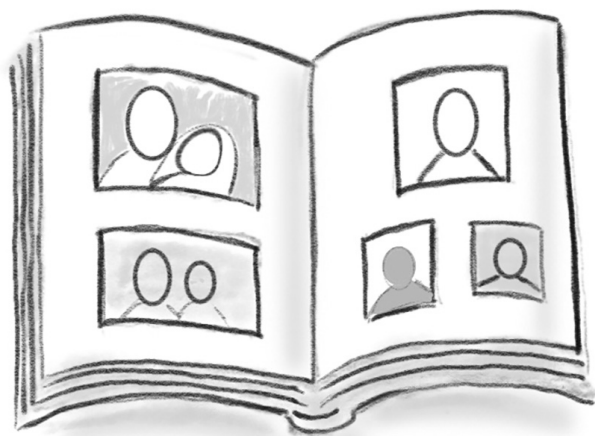
She liked the idea. But then she said something that made me realize she had already decided: “Why do I have to wait until I die to get this scholarship started?”

“You don’t!” I replied.

Starting right then, she worked on establishing a scholarship fund. Not someday—now.

A few years after she set it up, she sent me a picture. It was her and a young man who had gotten a scholarship from the foundation she’d established. The first scholarship recipient was not the “average girl” she’d originally envisioned, but a young man from a middle-income family who wanted to teach high school history.

The joy in that photo was unmistakable. Not only was she getting joy from money that otherwise would just be sitting in an account not doing anything, waiting to pass through an estate settlement process. But the joy that she got in sending me that picture—she had experienced deep joy. She had transformed her wealth into significance.



Susan had decided. She had acted on that decision, and once she worked through the first four Key Decisions, she had moved to the fifth key decision and decided who mattered. Those students mattered, and to them she mattered a great deal.

## THE BREADTH OF LEGACY

What struck me over the years wasn't the size of my clients' gifts—though some were substantial—but the personal nature of each one. My father and I have worked with clients who discovered their own unique legacies, each one as individual as the person creating it.

There's a client who established a scholarship for kids from the elementary school where she taught. Another created a scholarship for young women who wanted to go into nursing. We have scholarships set up for people who want to foster dogs. These are endowments that are funding annual gifting in line with what people cared about.

Each of these people answered the same question differently: What do I want my money to be doing in a hundred years? Not who gets it—but what work will it perform? What values will it perpetuate?

If someone said, "I want a \$10,000 annual scholarship for women in nursing or teaching," we could create a perpetual fund honoring their values forever.

There's no right legacy. There's only your legacy. The legacy that aligns with who you are and what matters to you.

## WHEN LEGACY HAPPENS BY ACCIDENT

Not everyone gets to be intentional about their legacy. Without a plan, others decide for you—the state, the IRS collecting first, family members fighting over what’s left. Your values? Your wishes? Your hopes for what your wealth could accomplish? None of that matters once you’re gone—unless you made it matter while you were here.

Most people spend more time planning vacations than planning their legacy. Hotels get researched. Restaurants get reviewed. Every day of a two-week trip gets mapped out. But eternal impact of life’s work? Values to pass on? Causes to support? Family harmony

---

Most people spend more time planning  
vacations than planning their legacy.

---

to preserve? Those receive maybe an hour of thought, prompted by a lawyer needing beneficiary forms filled out.

Legacy isn’t about death. It’s about purpose. It’s about taking everything you’ve learned, everything you’ve earned, everything you value, and ensuring it continues to work in the world after you’re gone. But here’s the secret—the sooner you live your legacy, the more joy you’ll find in wealth. Because wealth without purpose is just numbers. Wealth with purpose? That’s significant.

## ACTION STEPS

### **Step 1: Define the What**

Complete this sentence with an action phrase. “When I am done with it, I want my money to be [action phrase].”

### **Step 2: Define the Who**

Decide who will be receiving the outlet for step one.

### **Step 3: Decide on the When**

Will this happen now or at your passing?

### **Step 4: Check Your Alignment**

Does this plan create an effective outlet for your values and reflect who you are?

## CHAPTER 17

# Passing Down More Than Wealth

It may seem harsh to say, but you must *Decide Who Matters*. I'm not saying that some people don't matter or that they have no value. Of course, every person matters. I use that language because it is important to be intentional in who is impacting your decision making and who you are deciding to impact.

Things you observe influence you. That influence impacts your decisions. In deciding who matters, you are being conscious of who influences you but are also being intentional as to whom you will influence. It works both ways. If we admit to ourselves that the things we observe influence us, then we also admit that the things we do are observable by others and influence them.

How we direct our wealth impacts others as well. The decisions we make have meaning because there are only a few choices we have with our wealth. In no particular order, we can save or invest it, pay a down debt with it, pay taxes with it, spend it, or give it away. That's it.

No matter how much wealth we have, it is still finite for each of us. That means the decisions we make about our wealth are important. If we make poor decisions with our spending, we have

fewer dollars to apply towards reaching our primary goal. If we are not intentional with our tax planning, we have fewer dollars to give to causes that are meaningful to us. If we make poor investment decisions, we could have fewer dollars not only for our primary goal but for charitable giving as well. They are all interrelated.

## WHEN VALUES DON'T TRANSFER

Let me tell you about my grandfather—my mother's father. It's a story that haunts me to this day. When he died, I went to his widow's house. She gave me a Remington 25-06 hunting rifle that came in an old-school leather case, brown and mustard colored.

Seven months later, during deer season, I was walking through a field in the morning dark—you have to get up before the sun to hunt deer. I thought something was on fire. I could smell smoke but couldn't see any flames. Then I realized it was the leather strap of the rifle case. It still smelled of my grandfather's cigarettes.

"I'm not gonna sneak up on a twelve-point buck smelling like Marlboro Smooths," I thought. So I drove to the cemetery where he was buried, in Hico, Texas, near the land where I was hunting. On the way, I listened to Willie Nelson's "Uncloudy Day"—my grandfather had insisted on Willie Nelson being played at his funeral. I don't smoke, but I even picked up a pack of Marlboros at the gas station.

When I got to the cemetery, there was just a smooth pile of dirt. Not even a headstone. I called my mother early that morning. "Why doesn't my grandpa have a headstone?"

She said something I'll never forget: "Well, I paid for the funeral. Somebody else can pay for the headstone."

It turned out my grandfather, who went to TCU and was a Marine, died without a will. In the state of Texas, when you die without a will, half of everything goes to your current spouse, and the other half goes to the children from your first marriage. My mother and her sister inherited half of the house his widow was living in—which was the only thing he had.

My mother was generous enough to give her share of the house to his widow. But she didn't have to. The things I got were that gun and a red plaid pearl snap shirt that's too small for me. My mother doesn't even have that much—no shirt, no hat, no gun. Just part of a house she didn't want, which she gave away to my granddad's widow.

---

You're going to leave a trace whether  
you like it or not. Better to decide what  
it's going to be.

---

He had an opportunity, at the very least, to avoid conflict at his passing. My grandfather left a trace, but not the one he would have chosen. He left an absence of thoughtful planning. His estate got divided in a way he didn't want, and it was disruptive for his family.

You're going to leave a trace whether you like it or not. Better to decide what it's going to be.

## A SIMPLE BUT POWERFUL VALUE TRANSFER

Not all value transfers require wealth. Alejandro's parents were immigrants from Spain. Family was super important to them, and every Friday, they would have burgers together. Now his parents have passed away, but the family still meets every Friday for burgers.

They were very intentional about it, and the family continues doing it to this day. That's passing down values. It doesn't require an estate plan or a trust fund. It requires intentionality and consistency. It requires deciding what matters and then living it out so those who come after you can't imagine things any other way.

## CHOOSING YOUR OWN LEGACY

My grandmother provides a perfect example of how personal a legacy can be. She had set up her estate to benefit a specific charity—until the charity treated her poorly. They were demanding. They were not transparent. So, she wrote them out and created a fund that would benefit the Texas Christian University track team instead.

Growing up, my grandmother and I would go to TCU track meets. We'd be the only white folks there except for the 5,000-meter runners' parents. She stood out even more because of her beautiful white hair. But she was such a supporter that the runners knew her—including several who became Olympians like Darvis Patton and Kim Collins.

I watch the track world championships now because my grandmother did. Sometimes the values can be "track is cool." It doesn't have to be the most important life lesson ever.

When she passes, I'll call TCU about the substantial gift from my grandmother—a longtime employee, alum, neighbor, and devoted season ticket holder.

I will be very honored to make that call. I get to share that with her.

## WHEN GRIEF BECOMES PURPOSE

Ron and Sheri became my father's clients after their son Kyle died. Kyle had been older than me at the same school. My dad made small talk about football and teachers, then asked what he always asked first: What did they hope he could do for them?

Like many couples, they just wanted to get organized and pull things together in a cohesive plan. They wanted to feel more in control. It was natural that they felt out of control. Their world was upended when Kyle passed away while in high school. Nothing was as they had planned. There was money set aside for college that was now going to be unused. There were life insurance policies with Kyle as beneficiary that now seemed pointless, but it was still painful to cancel them.

"You've said getting all this under control is important to you. This may seem silly, but what's important about getting it all under control?" my dad asked. He was helping them with the first Key Decision.

"The last year has been a whirlwind, and I just want to get back in control," Sheri said. "We both do," Ron agreed.

"I just want to get in control so I can feel like, I guess... does peaceful make sense?" Sheri said, working out her thoughts aloud.

“Feeling peaceful makes sense. Is there anything more important than that?” my dad asked, not minimizing what they had just said, but digging to see if there was more.

“Just more of a peace of mind knowing that we are fine financially, but that we know we are doing the right thing. Not just for us, but for Kyle.” Sheri was figuring it out and processing it all as they talked.

“What would the right thing be? What’s important about feeling like you’re doing the right thing?” my dad asked, throwing two questions at them at once.

“You know, it just seems like we have all of this money we saved for Kyle, and now... I don’t know...” Sheri trailed off as Ron glanced at her and nodded.

“I think what we are both saying is we want to do something with the money we set aside for Kyle,” Ron summarized.

My dad guided Ron and Sheri through the first Key Decision: deciding who they were. The answer: people committed to making a difference. Understanding what mattered and what the money should accomplish led to clarity—peace, purpose, and doing good.

A second meeting the following week tackled *Decide Where You Are*. Wealth allocation between primary and aspirational goals took shape. Point A emerged. The next Key Decision (*Decide Where You Are Going*) established Point B.

Ron was ready to leave his job. He was ready to reconnect with Sheri and spend time with the family he was realizing he hadn’t spent enough time with over the previous decades. Their Point B involved setting up a scholarship fund for the golf team at Kyle’s former school and an annual golf tournament to raise additional funds for scholarships in Kyle’s name. Their Point B involved a core

feeling of peace, knowing they had done something good. Knowing that Kyle's name would live on in an endowed scholarship at the school he loved.

Ron and Sheri moved to the fourth key decision, *Decide How You Are Going to Get There*, and changed the secondary beneficiaries on their retirement accounts after both passed. They funded the scholarships with appreciated stock to avoid capital gains. They updated the beneficiary designations on their life insurance policies and named Kyle's cousins. By the time they had done this work, the fifth key decision, *Decide Who Matters*, was obvious. Kyle's legacy mattered. The students at the school mattered. But most importantly, Ron and Sheri mattered for being purposeful with their wealth.

## THE PRACTICAL HOW-TO OF VALUES TRANSFER

One of the last steps in this process is to discuss your plans with your family. You can use actual numbers or projected ones, but I always suggest making this part of the process. I don't want families learning for the first time at their parents funeral that substantial wealth is funding a charity their parents never mentioned.

If you're leaving everything to your kids and nothing to charity (or the other way around), let this conversation inspire you to share your values and priorities with them.

## LEARNING FROM MY FATHER'S WISDOM

As I've worked alongside my dad and now carry on his work, I understand what he means when he talks about *Deciding Who Matters*. He views the wealth we steward not as ours, but as resources temporarily in our care—resources that carry a responsibility to use and pass on purposefully.

When you think of it that way, the job gets bigger. It is no longer just about having the money to help you accomplish your aspirational goals, but about being a good steward of that wealth. It becomes your responsibility to understand your values and to put that wealth to use for a greater purpose. To be good stewards of money that outlives us, we must have a plan that outlives us.

But having an estate plan and updated beneficiary statements on retirement accounts and life insurance is only the start. Becoming Decidedly Wealthy means deciding who matters and building out a plan to transfer that wealth to them alongside the values and principles that are important to you. Our lives are impacted by the people we meet, the books we read, and the struggles we face along the trail. Who we travel with matters.

## ACTION STEPS

### **Step 1: Determine the Recipients**

Determine who will receive the gift of the outflow of your values. If you are married, do this with your spouse.

### **Step 2: Determine Your Guide**

Determine the trusted and knowledgeable guides that will create the plan to get you where you want to go. These are your professionals like CPAs, attorneys, and financial advisors.

### **Step 3: Determine Your Travel Companions**

Create a small personal board of directors or forum where you can share your struggles and victories along the way. These can be small business groups or church organizations.



# Conclusion

## Day 7. Morning.

The morning was cool and clear. We'd reached the end of our time together on the trail, though my father's journey would continue for another nine-hundred miles north. I stood at the road crossing, pack loaded, waiting for a local trail angel to drive me to the San Diego airport.

My dad adjusted his pack straps one final time, checking his water bottles, making sure everything was secure for the day ahead. He'd walk twenty miles today, alone, just as he'd planned. The solitude he'd sought was beginning.

"You good?" he asked, though we both knew he was asking something deeper. He was asking if I listened and learned.

"Yeah," I said.

Over seven days and 109 miles, he'd transferred more than knowledge. He'd shown me how wisdom moves from one generation to the next—not through lectures or lessons, but through shared experience and patient guidance. Every blister, every sunrise, every story along the trail had been told to illustrate what couldn't be taught in an office or explained in a meeting.

The Five Key Decisions weren't just a framework for financial planning. They were a philosophy for living with intention. *Decide Who You Are*—know your values and what matters. *Decide Where You Are*—assess your starting point. *Decide Where You Are Going*—set a

destination that aligns with who you are. *Decide How You Are Going to Get There*—choose your path wisely. *Decide Who Matters*—choose your guides and create a legacy that outlasts you.

I thought about all the people we'd talked about during our hike. Ghost, who found significance in driving hikers to town. Don and Nancy discovered joy in bringing their family together. Susan started living her legacy while she could still see its impact. My grandfather, who'd left no trace because he never decided what trace to leave.

"The trail continues," my father said, gesturing north toward the mountains that would be his companions for the next two months.

He was right. His trail led north toward Canada, toward more weeks of solitude and reflection. My trail led home, back to Fort Worth, back to the business I'd just purchased, back to clients who needed guidance on their own journeys toward significance.

We hugged, which made it emotional. I was choked up, the week having meant more than I expected, and now it was over. I could feel my eyes beginning to tear, and I suspected his were too, though we both looked away, neither wanting the other to see. When we let go, he turned and walked north, his pace steady and purposeful. I watched until he disappeared around a bend—the trail taking him toward whatever transformation awaited.

A couple of hours later, the trail angel arrived. "Ready?" he asked.

I climbed into the passenger seat and looked back one more time at the trail. I was ready. Ready to help others make their Five Key Decisions. Ready to guide them in transforming wealth to significance. Ready to leave my trace.

The trail, as my father said, continues. And so does yours.

# About the Authors



**Sanger Smith:** After spending ten years at his father's firm and then taking over as owner for another four years, private wealth advisor Sanger D. Smith, BFA™, APMA®, CEPA™ founded Decidedly Wealth in 2022, a boutique advisory firm focused on serving family business owners/operators looking to transition to the next phase of their personal and business lives. He has a passion for great decision-making, behavioral psychology, doing hard things, eating chocolate mousse, and collecting supplements.

**Shawn Smith:** Shawn D. Smith, CFP®, ChFC® is a bestselling author and business coach who has advised families since 1989. Recognized by Barron's, Financial Times, Forbes, and Texas Monthly, he's known for helping people align money with purpose and build calm,

durable wealth. Shawn wrote the book *Plateau Jumping*, co-created the Decidedly Wealthy framework, and co-hosted the Decidedly podcast for four years. If you can't find him, he's on a hiking trail somewhere in the world, coaching business owners, or bragging about his wonderful grandchildren.